

CM lays foundation for 53 projects worth ₹214 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta laid foundation stones for 53 development projects worth ₹214.12 crore in unauthorised colonies across Kirari, Bawana, Mundka, Narela and Nangloi Jat Assembly constituencies on Sunday. The projects are under the Seva Sankalp campaign, aimed at strengthening civic amenities for around 1.75 lakh residents.

The Chief Minister said the Delhi government's objective is to strengthen basic civic amenities across the city, with development works now being undertaken in a planned manner in areas that have long faced infrastructure problems. She

said roads, drains, sewerage and drainage are basic rights of every citizen, and the Government is ensuring development reaches every lane and area of Delhi.

Under the 53 projects, 1,062 roads and lanes in 27 unauthorised colonies will be developed, along with around 89.82 km of road network and 147.69 km of drainage network, to improve local connectivity and reduce waterlogging.

North West Delhi MP Yogendra Chandolia, Cabinet Ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh, Ashish Sood and Ravindra Indraj Singh, and MLAs Raj Karan, Manoj Shokeen and Gajendra Daral attended the event.

Kirari Assembly constituency accounts for the largest



share of the projects, with 27 development works to be undertaken in 14 unauthorised colonies at a cost of ₹105.51 crore, including development of 640 roads and lanes, 50.71 km of roads and

101.42 km of drainage network. Bawana will see nine works worth ₹38.83 crore, Mundka five works worth ₹22.05 crore, Narela four works worth ₹14.48 crore, and Nangloi Jat eight works

worth ₹33.25 crore. The stormwater drainage networks planned across these areas are expected to improve drainage and reduce waterlogging, while paved roads and lanes will improve connectivity and reduce dust from damaged surfaces.

The Chief Minister said development work has gained new momentum following the change in government in Delhi after 27 years, with the Government focusing on permanent solutions to long-pending problems rather than merely making announcements. She said the government is working to fulfil basic needs across every lane, area and Assembly constituency, moving toward Prime Minister Narendra Modi's resolve for a "Viksit Delhi," with emphasis

on time-bound implementation on the ground.

PWD and Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the Government is committed to ensuring development reaches every lane and household in unauthorised colonies, not just main roads, describing the 53 projects as an important step toward resolving long-pending basic problems by strengthening road, sewerage and drainage infrastructure.

Social Welfare Minister Ravindra Indraj Singh said adequate attention was not paid to development in the Kirari area during the previous Government's tenure, despite the Aam Aadmi Party remaining in power for a long period and continuing to hold the constituency's MLA seat.

Slap row: AAP seeks FIR against Parvesh Verma



AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj argues with a police official during a protest march with supporters towards the DCP office on Sunday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Sunday held a protest in west Delhi's Tilak Nagar area, demanding registration of an FIR against Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh over an alleged slapping incident.

AAP Delhi unit chief Saurabh Bharadwaj was detained by Delhi Police during the protest.

"We are going to the DCP office because the FIR has not been registered yet. When everything happened in front of the SHO and everything is on video, why has the FIR not been registered? This is complete collusion by the police. This hooliganism will not be tolerated," Bharadwaj told reporters.

Scores of AAP workers, along with local MLA Jarnail Singh, raised slogans demanding the resignation

of the PWD minister and registration of an FIR against him.

"To maintain law and order, some people have been detained and were removed to Jaffarpur Kalan Police Station," a police source said.

A political row erupted in Delhi on Sunday after a video surfaced on social media purportedly showing Parvesh Sahib Singh slapping a man who was recording a road inspection in west Delhi's Tilak Nagar.

The incident, captured in a video shared by Jarnail Singh on social media, took place when the minister was inspecting a newly laid road in the area. The MLA questioned the quality of the work and pulled out portions of the road surface by hand. A man standing nearby and recording the proceedings was then allegedly slapped by the minister.

NO CHANGE IN DDA PARK TIMINGS, SAYS AUTHORITY

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Sunday clarified that the timings of DDA parks have not changed.

Visitors may continue to use the parks during the previously applicable hours.

The advisory asking visitors to avoid isolated or poorly lit areas after sunset is a precautionary safety measure. It does not change park timings or restrict access during permitted hours.



DDA has strengthened security arrangements in its parks. Security deployment and patrolling have been intensified, and CCTV surveillance at entry and exit points is being strengthened.

Visitors are requested to promptly report any suspicious activity to park security or the police. DDA remains committed to keeping its parks safe and accessible to all.



Around 10,000 people visited during the two days of the 'Rang Ras Rooh' festival organised by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) at Baansera to mark World Tourism Day

CM Rekha unveils Bhagat Singh statues, renames RCS office

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's RCS Office Complex on Parliament Street will now be known as "Shaheed-e-Azam Bhagat Singh Sangharsh Shali," as Chief Minister Rekha Gupta unveiled statues of Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev during the "Chalo Bhagat Singh Ke Saath" walkathon organised on the revolutionary's birth anniversary.

Thousands of youth, volunteers, Delhi Government employees and citizens participated in the walkathon from Parliament Street to Kartavya Path, carrying the

Tricolour and raising slogans of "Vande Mataram" and "Bharat Mata Ki Jai."

The Chief Minister also visited the historic courtroom located within the RCS Office Complex. Cooperation and Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh attended as guest of honour.

The Chief Minister greeted the participating youth, praising their enthusiasm for the journey dedicated to Bhagat Singh.

Singh said the complex is not merely a Government office but a historical site associated with Bhagat Singh's life and struggle. He said that following his arrest



after the Assembly bombing, Bhagat Singh was brought from the then Parliament Street Police Station to the courtroom within this complex, where his case proceedings were conducted. After taking charge of the

Cooperation Department, Singh said he collected historical documents confirming these facts and raised the issue of preserving the site with Chief Minister and Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

"It is a matter of great

pride that the place which was known as the RCS Office will now be known as 'Shaheed-e-Azam Bhagat Singh Sangharsh Shali'. This is a true tribute by the Delhi Government to the great revolutionaries of our nation," Singh said.

The walkathon passed through Vitthal Bhai Patel House, Mavalankar Auditorium, Shram Shakti Bhawan, Rafi Marg and Krishi Bhawan before culminating at Kartavya Path, where patriotic songs, cultural performances and a light and sound show depicting Bhagat Singh's life were presented.

MCD clears 75% rebate on regularisation charges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has approved a proposal to provide a rebate of up to 75 per cent on charges for regularising constructed areas of houses in unauthorised colonies covered under the PM-UDAY scheme, officials said on Sunday.

The rebate, approved by Standing Committee chairperson Satya Sharma, will be available to applicants who complete the regularisation process by October 31, 2026. It will also apply during any extended period if the gov-



ernment extends the deadline, Sharma said.

The move aims to make regularisation more affordable for residents of unauthorised colonies, she said, adding that the PM-UDAY scheme seeks to provide

property rights to eligible residents.

The MCD levies four types of charges for regularisation: Compensatory Regulatory Charge, C&D Charge, Development Charge, and Admin/IT

Charge. The corporation has approved an additional rebate of up to 75 per cent on these charges, Sharma said.

According to an official statement, several charges under the Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL), 2016, for regularising construction existing up to April 6, 2026, in PM-UDAY colonies were waived from August 20.

These include permit fee, betterment charge, levy, additional levy, plinth fee, pre-occupancy charge and charges related to construction without approval. Labour cess is also not included in the MCD's regularisation charges.

Three rescued after fire in Mandoli godown

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Police said three family members were rescued after a fire broke out at a godown storing cloth and foam in a two-storey building in north-east Delhi's Mandoli area on Sunday. They said two fire incidents were reported from the godown located in D Block, Harsh Vihar, and police teams rushed to the spot.

Four fire tenders, two ambulances and four Delhi Disaster Management Authority personnel reached the spot. The fire was doused, and a thorough search of the building was conducted,

but no person was found injured or trapped inside, police said. "At the time of the incident, the ground floor was locked. Three members of the building owner's family were safely evacuated," a senior police officer said.

The building owner had rented the ground floor to Himanshu, a resident of Sunder Nagri, who was using it to store cloth and foam used to manufacture weightlifting belts, police said. During a preliminary inquiry, a fire brigade officer assessed that the probable cause of the fire was a short circuit. Further inquiry into the incident is underway.



Fire personnel at work after fire broke out at a godown at Mandoli area on Sunday

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Sunita Tirkey, W/o Mr. John Dung Dung, R/o A-62, Sector-17A, Noida, Dist. G. B. Nagar, U.P., hereby declare that my name was inadvertently recorded as "Sunita" in my son's school records. My correct name is "Sunita Tirkey". Henceforth, I shall be known and recorded as Sunita Tirkey in all school records documents. In future purpose.

NAME CHANGE
It is for general information that I, SHOBHA SAH D/o MOHAN SAH, R/o HOUSE NO. C-408, GALI NO. 4, MASTER PARK, NEAR JAGDAMBA BUILDERS, SHANI SHANIBAZAR, KHORA, GHAZIABAD, UTTAR PRADESH-201309, declare that name of mine, my father name and my mother name have been wrongly written as SHOBHA GUPTA, MOHAN GUPTA and POONAM GUPTA in my 10th and 12th educational documents. The actual name of mine, my father and my mother are SHOBHA SAH, MOHAN SAH and POONAM SAH, respectively, which may be amended accordingly.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. ICICI Bank Ltd. that Mrs. Lata Malhotra daughter of Mrs. Anu Malhotra is owner of Flat/Dwelling No. B2/421, on 4th Floor, Block/Tower-16, area measuring 1265 Sq. Ft. in Punvanchal Silver City-II, Plot No.10, Estate Chandra, Sector-Ph-II, Greater Noida, U.P., vide a Gift deed dt. 18.06.2026, registration No. 25666, executed by Mrs. Anu Malhotra after demise of her parents Mrs. Jeevan Kapoor & Mr. Prem Shankar Kapoor. All Persons are hereby informed that above owners want to sale the said property to someone of their nominee who is taking a loan facility from our client for purchase the said property. If any body including other surviving members of Mrs. Jeevan Kapoor & Mr. Prem Shankar Kapoor having any objection upon the ownership of above owners sale the mortgage & any other kind of objection/litigation, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 10 days of the present. **Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)** 208, 2nd Flr., 23, Shivaji Marg, Mayapuri, New Delhi-110028. Phone: 011-21112527-28. legal@kumaradv.com

2,809 complaints addressed during Thana Divas-Jansunwai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Police resolved 2,809 complaints during its weekly "Thana Divas-Jansunwai" public hearing programme held on Sunday at police stations across all 15 police districts of the Capital.

Senior police officers, from the rank of Special CP to ACP, attended the sessions at various police stations. Their presence gave citizens the opportunity to raise concerns directly with senior officers, helping ensure matters were addressed at the appropriate level. The sessions also allowed citizens to share suggestions and concerns regarding various day-to-day issues.

The "Thana Divas-Jansunwai" initiative was launched in June 2026, following directions from Lieutenant



Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu. It is being implemented under the leadership of Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, with the objective of providing citizens a direct and accessible platform for grievance redressal.

As part of the initiative, police stations organise public hearing sessions every Saturday from 10 am to 2 pm, enabling citizens to approach police with complaints, grievances, and suggestions.

Two sisters held for robbing delivery executive in Rohini

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two sisters were arrested for allegedly robbing a delivery executive of parcels by throwing chilli powder in his eyes in Rohini, police said on Sunday. The accused, Nancy Singh, 26, and Gracy Singh, 20, both residents of Karol Bagh, were arrested on Saturday, and three stolen parcels were recovered from them, police said.

Around 7.30 pm on September 25, one of the accused women, posing as a customer, allegedly approached the delivery executive near Sector 5,

Rohini, a police officer said. "The woman attempted to forcibly take the parcels from his delivery bag and threw chilli powder in his eyes when he resisted," he said.

According to the officer, the second accused arrived on a scooter and allegedly hit the delivery executive from behind. He fell and sustained a leg injury. The accused sisters fled with several parcels.

A case was registered at the Budh Vihar police station in the matter. Nancy has completed a fashion design course but is unemployed, and Gracy is a Class 12 dropout, police said.



Parvesh Verma slaps man during road inspection in Tilak Nagar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A political row erupted in Delhi on Sunday after Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma was caught on camera slapping a young man during a road inspection in west Delhi's Tilak Nagar, with the incident triggering an FIR, a war of narratives between the BJP and AAP, and demands from the opposition for the minister's arrest.

Verma, however, alleged that the man had abused his family members. He also accused Jarnail Singh of seeking a commission in the road repair work and said that an FIR would be registered in this regard. "When his (AAP MLA's) worker abused my family, I did what any person would do after getting angry," the minister said in a video message posted by the Delhi BJP on X.

The confrontation unfolded during Verma's inspection of a road in the Tilak Nagar

Assembly constituency, where AAP MLA Jarnail Singh joined him. The two clashed over the quality of ongoing road construction on the Vikaspuri Ring Road, and the exchange escalated into a public altercation caught on video.

Footage of the incident shows Jarnail Singh pulling at the newly paved road surface, lifting chunks of it with apparent ease, and challenging Verma over the work's quality. "Ye lo, mantri ji aap humse poocho, bura manne ki baat nahi hai isme. Ye BJP ki Sarkar mein ho raha hai kaam. Hamari video delete karwa rahe ho," Singh said, holding up pieces of the road, before adding, "Aapne jo sadak boli woh ukhad ke dikha di, ab batao."

Verma, who had his arm around Singh at the time, responded, "Galat nahi bolna." When the MLA asked what he had said wrong, Verma replied, "Bilkul galat bola. Aapne 15 saal mein sadak nahi banayi, ab hum



bana rahe hain." Singh shot back, "Aise mat banao na, ye toh 15 ghante nahi chalegi." Verma then turned to walk away. As Singh followed, holding pieces of the road, his personal assistant, identified as Sahib Singh, continued recording the exchange on his phone. The video shows Verma turning toward Singh's aide, pulling down his phone with one hand and slapping him with the other. Voices in the crowd can be heard reacting,

with one saying, "Oye maar kaise raha hai," and another remarking, "Aam aadmi ko koi thappad nahi maar sakta." Saheb Singh said he was live-streaming the conversation between Jarnail Singh and Verma on the MLA's page when the minister intervened. "At that time, I was live-streaming on the MLA's page. To stop the ongoing live stream, Parvesh Verma snatched the phone from my hand, raised his hand at me

and slapped me," Singh said, alleging that security personnel accompanying the minister also pushed and threatened him. He said he had filed a police complaint and provided the names of those involved, adding, "The rest depends on what action the police take, because he is a serving minister. Action should be taken against him."

AAP MLA Jarnail Singh shared the video on X, accusing Verma of losing his

DELHI POLICE GETS COMPLAINT AGAINST PARVESH VERMA

New Delhi: Delhi Police has received a complaint from a man allegedly slapped by PWD Minister Parvesh Verma during a road inspection in Tilak Nagar on Sunday, police sources said.

The complaint was received at Vikaspuri Police Station, the officer said, adding that police are verifying the facts.

The person whom the minister allegedly slapped had earlier identified himself as Saheb Singh, claiming to be an associate of Tilak Nagar AAP MLA Jarnail Singh. He further claimed that he handles the AAP MLA's social media accounts. The incident unfolded when Verma was inspecting a newly laid road in the area.

(PNS)

temper during the inspection. He alleged the SHO of Vikaspuri police station was present at the scene and accused the officer of helping the minister leave.

Former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal shared the video and called for Verma's arrest, saying a minister in the government had publicly slapped a young man for highlighting corruption in road construction, and announced he would visit Tilak Nagar to

inspect the road. Delhi AAP president Saurabh Bharadwaj also accused Verma of slapping the cameraman, calling the incident shameful.

Verma, responding on X, said people should know the "truth behind" the video AAP is circulating. He alleged Jarnail Singh had been pressuring PWD engineers for days to introduce him to the contractor and arrange a commission, and that a PWD engineer had lodged a police complaint over

this. He alleged Singh would visit the site at night after road-work was completed, tear up the newly laid surface, and record videos alleging corruption over not receiving a commission. Verma said he had personally called Singh three times and waited 45 minutes, without summoning any party workers, but Singh arrived with his own supporters who began behaving rudely. "When one of his workers started hurling abuses at my family, I reacted just as anyone would in the heat of the moment," Verma said.

Delhi BJP spokesperson Praveen Shankar Kapoor called the incident unfortunate, saying it should not have happened, but said the circumstances needed to be understood. He alleged Jarnail Singh had been raising complaints about the contractor and pressuring officials for a meeting, and when the contractor did not meet him, he pressured through social media videos, prompting Verma's inspection.

SIR row: CM targets Opposition over vote theft claims

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid a political row over the Election Commission of India's (ECI) handling of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday hit out at the Opposition over allegations of "vote theft", saying attempts were being made to create circumstances aimed at misleading people in the country. Referring to Opposition leader Rahul Gandhi and other Opposition leaders, the Chief Minister said their statements were no less than treason and that cases of treason should be registered against them.

Speaking to reporters at Janseva Sadan on Sunday, the Chief Minister questioned the baseless allegations being levelled by Opposition leaders and asked whether the Election Commission had functioned with the same level of transparency during the Opposition's tenure as it



was demonstrating now by placing its processes and decisions before the public. She said it was not appropriate for the Opposition to create a baseless controversy on the basis of an article published in just one newspaper. The Election Commission, she said, had placed each issue before the public with complete transparency and clarified that the decisions had been taken unanimously.

The chief minister's remarks follow the demand by Congress and several other parties and organisations for the resignation of

Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar after a recent investigation by The Indian Express claimed that two election commissioners formally objected at least 14 times over a 10-month period to the poll panel's handling of the SIR process.

The Chief Minister said everyone had the right to ask questions in a democracy, but such questions should be based on facts. Merely making political allegations and damaging the credibility of a constitutional institution was not appropriate.

On the Opposition's allega-

tions of 'vote chori', the Chief Minister said the process of updating electoral rolls involved identifying people who had died years ago, duplicate entries, voters who had shifted and other entries that had become invalid for various reasons.

She questioned why the Opposition was troubled when the names of people who had died years ago, duplicate names or names of people who did not even exist were verified and corrected, bringing the genuine voters to the fore. "People say so many votes have been cut. Those who have shifted, those who are no longer alive — would you conduct voting for such people? This is how such names are removed," she claimed.

The Chief Minister also referred to the questions the Opposition has raised over Form-6. She said the Election Commission had clarified that the original Form-6, used to register new voters, had not changed. A declaration

related to the SIR process had been added separately. She said Form-6 and the related declaration for new voter registration were still available on the Election Commission's citizen services portal. Keeping public convenience in mind, the electoral process was being made more organised and accessible, she said.

The Chief Minister said the BJP had received a clear mandate in the 2014 Lok Sabha election. She asked the Opposition who was handling the Election Commission's system at that time and whether similar questions had been raised about the credibility of the Election Commission then. The Chief Minister said the kind of activities being carried out by Opposition leader Rahul Gandhi and other Opposition leaders, and the kind of statements they were making, were, in her view, no less than treason. She said cases of treason should be registered against them.

BJP leader asks BLAs to ensure every eligible voter enrolled

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi BJP president and Minister Harsh Malhotra on Sunday asked the party's Booth-Level Agents (BLAs) to coordinate with Booth-Level Officers (BLOs) appointed by the Election Commission of India and ensure that every eligible voter is enrolled.

In a video call with the BJP's BLAs in Delhi, Malhotra discussed what he described as misinformation spread by the opposition about the Election Commission, according to a statement.

He said the poll panel had clarified on September 26 that the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process was transparent and no voter's name would be deleted without an opportunity for a hearing.

"Opposition parties had been blaming the Election Commission for their electoral defeats instead of



Delhi BJP president and Minister Harsh Malhotra

taking responsibility," Malhotra said. He said the current Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar had been in office for only two years and questioned how he could be held responsible for 12 years of electoral defeats.

He also criticised the Congress over the Emergency imposed in 1975 and referred to former election commissioners SL Shakhdar and MS Gill, saying the party had rewarded the

election commissioners with positions after their retirement, the statement read.

Malhotra said the SIR aims to clean electoral rolls by removing duplicate, fraudulent and deceased voters, and that it was matching them with the 2002 electoral rolls to ensure transparency.

He said the Election Commission had extended the deadline for filing claims and objections to October 30 and the deadline for responses to November 30.

Kalkaji gang rape highlights safety gaps at Aastha Kunj park

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The gang rape of a 17-year-old girl at Aastha Kunj Park in southeast Delhi's Kalkaji area has highlighted safety and maintenance issues concerning the sprawling 142-acre green space and other such DDA parks, with residents and local RWAs flagging poor lighting, broken sections of the boundary walls and inadequate security.

Residents said the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) parks remain poorly lit in the evening and portions of boundary walls are damaged, making it difficult to monitor movement in and around the premises.

"One of the biggest issues is that these are huge parks, which are under DDA, but there is no proper ownership. The recent incident has

highlighted the problem. If the DDA is unable to properly maintain these parks, it should let locals come together and form neighbourhood park safety committees, with members from Residents' Welfare Associations (RWAs), police officials and others," Ruby Makhija, secretary of Navjiwan RWA.

The suggestion aligns with the global trend of shifting public park management from a state-funded model to a collaborative public-private partnership. Makhija also said that DDA park timings should be clearly displayed and authorities should ensure proper illumination throughout the parks.

In the recent incident, the survivor, a resident of Faridabad, was allegedly gang raped by three men posing as police personnel at



the park on Monday. The incident has led to scrutiny of security arrangements at the DDA-maintained Park, particularly after dark, as well as monitoring of its multiple entry and exit points.

Aastha Kunj is among the large green spaces maintained by the DDA, which manages more than 16,000 acres of green assets in the

city, including over 700 parks, biodiversity zones, city forests, regional parks and neighbourhood gardens. Residents have questioned whether the existing system is adequate to ensure security and maintenance across such large areas.

"Aastha Kunj was once our go-to spot every morning and evening. My son and I

used to regularly go there for walks and jogging, but the situation has completely deteriorated now. DDA can and should be held accountable for the condition and management of the public environment under its control," KK Anand, a resident of East of Kailash, said.

He said, "When the state manages a public space, citizens should not have to discover its vulnerabilities through a tragedy."

Vaibhav Gupta, general secretary of the Sant Nagar RWA, which is located near Aastha Kunj, said, "The facts emerging from the investigation raise fundamental questions about DDA's management of one of Delhi's major public parks. If DDA needs outside agencies or adoption models to maintain parks effectively, why has it not established a consistently

effective system of basic security and maintenance within parks under its direct jurisdiction?"

The DDA has said several steps have been taken to strengthen the security at parks. "Additional security guards have been deployed during the night shift; regular patrolling is being carried out to ensure that every corner of the site is covered. Bike patrolling with torches and other safety equipment is being undertaken during night hours, and additional lighting is being provided at identified dark spots to improve visibility and safety," it said in a response.

Delhi LG TS Sandhu, who heads DDA, has directed a safety audit of all DDA parks by next week. Several safety measures are also expected to be put in place in the interim period.

BLOs begin home visits over SIR discrepancies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Booth-level officers in the national Capital have started visiting the residences of electors who have received notices for discrepancies, including in names and mapping, as part of the Election Commission's outreach after facing ire over difficulties people have faced during the ongoing SIR exercise. A senior EC official said on Sunday that "door-to-door" visits by BLOs will continue till all notices are disposed of. Notices to electors included in draft rolls are issued for shortcomings in their enumeration forms.

electoral or assistant electoral officers only in exceptional cases. In Delhi, camps were organised on Sunday for voters facing problems with inclusion in poll rolls.

Form-8 applications, used for address changes or corrections, saw 51,904 fresh filings in the same period, against 2,60,768 received up to August 30. North East district led with 6,604 new filings, followed by East at 5,715 and South West at 4,125.

Form-7 applications, filed to object to inclusions or seek deletions, recorded 2,844 fresh filings, against 51,471 received earlier. South East district recorded the highest at 595, followed by



According to status report shared by the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer's office, 1,34,485 fresh Form-6 applications for new voter enrolment were filed between August 31 and September 26, adding to 2,12,400 received up to August 30. West district recorded the highest fresh filings at 16,351, followed by South East at 13,325 and North East at 12,418.

Around 33 lakh voters have been issued notices for minor or superficial discrepancies in Delhi, triggering criticism of the Election Commission of India (ECI), which on Saturday announced measures including additional time for filing claims, home visits by election officials, and help desks for those facing notices. The EC also said that people will have to appear for hearings before

South at 330 and North West at 181. Form-6A applications, meant for overseas Indian electors, saw 268 new filings, against 1,351 received up to August 30.

The Draft Electoral Roll, published on August 31, remains available on the CEO Delhi website at voters.eci.gov.in and at all polling stations. Citizens whose names are missing can file Form-6 with supporting documents, while new applicants turning 18 on or before October 1, 2026 can also apply through Form-6. Use Form-8 for address changes. Special Camps were successfully held at all polling station locations on September 27, a Sunday.

Additional camps will be organised at all colleges and universities on September 29 and 30 to enroll young electors in Delhi.

Delhi Police busts extortion racket, two arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has arrested two men for allegedly running an extortion racket in the name of gangster Kapil Sangwan alias Nandu and demanding ₹3 crore from a businessman, an official said on Sunday. Police also said the accused were allegedly planning firing incidents at the residences and business premises of their targets to create fear.

According to the police, Rohit Arora, 47, a resident of Dwarka, and Sudhir Gahlot alias Chota Nandu, 44, a resident of Uttam Nagar, allegedly made extortion calls to several businessmen in the Dwarka area and threatened them and their families with serious consequences if they failed to pay.

"The accused allegedly used virtual mobile numbers created through a mobile application with fake email IDs to conceal their identities while making the calls," the officer said.

He further said the case came to light after a complaint led to the registration of an FIR on

September 6 at Bindapur police station, in which the accused demanded Rs 3 crore from the complainant.

During the probe, police found that the accused had allegedly targeted at least five businessmen in the Dwarka area, including three known targets and some unidentified persons, police said.

The accused had planned to arrange shooters and carry out firing at the residences or business establishments of their targets to create fear and force them to pay the demanded money.

"A team of the crime branch launched an investigation and mounted technical surveillance on the mobile number used to issue threats to the businessman. One suspect number was identified and traced to Gahlot," the officer said. Subsequently, Arora was apprehended from Sector 11, Dwarka, on September 23, the officer added.

Gahlot was subsequently apprehended from the Dwarka area on September 24 at the instance of Arora. During interrogation, the two allegedly disclosed their involvement in the



extortion case. Police said the accused created virtual numbers using a mobile application and fake email IDs with the assistance of a technical expert, identified as Ajay, who had recently been deported from Canada and is a resident of Madhya Pradesh.

"Gahlot had come into contact with Jyoti alias Baba, the brother of gangster Kapil Sangwan, during

a previous period of incarceration and later projected his association with Sangwan among his acquaintances. Both accused were facing financial difficulties and heavy losses in cricket betting and gambling and decided to exploit Sangwan's name to extort money from financially well-off businessmen," the officer added.

Gahlot allegedly arranged a

new mobile phone for Arora after receiving Rs 9,000 from him and provided him with three mobile numbers of prospective targets. Arora allegedly made threatening calls to the targets during the last two weeks of August.

After the Bindapur case was registered, the accused allegedly became apprehensive of arrest, disposed of the phone used for the calls, and removed the SIM card from his personal phone. Arora told police he had suffered losses of around ₹50 lakh in cricket betting and was struggling to meet household and his children's educational expenses. Police said he and Gahlot planned to use the extorted money to meet their financial liabilities and establish their own extortion network.

Police said they recovered six mobile phones. Gahlot has previously been booked in several cases, including those related to cheating, criminal breach of trust and forgery, while Arora has a previous case involving cheating, forgery and criminal conspiracy. Further investigation is underway.

Thar hits bike on Dwarka Expressway, flees scene



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Mahindra Thar Roxx knocked down a motorcycle on the Dwarka Expressway in Delhi and fled the spot without stopping, with the entire incident captured on the dashcam of a car travelling behind, according to viral footage circulating on social media.

The incident reportedly took place after 8 pm on Saturday. In the dashcam video, the Thar can be seen weaving through traffic in a zigzag manner before attempting to squeeze through a narrow gap between a car and a motorcycle.

The driver tried to force his way through the tight space between the two vehicles, and the SUV struck the bike during the manoeuvre, knocking down both the rider and the pillion passenger.

Both the motorcycle rider and the pillion passenger were injured in the accident. The Thar did not stop after the collision and drove away from the scene.

Delhi Police is collecting details about the accident. As of now, no complaint has been registered in Delhi in connection with the incident, and police are looking into the circumstances surrounding the crash as the video continues to spread online.

Ladakh focuses on diverse tourism segments: LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Leh/Jammu

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena said the Union territory is actively working towards becoming a year-round tourism destination, with a focus on winter, astro, wellness, culture-based, eco, adventure and village tourism.

He said the objective of tourism development is not merely to increase visitor numbers, but to promote sustainable, community-led and environmentally responsible tourism that creates equitable economic opportunities for local communities while protecting Ladakh's fragile ecology and cultural heritage.

The lieutenant governor was speaking after inaugurating Ladakh Festival 2026 at the polo ground, Leh, in the presence of a large crowd on Saturday evening, marking the beginning of a three-day celebration of the region's rich cultural heritage, traditional lifestyle, art, cuisine, sports and diverse tourism experiences.

The festival, one of the region's significant cultural and tourism events, celebrates the living heritage, cultural identity and collec-



Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena

tive spirit of the people of Ladakh. Over the years, the festival has evolved into an important platform for showcasing Ladakh's unique traditions, landscapes, hospitality and diverse tourism potential to audiences from across India and the world.

The festival also assumes signif-

icance from the tourism perspective as Ladakh continues to strengthen its position on the national and international tourism map. As of September 16, Ladakh had received 4.37 lakh tourists, a number already higher than the total tourist arrivals recorded during the entire year of

2025.

"The Ladakh festival is an important platform for preserving Ladakh's centuries-old traditions and presenting its rich cultural heritage on the national and international stage," the lieutenant governor said, emphasising that as Ladakh moves forward on the path of development and modernisation, preserving its deep cultural roots becomes even more important. He said these events create opportunities for local artisans, entrepreneurs, artists, performers, and tourism stakeholders.

"Ladakh is working towards becoming a true all-season tourism destination, with focus on winter tourism, astro tourism, wellness tourism, culture-based tourism, eco-tourism, adventure tourism and village tourism," Saxena said.

The lieutenant governor remarked that the festival offers a significant opportunity to extend the region's cultural identity beyond its geographical limits. He described cultural exchange as a key strength of tourism, ensuring that Ladakh's heritage is passed on to future generations. He urged visitors to experience

Ladakh responsibly, engage with local communities, understand local traditions, support local artisans and entrepreneurs, and help protect the region's fragile environment.

Traditional sports such as archery and horse polo, local cuisine, exhibition of the craftsmanship of local artisans through handicraft and handloom exhibitions and live demonstrations, astronomy and star-gazing activities, river rafting, short films, and a sound-and-light show are the major attractions of the three-day festival aimed at expanding the festival's appeal, bringing together culture, adventure, creativity and new forms of visitor engagement, an official spokesman said.

The opening day featured performances by the Stringmo Sisters and the Shillong Chamber Choir, as well as a variety of folk and cultural performances that reflect Ladakh's vibrant artistic traditions.

Earlier, a cultural parade featuring monastic groups, folk troupes, traditional musicians, horse and camel riders, and representatives from different villages and districts took place from Karzoo and culminated at the polo ground.

BJP steps up attack on SIR row

Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis dismissed the Opposition's allegation of vote theft and accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of attempting to weaken public trust in constitutional bodies to sow seeds of "anarchy and chaos". Speaking to reporters in Nagpur, Fadnavis dismissed media reports alleging rifts within the poll panel and said all three election commissioners had clarified in a joint press statement on Saturday that they took decisions on the SIR unanimously.

Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of spreading "lies and confusion" about the ECI and demanded his resignation. Yadav said the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha should apologise for questioning the ECI over SIR.

Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami too hit out at the Congress. "Every time they fabricate a narrative, it proves to be false, and they get exposed," he said. The CM pointed out that while everyone has the right to question any institution in a democracy, such questions and allegations must be supplemented with facts. Dhami recalled the ECI's clarification on Saturday, saying the SIR order issued on June 24, 2025, was passed unanimously, contradicting the earlier news report that Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar went ahead with the process despite objections from two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi. "It would be inappropriate to portray any internal deliberations or comments as a 'difference of opinion' regarding the commission's final decision," Dhami said.

Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini urged the Opposition to respect constitutional institutions such as the ECI, saying allegations against them should be backed by evidence. Saini targeted Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and other opposition leaders, alleging that they make reckless statements and baseless accusations before later offering unconditional apologies. He said the Opposition had every right in a democracy to question the Government and seek answers, but such questions should be based on facts. Allegations against constitutional institutions, he added, should be supported by concrete evidence.

Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary said, "It was during the Congress rule that former Chief Election Commissioner MS Gill became a Union minister. Another ex-CEC, TN Seshan, contested an election on the Congress ticket against former BJP president Lal Krishna Advani. There was also the case of VS Ramadevi, who had served as an Election Commissioner long ago and was later made a Governor. So, the Congress does not have any right to question the EC's impartiality".

Rape claim sparks highway blockade...

A five-member SIT headed by Phagwara SP Major Singh, with DSP Palwinder Singh, a woman police inspector and student representatives, has been constituted to investigate the matter. The probe will examine CCTV footage, phone data and other forensic and technical evidence.

The controversy, which began late Saturday night, saw students gather near the girls' hostel before the protest spread across the campus. Property was damaged, windowpanes and other fixtures were broken and some objects were set on fire. Students later blocked the Jalandhar-Phagwara National Highway, causing prolonged traffic disruption and forcing diversions.

Jalandhar Range DIG Naveen Singla said students' primary grievance related to an alleged incident involving a girl from Girls Hostel 3 around three days earlier. Police recorded a student's statement and registered an FIR at Satnampura police station against an unknown person. The identity of the alleged victim and accused is still being verified.

Kapurthala SSP Gaurav Toora said police had initially received information about students gathering over rumours and that no complaint regarding the alleged sexual assault had been received at that stage. Police subsequently began recording statements as students pressed for action and a probe.

LPU Registrar Dr Monica Gulati said there was "no truth in the rumours presently being circulated" and urged students, parents and the public not to believe, circulate or amplify unverified information. She said the university had learnt that "anti-social elements" were spread-

ing misleading information in what appeared to be an attempt to malign the institution and disturb its academic environment.

Executive Dean Dr Saurav Lakhanpal described the episode as "rumour rage" and said anti-social elements, rather than students, were responsible for the vandalism. He said the university would cooperate with the police investigation and was willing to involve student representatives and show them CCTV footage. Students, however, continued to demand a transparent probe, action against the alleged accused and stronger hostel security. They also insisted that LPU Chancellor and BJP Rajya Sabha member Ashok Mittal meet them before they called off the protest.

The university's entry gates remained closed amid tension, while heavy police deployment continued on campus. The incident came a day after unrest at Chitkara University in Rajpura over separate unverified social-media claims, prompting authorities to scrutinise the circumstances surrounding both episodes.

Assets worth ₹442 crore seized in Gameskraft...

The assets include fixed-deposit balances, commercial shops, a villa, and several residential properties.

Family members of Gameskraft shareholders, private family trusts and several linked entities hold these assets. The total value of the assets attached, frozen, and seized as part of the investigation has reached about ₹2,843 crore, the agency said. The investigation began after law-enforcement agencies in Telangana filed several first information reports. Gameskraft and RummyTime provided online real-money games, especially rummy games and tournaments, through mobile applications marketed under brands such as RummyCulture, RummyPrime, Playship, and RummyTime.

The companies allegedly promised users that the games would be conducted transparently and fairly, with no automated participants. In reality, however, they allegedly used bots, automated programs, and algorithms against unsuspecting players without their knowledge or consent. Additionally, users were lured using bonuses, referral incentives, entries into free tournaments and other promotional rewards.

The platforms reportedly had a user base of about three crore players nationwide. The ED said many of these users were in States where online real-money gaming is banned, such as Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu. The Union Government banned online money gaming in August 2025.

The ED claims that the profits from the illegal activities were layered and incorporated into the formal financial system, using methods such as paying dividends, carrying out share buy-backs, and investing in mutual funds, bonds, convertible notes, equity shares and high-value real estate, usually going through family trusts and related companies so that the money seemed clean. The ED has said its investigation is still ongoing.

Three-day bank strike deferred, all banks...

As regards the PLI scheme for Scale IV and above officers, the discussions can start with the IBA to propose modifications in the scheme to the government to address the observations of the unions/associations, it said.

The residual issues as listed in the minutes dated March 8, 2024, will be discussed between the parties for expeditious resolution, it said.

In view of the above, it was agreed by the UFBU that the proposed agitational programmes and strike actions will be deferred, it added.

ACs, TVs set for 5%-8% price hike

While some companies fear the hike could affect festive demand, others believe the impact will be limited, as dealers and distributors have already stocked inventory bought at older prices through pre-buying schemes in August and September.

Companies like Blue Star, Godrej Appliance, Haier, Daikin, and Super Plastronics have already announced or confirmed price hikes ranging from 4-10 per cent across categories, while

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Panasonic said it was still evaluating the situation before deciding on any increase.

According to sources, LG and Bosch Home Comfort, which owns Hitachi-branded air-conditioners, have also increased AC prices by around 5 per cent. Blue Star Managing Director B Thiagarajan said prices of ACs and deep freezers have already increased by 5-8 per cent due to higher commodity costs.

"All the commodity prices have been going up because of the war. Copper, steel and plastics have all become costlier," he said, adding that this is the third price increase undertaken by the company this year. Comparing prices with last year's festive season, Thiagarajan said costs have risen around 15 per cent, but with GST benefits of about 10 per cent now available to consumers, the net impact for buyers would work out to roughly 5 per cent more.

Kamal Nandi, Business Head and Executive Vice President, Appliances Business, Godrej Enterprises Group, said another industry-wide round of price increases has become 'inevitable' after commodity prices rose 8-10 per cent since the last revision. "Price hikes of 5-7 per cent across categories will happen. The timing may differ from brand to brand, with some implementing it from October and others from November, but it has to happen," he said. However, he also said consumers would still have an opportunity to buy products at existing prices during the festive season as inventory procured before the hikes remains available in the distribution channel.

"There are pipelines which will last for about a month to one-and-a-half months. Diwali should largely get covered with old-price inventory. Post-Diwali, the new prices will certainly take effect," he added. Haier India President NS Satish said: "If we avoid taking price hikes, we will lose money. If we increase prices, sales may be slightly impacted, but there is no choice," he said.

Satish said the company plans to raise prices by around 5 per cent on RAC from October 1 and may undertake further increases after Diwali and again in January if input costs continue to rise. He also confirmed a 2-3 per cent price hike in other categories such as LED TVs, washing machines and others. He noted that copper prices have risen significantly over the past year, sharply increasing manufacturing costs, particularly in the air-conditioner segment where copper is a critical component.

Satish said Haier plans a cumulative hike of about 15 per cent between now and January — 5 per cent from October 1, another 5 per cent around December, and a further 5 per cent in January.

Daikin Airconditioning India Chairman and Managing Director Kanwaljeet Jawa said the company has already increased prices by 8-10 per cent from September 16.

On consumer demand, he said it remained good for now. "I don't know what will happen going forward, but everybody is aware of the reality in the marketplace right now. It might affect things in the long term if the situation doesn't improve," he said.

Mohan Yadav swings pickaxe at own home...

The initiative is being seen as an example of public participation in the city's infrastructure and beautification works ahead of Simhastha 2028.

Local resident Kadar Bhai said widening the road would fulfil a long-standing demand, as the existing narrow stretch often made vehicular movement difficult. He said residents on both sides of the road had willingly agreed to provide space for the project.

Pawan Panchal, who lives next to Yadav's ancestral house, said the wider road would improve connectivity and benefit local businesses. He said better access could also increase the value of shops and residential properties in the area. Yadav's sister, Kalawati Yadav, the presiding officer of the Ujjain Municipal Corporation, also owns a house on the same stretch, which falls within the widening corridor.

Narendra Jain, who runs a milk shop in the locality, said the demolition of properties belonging to the chief minister and his family had sent a message that the development exercise applied equally to residents. He said people from different sections of society were participating in the Simhastha-related works.

Former councillor Jagdish Panchal said the project would improve the area's appearance and create better facilities for the large number of pilgrims and tourists expected to visit Ujjain during Simhastha.

Abdalpura is among Ujjain's oldest settlements, and the road connects Khajur Wali Masjid with

jiwajiganj police station. The widening is part of a broader infrastructure push to improve traffic movement and civic facilities across the city ahead of Simhastha 2028.

UP cop couple turns lifeline for five lives

The injured were first taken to the Community Health Centre in Saurikh. Usha Singh, Ayush Verma and Arvind Kumar were later referred to Tirwa Medical College for further treatment.

A video of the rescue quickly circulated on social media and drew widespread praise for the couple's prompt action. On Sunday, Kanpur Zone Additional Director General Anupam Kulshreshtha publicly commended Amit Teotia and Archana Singh and announced that they would be formally honoured. Kannauj Superintendent of Police Vinod Kumar described their intervention as commendable, noting that they had not only extracted the trapped passengers but also ensured they received medical attention without delay. Station House Officer Ranjana Pandey confirmed that an investigation into the accident had begun.

Congress challenges ECI claims on SIR

What is the point of this SIR process which has turned into a "colossal waste" of public resources and a nuisance for every citizen, Ramesh asked.

"For nearly 14 crore voters deleted so far in all 3 phases of the SIR, the Commission's answer is that they must now apply afresh to their Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) for inclusion. First disenfranchise en masse, and then ask voters to get themselves re-added," the Congress leader said.

There is widespread evidence of targeted deletions of marginalised voters to benefit the BJP and the ECI has not addressed this charge, he said.

"The centrality of the ECINet software to the electoral roll preparation, its deletion of eligible voters and illegal override of EROs have not been denied. Nothing has been proposed to substantively address these issues," Ramesh said. The ECI has proposed a committee to certify that the software "complies with the Acts and Rules", he said, adding that this is an admission that its legality is in doubt after it has been used all over the country during the SIR.

"We have clear evidence that ECINet was used to delete eligible voters, overriding ERO decisions — this is illegal. ECI claims to be resolving the issue in Goa, where it was caught. What about West Bengal where the same thing happened at a much larger scale?" Ramesh said.

What about all other states where EROs may have been overruled to delete eligible voters, he asked. The ECI has still not clearly stated that EROs will be the final authority over the electoral roll, as defined in the Representation of the People Act, 1950, he said.

Ramesh's remarks come a day after the Election Commission asserted that all SIR orders received unanimous consent from all three commissioners and that the updates to Form 6 for voter enrolment were upheld by the Supreme Court, as it sought to address issues at the centre of a raging row over decision-making in the poll panel and concerns over exclusion of voters from the rolls.

After its first meeting following reports claiming differences between Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the two election commissioners, the poll panel had said in a statement that the letters sent by Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi to the Cabinet Secretary pertained to an officer on deputation, rather than policy or IT division matters. The Indian Express has claimed that Sandhu and Joshi had objected on record at least 14 times over the past 10 months to decisions and orders on SIR that they said were issued without their knowledge or recommendation.

Ramesh further said the ECI has not been transparent about who is operating ECINet.

It is only from TCS disclosures that it was revealed they were involved, he said.

"Why this lack of transparency? Does the ongoing struggle to control the Tata Group have anything to do with this?" he asked.

The clarification on the letter to the Cabinet secretary hides more than it reveals, Ramesh claimed. The ECI has downplayed the letter as

concerning "the working of an officer on deputation" and unrelated to "any policy matter of the IT division".

However, the letter was prompted by an order that removed oversight from the IT division. It stemmed from concerns repeatedly raised around the opaque and non-compliant operation of the IT division, he said.

The core issue was that the IT division was overriding "statutory safeguards" through ECINet, Ramesh alleged and added that these issues still remain unaddressed.

The lack of transparency around widespread use of AI in electoral roll preparation is dangerous, he argued.

"The disastrous Delhi SIR has revealed that AI is being used in the large-scale flagging of voters. The Delhi CEO's defence was that some of the notices were 'system-generated'. The ECI has not been transparent about the use of AI in the SIR," he said.

"In November 2025, the West Bengal CEO admitted to the use of AI. But in July 2026, the ECI told UN Special Rapporteurs that 'no artificial intelligence is used at any stage'. The ECI must be transparent about AI use," Ramesh said.

Ramesh claimed that the illegal change to Form 6 has not been denied, and the weak attempt to defend it only raises more questions.

The ECI has attempted to use a Supreme Court judgement from 27 May, 2026 permitting the addition of a new declaration in Form 6 to defend the change, but this falls flat since the change was made in July to the online Form 6 for all voters, not just for SIR, he said.

"The same judgement also states that the ECI on its own cannot depart from the statutory procedure without a rational basis," he said.

Ramesh pointed out that the non-SIR Form 6 pathway being offered is also deceptive as the Special Summary Revision (SSR) has been frozen since 2024, there is no non-SIR voter roll being published where voters can have their name added through non-SIR Form 6.

The promise to follow basic operating procedures is an admission that they have been disregarded thus far, he said.

"This is a shocking state of affairs. The ECI now promises to circulate agendas before its own meetings and complete performance appraisals on time. We know that the ECs themselves were being kept in the dark and finding out things from the media," he said.

This flagrant disregard for the law and procedures in a Constitutional authority is deeply troubling, he added. The Congress has earlier said the ECI was in "damage control" mode after differences within the poll body came out following a media "expose" and demanded that the ongoing SIR exercise is suspended immediately. It has also said that nothing short of CEC Kumar's resignation or prosecution will suffice.

Terror will face strong response: PM

The prime minister said India endured pain for a long time due to terrorist attacks and the surgical strikes were the country's decisive response against that agony. "India is following the policy of zero tolerance against terrorism," he asserted.

The Indian Army carried out surgical strikes against terror launch pads across the LoC following the terror attack on an Army camp in Uri.

Referring to the ongoing Census exercise, Modi said Census is a national responsibility and every citizen has a role to play. He also asked everyone to avail the online enumeration facility during the Census exercise. Talking about the fight against narcotics, the prime minister said India's youth are coming together against drugs.

"Through the 'Nasha Mukti Yuva Abhiyan' (Drug free initiative), the youth are spreading awareness through creative campaigns and activities," he said.

Modi said during the 'Drug-Free Youth Campaign', millions of youth across the country have taken a very important pledge against addiction and drugs.

"The youth have themselves pledged to stay away from drugs and have also taken the responsibility to spread this message to others," he said.

During the address, the prime minister also paid tributes to late VHP leader Ashok Singhal on his birth anniversary on Sunday, and said he lived a life like an ascetic while remaining in society.

"The direction he gave to the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, the energy he infused into it that very result is what we are witnessing today as we see the grand temple in Ayodhya come to life before our eyes," he added.

GRAPEVINE

Dhaka's birthday wish to Modi

World leaders queued up with birthday greetings for Prime Minister Narendra Modi on September 17. One message, political whispers in both capitals – New Delhi and Dhaka – say, arrived rather late – around 10 pm – and did more than wish him well.

Grapevine has it that the greetings exchange with Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman quickly moved from cake-and-candles formality to a personal invitation. Rahman's maiden official visit to India is now being talked about for November.



Who advised the election commissioners?

The talk of the town is who advised the Election Commissioners to patch up after controversy broke out.

The grapevine is that top leadership advised the three Commissioners to sit together, settle their differences, and avoid creating a burden on the Government. Sources say they were summoned that evening when the news broke and urged to join hands and iron out the differences, as the act is tarnishing the image of the Government as well as Nirvachan Sadan. Grapevine has it that soon all three ECs will also hold a joint Press conference.



Airport babu too bureaucratic?

A few days back, the Airport Authority of India (AAI) chief was shunted to the Ministry of Rural Development as Additional Secretary. But nobody has been replaced for the top job at AAI. Rumors are abuzz about who will be the new AAI chief and why the current chief was suddenly shunted. The gThe grapevine says the that the top office's displeasure led to the immediate shift, citing slow movement of files on airport privatisation and complaints from private operators and a top industrialist that the airport babu was too bureaucratic.



CBI nabs two more in Gujarat digital arrest case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) arrested two more people on Sunday in connection with a ₹11.42 crore digital arrest fraud in Gujarat. The agency also searched 22 locations in 10 states as part of Operation Chakra-VI.

This move steps up the CBI's efforts to fight cyber gangs that pretend to be police or Government officials, keeping victims under virtual detention and forcing them to pay large amounts of money.

CBI said the victim was held under digital arrest for three months by criminals pretending to be police officers and officials from the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI). The victim was forced to transfer ₹11.42 crore into accounts controlled by the group. After tracking the money, the CBI searched several places and found banking documents, account records, digital devices, and other materials, which forensic experts are now examining.



The two men arrested, Himanshu Prasad and Unis Biswas, are accused of handling, moving, and hiding the stolen money. Investigators found that they used the bank account of M/S Hexaquest Global Pvt. Ltd. to receive ₹2.5 crore of the stolen funds, then sent the money to several other accounts to hide its origin.

Both men are also accused of using bank accounts and installing APK files to steal money from digital arrest frauds and other cybercrimes. Police found incriminating chats, messages, and documents on the devices they

Rahul slams BJP over Delhi minister slap row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday attacked the BJP after a video surfaced on social media showing Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh slapping a man who was recording a road inspection, alleging that "vote chori" had made the ruling party fearless of elections and voters.

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha said "vote theft buys not just the result, but the arrogance that follows".

"A BJP minister from the Delhi Government is seen slapping a young man in a video. His crime? He was

making a video. A road was being dug up right in front of the minister, and he had a camera in his hand," Gandhi said in a post in Hindi on X.

"This is the face of a power that no longer fears the voters," he said.

"Ask a question on the street – a slap. Ask a question on paper leaks – a lathi charge. Ask a question in Parliament – the mic is switched off. These people do this because they no longer fear that elections can remove them," Gandhi said.

"Vote theft buys this – not just the result, but the arrogance that follows," he said.

"A Government that takes



victory for granted doesn't need your consent – it demands your silence and 'andhbhakti'," Gandhi said.

Responding to Gandhi's post, the PWD minister said, "Rahul ji, aap rehne do bhai,

ping a man during a road inspection in west Delhi's Tilak Nagar. The incident took place when the minister was inspecting a newly laid road in the area. AAP MLA Jarnail Singh, who was present at the spot, questioned the quality of the work and pulled out portions of the road surface by hand. A man standing nearby and recording the proceedings was then slapped by the minister.

Parvesh Singh, however, alleged that the man had abused his family members. He also accused Jarnail Singh of seeking a commission in the road repair work and said an FIR would be registered in the matter.

"When his (AAP MLA's) worker abused my family, I did what any person would do after getting angry," the minister said in a video message posted by the Delhi BJP on X.

The man allegedly slapped by the minister identified himself as Saheb Singh and said he was an associate of Jarnail Singh and handled the MLA's social media work.

"I was recording a video of the inspection when Parvesh Singh snatched my phone and raised his hand at me, which is clearly visible in the video. His security personnel held my hand and grabbed me by the neck, and pulled me away," Saheb Singh said.

Foreign secretary meets bipartisan US Congressional delegation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri met a bipartisan US Congressional delegation, with the discussions covering the entire gamut of India-US ties, including the recently enacted Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act (SRIA) and the future trajectory of the relationship, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Sunday.

They also exchanged views on international issues of mutual concern, energy security, counter-terrorism and freedom of navigation, it said.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal shared the update in a post on X, along with photos of the meeting.

"Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri met a bipartisan US Congressional delegation led by Rep Brian Mast, Chairman of the



Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri during a meeting with USA's House Foreign Affairs Committee Chairman Brian Mast

House Foreign Affairs Committee. Discussions covered the entire gamut of India-US relations, including the recently enacted SRIA legislation and the future trajectory of the relationship. They also exchanged views on international issues of mutual concern, energy security, counter-

terrorism and freedom of navigation," Jaiswal said.

US President Donald Trump recently signed into law the 'Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026', which authorises him to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on countries buying Russian oil and gas, including China and India.

FIR can't be lodged just because ED wants it: Chennithala on CMRL case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said on Sunday that an FIR cannot be lodged merely because the Enforcement Directorate wants one, and that the Government ordered a preliminary enquiry into the alleged CMRL bribery case because of a lack of clarity on certain issues.

At the same time, Chennithala said the Government was not opposed to registering an FIR against former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan in connection with the case, but decided to first order a preliminary enquiry as recommended by the Advocate General.

Speaking to reporters, Chennithala said the Government's stand was submitted before the Kerala High Court on Saturday.

"We are not against lodging a case. However,



based on the legal opinion we received from the Advocate General, we decided that further steps can be taken after a preliminary enquiry into the allegations raised by the Enforcement Directorate, as there was a lack of clarity regarding some matters," he said.

The Keralam Home Department on Wednesday constituted a Special Investigation Team to inquire into allegations against Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and her husband (former minister) P A Mohamed Riyas

in connection with the CMRL-Exalogic case.

The ED had sought registration of an FIR against Vijayan, his family members and others over alleged financial transactions involving Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL), a private mining firm, and Exalogic, a now-defunct IT firm owned by Veena.

Chennithala said an FIR cannot be registered merely because the Enforcement Directorate has sought one and that the Government had acted in accordance with the legal opinion it received.

Congress targets BJP over tribal rights in Chhattisgarh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

The Congress on Sunday accused the BJP Government in Chhattisgarh of failing to protect tribal rights, create employment, ensure development in mining-affected areas and maintain law and order.

Addressing the media, newly appointed All India Congress Committee in-charge of Chhattisgarh Sukhdeo Bhagat alleged that forests were being cleared for mining projects in several areas, including Hasdeo Aranya, and claimed that the rights and consent of Gram Sabhas were being disregarded.

"Chhattisgarh is not merely a mineral warehouse. It is home to tribal communities, their culture and livelihoods," Bhagat said, questioning whether local communities were receiving an adequate share of the benefits generated from the State's mineral resources.

He alleged that District Mineral Foundation funds were not being adequately utilised in mining-affected



villages and demanded details of expenditure and pending development works in such areas.

The Congress leader also raised questions over implementation of the Panchayats (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act, or PESA, and the Forest Rights Act. PESA gives tribal communities a greater say in decisions concerning their villages and local resources. He demanded that the Government make public details of pending and rejected claims relating to forest rights.

On Bastar, Bhagat questioned whether development accompanying securi-

ty operations was reaching people in the form of schools, health facilities and employment. He also demanded an impartial inquiry into allegations of fake encounters and harassment of villagers.

The Congress leader attacked the Government over unemployment, alleging that recruitments were stalled, examinations postponed and young people remained uncertain about Government job opportunities. He demanded that the number of vacant posts and a recruitment calendar be made public.

According to the latest

Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) annual report, "the unemployment rate among people aged 15-29 in Chhattisgarh was 6.1 per cent in 2025, based on usual status (principal and subsidiary status)", he said.

Bhagat also criticised the Government over what he described as unfulfilled election promises relating to jobs, farmers and allowances, and sought a public "report card" on the commitments made under the BJP's campaign and "Modi's Guarantee".

On the electoral roll revision, he demanded constituency-wise details of names removed during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), including social categories of those affected. The final electoral roll published in February 2026 contained 1,87,30,914 electors, compared with 2,12,30,737 in the pre-draft roll, he said.

Bhagat also accused the State Government of failing to maintain law and order and alleged corruption and illegal sand-mining activities in different parts of the State.

CM Bhagwant Mann deliberates on anti-sacrilege Act amendments

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday reiterated that the Akal Takht is supreme for "all of us", and that the State Government will leave no stone unturned to protect the sanctity and dignity of Guru Granth Sahib through the strongest possible legal framework against sacrilege.



on the provisions of the Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act, 2026, the concerns raised about certain provisions, and the way forward through consultation and consensus, an official statement said.

Mann directed the committee to hold detailed and regular meetings with the panel constituted by the Akal Takht to review the proposed amendments, consider its

suggestions and evolve a consensus, while ensuring that the law continues to provide the strongest possible protection to the sanctity of Guru Granth Sahib and brings solace to the "deeply hurt sentiments of the Sikh Sangat".

"The spirit and core objective of the law must not be compromised while discussing its provisions with the panel constituted by the Akal Takht.

Boeing flags software glitch in 737 MAX jets

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

Boeing has identified a software problem on some 737 MAX aircraft that can reduce automated flight guidance after a missed landing, and the manufacturer is preparing a permanent software update.

The condition can appear when a crew flies a precision approach with autopilot engaged, executes a go-around, and then changes the programmed path for a subsequent approach. In that sequence, the flight management computer may drop vertical navigation (VNAV) and leave the aircraft in a simpler pitch mode. Boeing has told operators the situation is not an immediate safety concern and that existing pilot procedures cover it. As an interim step, it has advised crews to reset the system after a missed approach.



A Boeing spokesperson said the company informed all 737 operators last month. "We shared information with operators that reinforced existing pilot procedures for safely handling such cases. Our engineers are working on a software update to permanently address the issue."

The US Federal Aviation Administration said it is reviewing a potential issue in a software update for flight computers on certain

737 MAX airplanes and is working with Boeing and airlines. It said it will convene a Corrective Action Review Board and act at once if it finds a safety concern. Some US airlines have asked Boeing not to deliver new jets with the affected software version.

Boeing has delivered more than 2,400 737 MAX aircraft worldwide. It is not yet public how many of those jets carry the software ver-

sions linked to the glitch.

In India, Air India Express and Akasa Air operate about 96 Boeing 737 MAX aircraft between them – roughly 53 and 43 respectively.

Akasa Air said it is coordinating with Boeing and that safety and operations are unaffected. "Our aircraft continue to operate safely in accordance with established procedures and applicable regulatory requirements," a

spokesperson said. Air India Express had not commented. The Directorate General of Civil Aviation had not issued an immediate public statement.

Separately, Airbus has found a quality deviation in surface-protection coating on stringers in the lower forward fuselage of a significant number of A321neo aircraft.

Airbus said the source has been identified and contained, a remedy is available, and the matter is a quality issue rather than a safety issue. Affected aircraft can continue to fly.

Sources said about a dozen IndiGo A321neos are involved, with no reported impact on Air India's A321neo fleet. IndiGo and Air India together operate about 190 of the type. Corrective recoating is expected to take up to two years and does not require removing the stringers.

States Focus



NANOMEDICINE WILL DRIVE PERSONALISED CARE: JITENDRA

Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science and Technology Jitendra Singh on Sunday said that nanomedicine will drive the next generation of precision Medicine and personalised healthcare, adding that India's indigenous research carries global potential. Speaking at the inaugural function of the World Congress on Nanomedicine in New Delhi, he described nanomedicine as one of the most transformative developments in medical practice, with the potential to make healthcare increasingly precise and personalised by working at the nanometre scale. The minister said the future of medicine would increasingly involve individualised treatment based on a patient's genetic profile, lifestyle, dietary habits and environmental factors, with nanotechnology offering new possibilities for precision at the cellular level. (PTI)



GOA CM SAWANT HAILS PM'S CALL FOR DRUG-FREE INDIA

Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant on Sunday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call for people's participation in nation-building and a drug-free India resonated with the coastal State's efforts to promote its culture, heritage and tourism. Sawant, after listening to the 138th episode of Modi's monthly radio programme *Mann Ki Baat*, in a post on X, said the Prime Minister highlighted *Jan Bhagidari* (people's participation) as a powerful force in nation-building. "The Prime Minister highlighted Jan Bhagidari as a powerful force in nation-building and called upon citizens to support the *Nasha Mukta Bharat* movement, by guiding youth away from harmful habits and supporting those striving to overcome addiction," Sawant said. Modi also shared the story of Ganesha Himal Museum in Chiang Mai in Thailand, which showcases India's faith, art and the Ashtavinayak tradition, highlighting how Indian cultural traditions are reaching devotees across the world, the CM said. Sawant said the PM's message on promoting India's rich heritage, culture and tourism was particularly relevant to Goa on World Tourism Day. "On World Tourism Day, the message of promoting India's rich heritage, culture and tourism resonates strongly with Goa's own journey of showcasing its unique traditions to the world," he said. (PTI)

Shah flags off India's first LNG-powered train in Gujarat

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Gandhi Nagar

Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah on Sunday launched railway development projects worth ₹1,472 crore and flagged off India's first LNG-powered train from Sabarmati Railway Station in Ahmedabad. Shah said the new dual-fuel train will help protect the environment, make travel more convenient for passengers, and improve safety. The LNG-powered train is a Diesel Electric Multiple Unit with two 1,400 HP Driving Power Cars, converted at the Sabarmati Integrated Coaching Depot to run on both diesel and LNG. Liquefied natural gas (LNG) is stored in cryogenic tanks of about 2,200 litres each and can replace almost 40 per cent of diesel use. The engines can switch between diesel and LNG as needed. Field trials have already covered over 2,000 km. Officials estimate yearly fuel savings of about Rs 11.9 lakh per power car and nearly ₹23.9 lakh for an eight-coach train, along with lower emissions of carbon dioxide, nitrogen oxides, and particulate matter. Shah said the launch is part of Indian Railways' push to reduce diesel use. He pointed out that diesel consumption dropped from 293 crore litres in 2015-16 to 108 crore litres in 2024-25, with the goal of reaching zero by 2030. The network is now 99.6 per cent electrified, up from about 30 per cent before 2014. At the same event, Shah also opened a new WAG-12 locomotive maintenance shed in the Ahmedabad Division, built for ₹700 crore. The new facility can service up to 300 high-power WAG-12 electric locomotives, each with 12,000 HP in a twin-section setup. These engines can haul as much freight as about 600 trucks, so one engine can now do the work that used to need two. The event also included the launch of a WAG-12 locomotive.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the inauguration and foundation laying ceremony of various important projects for Gujarat railway in AhmedabadPTI

up to 300 high-power WAG-12 electric locomotives, each with 12,000 HP in a twin-section setup. These engines can haul as much freight as about 600 trucks, so one engine can now do the work that used to need two. The event also included the launch of a WAG-12 locomotive.

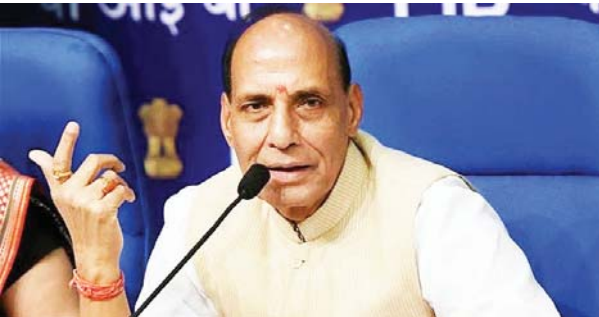
Shah also laid the foundation stones for the Indian-made Kavach automatic train-protection system on 404 km of track: 157 km on the Ahmedabad-Palampur section and 247 km on the Ahmedabad-Samakhiali section, for ₹411 crore. Kavach is already in use on the

Peace must not mean weakness: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Sunday said, "India believes in peace and does not seek to occupy the territory of any country. However, peace should not be mistaken for weakness. We seek global stability, but not at the cost of our strategic autonomy. We are firmly committed to safeguarding our security and strategic autonomy when threatened." Making these assertions while addressing a defence conclave here, he also underlined that there can be no scope for dialogue with any country that promotes terrorism against India. "Countries that use terrorism as an instrument of state policy or provide shelter and support to terrorists must be firmly reminded that terrorism cannot be a strategic asset for any nation, the defence minister said.

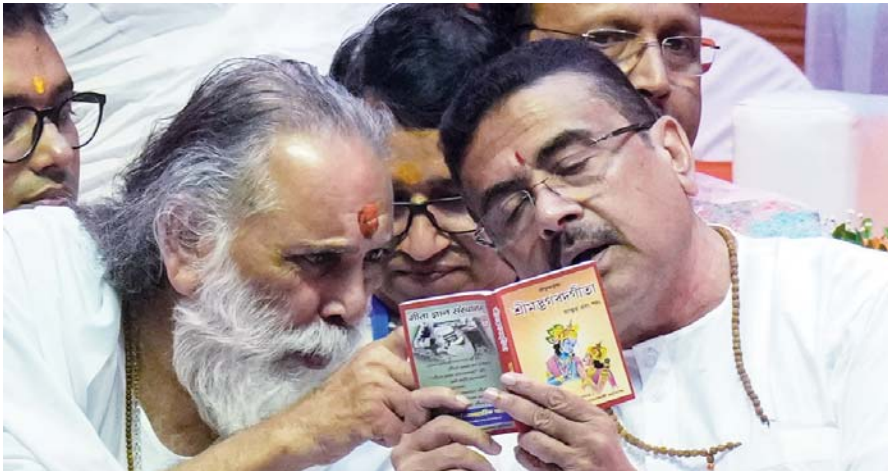
He reiterated that as long as a neighbouring country continues to pursue a policy of supporting terrorism, India remains fully entitled to take all necessary measures against terrorism," referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's remarks at the recent SCO meeting. Emphasising national unity as a key pillar of national security, Rajnath Singh stated that the security of the country is not solely the responsibility of the armed forces but a collective responsibility of every citizen. He urged citizens to rise above divisions based on religion, caste, creed, language, region and other identities, and to place national interest above personal and narrow interests. He described India as a civilizational power whose rise is based on inclusive development rather than confrontation or disruption. He outlined three foundations of India's approach: its long democratic and civilizational traditions, the principle of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* and the vision of *Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas*, and five strategic pillars—respect, dialogue, prosperity, security and culture. Rajnath Singh highlighted India's significant progress towards self-reliance in defence, noting that the country is developing indigenous capabilities ranging from aircraft and drone engines to fifth- and sixth-generation fighter jets. He emphasised that growing international demand for Indian missiles, radars, ammunition and defence platforms reflects global confidence in India's technology, quality and delivery capabilities.



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Rajnath Singh stated that the nature of warfare is rapidly changing, with modern conflicts extending beyond conventional domains to cyber, space, electronic and information warfare, alongside emerging technologies such as Artificial Intelligence, drones, autonomous systems, quantum technology and hypersonic systems. He underlined the need for India to develop future-ready capabilities across these domains. Highlighting India's efforts to address strategic vulnerabilities in areas such as technology, energy, data, and supply chains, the defence minister said initiatives are underway to strengthen domestic capabilities in semiconductors and critical minerals, diversify energy sources, and enhance energy security.

No disrespect to seers will be tolerated: Suvendu



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari with Swami Gyananand Ji Maharaj during the grand mass recitation of the Bhagavad Gita by 11,000 participants at Netaji Indoor Stadium in Kolkata PTI

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday reiterated that his Government would not tolerate any disrespect shown to the sadhus.

Taking part in a programme for mass recitation of the Bhagavad Gita featuring 11,000 voices at the iconic Netaji Indoor Stadium, Adhikari assured the seers, saying "*zamana badal gaya* (time has changed)," that all the sanatanis could practice their religion without fear. "*Zamana Badal Gaya* (Bengal has changed) for good ... gone are the days when the *sadhus* were

humiliated and disrespected ... now the Government will not tolerate any humiliation of the Sadhus ... in Bengal no one will be stopped from organising Pujas or chant Hanuman Chalisa, Bhagwad Gita or Krishna Naam, blow conch shells, chant your mantras and worship Gaumata (mother cow) freely... No Sadhus will be ridiculed... remember that the Government has changed," he announced to thunderous applause. Reminding that he had taken strong action against those who had tried to insult Godman Dharendra Shastri, the Chief Minister said "some people had tried to humiliate Baba

Bageshwar dham but we have taken strong action against them driving home the message that no acts against the sanatanis will now be tolerated in West Bengal."

Announcing that he was not attending the programme as the Chief Minister but as a Sanatani, Adhikari said, "I have come here as a son of Maa Bharati ... I must thank you for reawakening Bengal," adding, however, that the State would have to remain alert against the "*Azadi and Tukde Tukde* gangs who demand freedom for Kashmir." He also promised participation in the Kurukshetra International Gita Mahotsav.

2025 Ladakh violence: Wangchuk seeks release of inquiry report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A year after violence in Ladakh left four people dead and led to his detention under the National Security Act, activist Sonam Wangchuk on Sunday demanded the release of the judicial inquiry report, higher compensation for victims and accountability for the use of state powers.

The Magsaysay awardee, who was released in March this year, said the inquiry, headed by former Supreme Court judge Justice B S Chauhan, should establish what happened during the police firing on September 24 last year, including whether an order to open fire was issued and whether prescribed crowd-control measures had been exhausted before live ammunition was used.



"These are not questions to be answered by rumours, accusations, or counter-accusations. That is exactly why a judicial inquiry was constituted," he said. Addressing a press conference in Delhi a year after his detention, Wangchuk recalled how he was taken to Jodhpur on a special flight on September 26 last year and subsequently informed

that he had been detained under the NSA and would be kept in total isolation.

Wangchuk said he believed there had been a plan to kill him in an encounter on September 24 last year. "From what I understand, there was a plan to make an encounter of myself, but that could not happen," he said, adding that he was instead taken into "total isolation" in a jail cell.

GUNJAN SHARMA
■ New Delhi

The National Testing Agency, (NTA) which recently moved its operations to a new office following a huge controversy over NEET paper leak and administrative lapses, will now be guarded by CISF to ensure foolproof arrangements in the "confidential areas" on its premises, officials said.

The move comes in the wake of the question paper leak of medical entrance exam NEET-UG earlier this year, which had sparked nationwide student protests and led to the resignation of then Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan. A day after Pradhan's resignation, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had announced the constitution of a high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to recommend reforms to make the exam system leakproof. The



Representative photo

panel is yet to submit its report. According to a CBI chargesheet, which identified three subject experts as primary sources of the paper leak, there was no checking or frisking of experts during entry or exit from the confidential section at the NTA, allowing the experts to take briefs from designed question papers on small chits, made out of plain sheets provided to them for rough work and translation. Set up in 2017 under the Ministry of Education to conduct fair, transparent and

standardised examinations, the NTA was so far operating from its office in Okhla.

"A dedicated over 55,000 square feet office space has been allotted in the Government of India Press Building on Minto Road. The fifth floor and parts of the fourth and sixth floors of the said building have been allotted to the National Testing Agency. Confidential and sensitive operations have been shifted in the last one month to the newly allotted building," a senior



Union minister Kiren Rijiju

appointment, Rijiju said. "Frustrated by such behaviour, many groups went back to their homes in the Northeast, took up arms, and engaged in violence," he said. The minister asserted that no one can support or validate militants taking up arms, as there can be no justification for such acts in a democracy. "But we have to see why they took up arms," he said. However, the minister noted that the situation has changed completely in the last 12-and-a-half years since the Narendra Modi

officer of the Union Government was always dismissive of the problems faced by the small communities in the Northeast and would sometimes not even grant an

official told PTI.

The CBI report also noted that the work of the three accused experts went unnoticed as there was no dedicated CCTV live feed monitoring control room in the NTA office in the national capital.

On the plan for monitoring at the new premises, the official said, "Confidential areas have been demarcated in the building where the movement and operations will be strictly monitored to ensure that a foolproof system is in place. The Home Ministry has approved Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) security cover for the premises," the official added.

Sharing the details, the official said 39 CISF personnel have been deployed who will be responsible for security, appropriate access-control and screening measures, including frisking using X-ray baggage screening machine and Door Frame Metal Detectors (DFMDs). "The CISF is being deployed

at suitable locations at all the entry and exit points for monitoring and regulation of access into the confidential area," the official added.

Other parts of the Government of India Press Building are already under CISF cover. While no educational institution in the country has CISF security, the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), which conducts the recruitment exams, is guarded by CISF.

A similar NEET paper leak in 2024 led to the setting up of a high-level committee headed by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan.

The panel made detailed recommendations for enhanced security controls for examination-critical systems covering question paper systems, candidate registration, fee payment, admit card systems, computer-based testing platforms, OMR processing, normalisation engines and result systems. (PTI)

Manipur peace requires community dialogue, not military force: Kiren Rijiju

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union minister Kiren Rijiju on Sunday said the warring communities in Manipur must talk to each other to ensure permanent peace in the troubled state, as the Centre cannot use the military to end the conflict, which has been going on intermittently for more than three years.

Addressing a conclave organised by the Assam-based Pratidin Media Network here, Rijiju also said that "humiliation and insult" towards small communities

by successive governments since Independence led to the formation of a large number of militant groups in the Northeast.

Sharing his own experience of facing humiliation at the hands of then-Union Home Minister SB Chavan in the 1990s – when he and other students went to meet him as part of a student delegation – Rijiju said Chavan even insulted then-Union minister of state PK Thungon for accompanying the students, terming them "*gunda*" (rowdies). Talking about the ongoing

conflict in Manipur, the minister for parliamentary and minority affairs said the Meitei and Kuki communities, as well as the Naga and Kuki communities, must talk to each other to find an amicable solution.

"I have a simple formula. Surrender arms, and peace will automatically come. We cannot use the military because its side effects are huge. The groups should talk to each other. There should be dialogue. A solution will come through talks, and only then will peace prevail," he said. Rijiju said everyone should

Government came to power.

"Today, the Northeast is no longer an isolated and neglected region. In the last 12-and-a-half years, from what I have seen, it has changed so much. In fact, we are becoming one of the engines of growth for India," he said.

However, Rijiju added that sometimes one or two incidents can entirely spoil the progress.

"More than 10,000 militants have surrendered in the last 12-and-a-half years and joined the mainstream," he said.

Sharing his life journey from a small village in Arunachal Pradesh, Rijiju said, "I grew up in a place so remote that I did not know what was happening in the world. Coming from such a background, I am now in a position where my decisions and contributions are critical to national politics – at the heart of Indian politics."

The minister also said that Parliament is the symbol of Indian democracy. "Sitting there to formulate policies and shape the destiny of India is a great journey and a vast opportunity for someone like me," he said.

PM urges online self-enumeration for census

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Noting that the census is a national responsibility, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday urged citizens to self-enumerate online to ensure accurate data for planning the nation's future.

In his monthly radio address, *Mann Ki Baat*, he said so far more than 2.6 crore people have entered their details on the census portal via mobile phones, completing the self-enumeration.

“Census is a national responsibility for all of us. It is important for the nation as accurate information about you and your family helps create a precise picture of the country's future,” he said.

The prime minister said the online self-registration facility is highly convenient, allowing citizens to easily enter information for themselves and their families directly from their mobile phones. Along with Hindi, this facility is available in 16 regional languages, he said.

“A grand picture of the nation is currently emerging. This picture includes you, your family and even your neighbours. I am referring to



India's census. The first phase of this exercise is nearly complete across all States and union territories,” he said.

Modi said data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded, and work is currently underway also in the remote, snow-clad regions of Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, and Uttarakhand.

“To do this, you need to visit the census online portal. The portal is se.census.gov.in

log in using your mobile number, enter your location, fill in the details regarding your family and submit the information,” he said.

The prime minister said the entire process takes about 15 to 20 minutes and for that, no documents need to be uploaded. “After submitting the information, you will receive a special ID. You can share this ID with the census enumerator when they visit your home. After the

information you provided is verified, it will become part of the census record,” he said.

In his radio broadcast, the prime minister also spoke about protecting the environment and animals. Modi said when people protect the environment, they do not merely save plants or animals; they strengthen that entire ecosystem.

He said some initiatives taking place in various parts of the country are beautifully highlighting this sentiment. Referring to the Sonai Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary in Assam, he said there was a time when elephants used to inhabit this area, but as human interference on forest land increased, the elephants moved away.

He said three years ago, this land was cleared of encroachment, and the results have been remarkable - the elephants have returned here again. “Herds of elephants are once again being spotted in areas where they had not been active for years,” he said.

Modi said another wonderful initiative has taken place in Assam itself - this effort is to save a tiny creature, the Pygmy Hog.

“Once, its very existence was under threat; at that time, a conservation programme was launched with just six Pygmy Hogs, and they were reintroduced into the wild. Grasslands were also curated for their living. Today, thanks to this program, the Pygmy Hog population has risen to over 190,” he said.

The prime minister said the relationship between humans and nature is not limited to its preservation because when people care for nature, it becomes a source of sustenance for their own lives.

He said in Sundarbans of West Bengal, some women are setting an inspiring example of this very bond, and some women from Jharkhali are creating mangrove forests.

“Most of them are women who lost their husbands to tiger attacks. After losing their husbands, they found a means of livelihood within the Sundarbans itself,” he said.

The prime minister said the mangroves they have planted are now serving as a natural protective shield for their villages, while also providing them with an income.

TMC MLA Kunal Ghosh attacked in West Bengal, blames BJP

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Senior Mamata All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) leader and party MLA Kunal Ghosh was allegedly attacked by motorbike-borne miscreants who smashed the windshield of his vehicle. This was the second such attack in 24 hours, the former TMC Rajya Sabha member complained.

The pro Mamata Banerjee TMC leader, who literally broke into tears, said, “They had nearly killed me... it was an attempt to murder as they were carrying guns and hammers... they trailed my car for quite some distance,” before attacking his vehicle at Narkeldanga area near Sealdah in North Kolkata.

“This is the second such attack as they attacked me yesterday while I was going to Mamata Banerjee's programme at Serampore... and now they attacked me here,” he said, alleging, “this is a jungle raj that is going on during the BJP rule... where if an MLA is not safe then who is safe,” he said.



Mamata AITC MLA Kunal Ghosh

MTMC general secretary Abhisek Banerjee too raised concerns about the “pre-vailing law and order situation,” seeking intervention from State Governor RN Ravi. “There is no place for political violence in a democratic state ... this cycle of violence must stop, and I urge the honourable Governor to direct the Director General of Police and Commissioner of Police

to bring the guilty to book.”

The BJP, however, denied any involvement in the attack, with State party president Samik Bhattacharya saying the attack on Ghosh could have resulted from the current conflict between the two groups in the party — one led by Mamata Banerjee and the other by Opposition Leader Ritabrata Banerjee.



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis

Crop loss survey begins in Maharashtra, says CM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nagpur

The Maharashtra Government has begun work on preparing crop inspection reports after declaring 265 talukas drought-affected, and it will provide appropriate assistance to affected farmers, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said on Sunday.

He said that considering the possibility of El Nino peaking in next February, “we should be ready to face troubles if it intensifies”.

The State Government on Saturday declared drought in 265 of its 358 talukas, or 74 per cent of the State, amid rainfall deficit and announced various relief measures, including crop loan restructuring, land revenue concessions, and power bill subsidies.

Fadnavis said complaints about the exclusion of certain talukas from the drought criterion are very few and that losses in those areas will be assessed.

“The assistance will be provided to the affected talukas. Twelve emergency measures have been approved, and at the first trigger we already issued orders for their implementation,” Fadnavis told reporters.

He said the Government

has started preparing (crop) inspection reports to an extent, and will provide appropriate assistance after these reports are prepared.

“We are rapidly completing whatever processes are needed (preceding the announcement of financial assistance to farmers),” Fadnavis added.

He said the state Government has received complaints about the exclusion of some talukas from the drought criterion; however, the numbers are very few.

“Even in those locations from where we are receiving complaints, we will assess losses incurred by farmers,” he said, adding that cultivators affected by crop loss will be included under Trigger Three, reiterating that no farmer will be left out.

Responding to a query on water wastage at certain facilities, Fadnavis said every district should prepare a water plan.

“If you reserve water from the available stocks, it will last until July and August 2027, and if somewhere there is excess water, then that water can be used for other purposes,” he added.

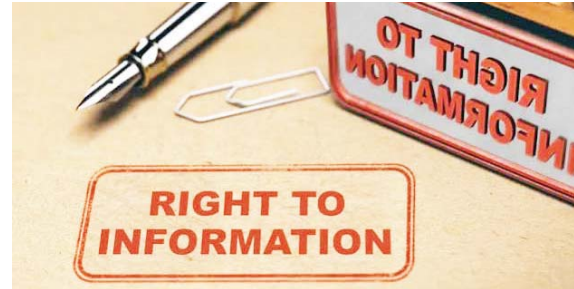
He said many large reservoirs currently have abundant water and they are full.

TN revokes controversial order exempting Law and Order Department from RTI Act

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The Tamil Nadu Government on Sunday revoked a controversial order that exempted the State's Public (Law and Order) Department from the purview of the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, following intense pushback from political allies of the ruling TVK and transparency advocates.

The administration officially withdrew the GO of the Human Resources Management (R) Department, dated September 21. The now-retracted order had originally invoked Section 24(4) of the transparency law to classify the department as an “Intelligence and Security Organisation,” thereby shielding it from public disclosures. The swift reversal comes after the initial move by the TVK-led state administra-



Representative image

tion triggered a political storm, drawing sharp criticism from alliance partners—the Congress and the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK).

Prior to the revocation, VCK chief Thol Thirumavalavan had termed the gazette notification “highly shocking,” warning it would “pave the way for suppressing human rights,” and had strongly demanded its immediate withdrawal.

Congress MP Karti Chidambaram also flagged the initial decision, stating it

set a “bad precedent” and maintaining that the scope of the RTI Act must be expanded rather than restricted.

Had the order remained in force, the exemption would have blocked RTI access to records concerning inquiries into police torture, custodial deaths, police firings, communal clashes, and security-related detentions, he argued. The Sivaganga Lok Sabha MP later welcomed the Government revoking the controversial GO.

CM Vijay to launch one-gram gold ring scheme for newborns in TN

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay will launch the Thaaaimaman Thanga Mothiram Thittam, a welfare scheme, on Monday, under which the Government will provide a one-gram gold ring to babies born in state-run hospitals.

Sources on Sunday said the CM will arrive in Madurai to launch the scheme at the Government Rajaji Hospital.

Arriving by a special flight, Vijay will inaugurate the scheme at the GRH auditorium and present gold rings to 25 newborns.

He is also scheduled to visit the maternity ward to personally present rings to

infants born on the day.

To be eligible for the one-gram gold ring scheme, mothers of newborns must be permanent residents of Tamil Nadu.

The scheme was originally scheduled to be launched on September 15, the birth anniversary of late Chief Minister C N Annadurai, but was postponed due to Vijay's overseas trip to London.

Under the (maternal uncle gold ring) scheme, each eligible newborn delivered at a Government hospital will receive a one-gram, 22-carat gold ring.

The State Government has allocated an annual outlay of ₹755.83 crore for the scheme. In the first phase, 1.28 lakh gold rings have



been made ready.

The gold rings will carry unique serial numbers and be distributed in tamper-proof packaging, the Government said in a press release.

The scheme will be imple-

mented across the State, except in areas falling under the Maduranthakam and Dharapuram Assembly constituencies, where bypolls are scheduled to be held on October 6.

Eligible beneficiaries should be registered under the Pregnancy and Infant Cohort Monitoring and Evaluation (PICME) system and have a Reproductive and Child Health (RCH) ID.

The gold rings will be provided when the beneficiaries are discharged from the hospitals.

Government sources said the scheme would not only increase public trust in Government healthcare services but also promote safe delivery practices in hospitals. According to the Government, around 7.80 lakh children are born in Tamil Nadu every year and, as per the National Family Health Survey-6 (NFHS-6), 99.9 per cent of these deliveries take place in health-care institutions.

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Former Tripura CM Manik Sarkar faces protests, black flags

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Agartala

Former Tripura Chief Minister Manik Sarkar on Sunday faced protests and black flags by a group of villagers in West Tripura district while he was on his way to attend a DYFI programme, police said.

Sarkar's party, the CPI(M), and the Congress condemned the attack and alleged that it reflects the prevailing law-and-order situation under the BJP-led Government in the State.

Police said Sarkar was proceeding to attend the Mohanpur divisional committee conference of CPI (M)'s youth organisation, DYFI, at Kalibazar around 12 pm when protesters surrounded his vehicle and raised slogans asking him to go back.

They also waved black flags at Sarkar who was the chief minister between 1998 and 2018.



“A strong contingent of police and CRPF personnel reached the spot after being alerted and escorted Sarkar safely to the local CPI(M) office. The ex-chief minister addressed the programme and safely returned to Agartala”, Sub Divisional Police Officer (SDPO), Mohanpur, Asish Das Gupta, said.

CPI(M) State secretary and Leader of the Opposition in the Tripura Assembly, Jitendra Chaudhury, condemned the incident and said he had spoken to Director General of Police (in-charge) GS Rao, who assured him that the matter would be looked into.

Nearly 5,000 rescued after rains swell rivers across Chhattisgarh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jagdalpur/Raipur

Nearly 5,000 people were rescued, including 16 airlifted, in the last two days after heavy rains swelled rivers in Chhattisgarh, officials said on Sunday, while a video showed people retrieving liquor bottles swept away from a shop in Dhamtari.

As many as six truck drivers and helpers were stranded on a highway in the worst-affected Bastar and sought help from the rooftops of their vehicles before being rescued, they said.

On Saturday, two persons were reported missing after being swept away in separate incidents in Dhamtari district, while two boys, aged 12 and 16, were swept away while bathing in the swollen

Arpa river in Bilaspur district, they said, adding that the body of one of the victims was found.

Although rainfall has subsided, rising water levels in rivers and streams due to continued inflow from upstream areas and release of water from dams have aggravated the flood-like situation, particularly in Bastar and adjoining areas, they said.

More than 1,000 persons have been rescued and shifted to relief camps in the last 24 hours in Bastar district, an official in Jagdalpur said. Sixteen persons stranded in the Dongaghat area were rescued using helicopters on Sunday morning, he said.

The administration has set up 43 relief camps in urban and rural areas of the district, where more than 5,000

affected people were being provided shelter, food and other essential facilities, the official said.

The Indravati river level rose to 12.56 metres by 8 pm on Saturday, 4.26 metres above the danger mark. The rising water level has prompted heightened vigilance in low-lying and riverside settlements, with field teams instructed to monitor vulnerable areas round the clock and evacuate people whenever required, he said.

Bastar Collector Akash Chhikara and Superintendent of Police Shalabh Sinha visited several affected areas, including Dongaghat and Asna, for the second consecutive day on Saturday to assess the situation. They also inspected arrangements at a relief camp in



Panarapara, he said.

In another rescue operation, around half a dozen truck drivers and helpers stranded amid floodwaters near Sonarpal in the district

on National Highway-30 were rescued by relief teams on Saturday, he said.

Five trucks got stranded after several feet of water accumulated on the

Jagdalpur-Raipur road. The drivers and helpers had taken shelter on the roofs of the vehicles and sought help from the administration through videos, he said.

In Dhamtari, the rising water level of the Mahanadi had submerged the liquor shop, sweeping away bottles kept there. A video showed some people trying to retrieve the bottles from the flowing water using a sari and net tied to a bamboo pole.

A 65-year-old retired forest department employee, Babulal Sahu, went missing in Sirsida village of the district. His mobile phone, shawl, walking stick and towel were found near the riverbank, raising fears that he may have been swept away, officials said.

In another incident, a 15-year-old girl, Tarana Nishad, was swept away in a rivulet near a petrol pump in Megha village under the Magarlod police station area, they said.

Police and SDRF teams were conducting search operations in both places.

In Bilaspur, two boys, aged 12 and 16, were swept away while bathing in the swollen Arpa river at Madhuban Ghat in the Dayalband area on Saturday. The body of one of them was recovered late on Saturday, while a search was underway for the other boy, officials said.

In Durg, 764 people were rescued after water entered around 200 houses in 13 rural areas and parts of Durg and Bhilai following continuous rainfall on September 24 and 25. They were shifted to 16 temporary relief camps established in different places of the district to provide food, drinking water and other essential facilities, officials said.



Editor's
TAKE

Jaishankar's rebuke:
Necessary message

At the UN General Assembly, Jaishankar rejects Pakistan's framing of terrorism and self-defence charges while Sharif revisits Kashmir, Indus waters and Trump's role

At the 81st UN General Assembly, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar delivered India's sharpest riposte yet to Pakistan, calling it a "serial practitioner of terrorism" without naming it directly. The target was unmistakable: a day earlier, PM Shehbaz Sharif had told the same assembly that Pakistan's response to Operation Sindoor was an exercise of its "inherent right of self-defence," credited Donald Trump for a "timely intervention" in the 2025 conflict, and revived Kashmir and the Indus Waters Treaty. Jaishankar's reply was blunt: arguments invoked to normalise terrorism and claim immunity from its consequences "will not stand." Friendship, he said, cannot coexist with terrorism.

On substance, Jaishankar's case is strong. The Pahalgam attack of April 22, which killed 26 civilians, was condemned by the Security Council within days; the Resistance Front's claim of responsibility was well documented, even as Pakistan lobbied to keep its name out of the Council's statement. Operation Sindoor's strikes on Jaish-e-Mohammed's Bahawalpur stronghold and Lashkar-e-Taiba's Muridke base followed the red line India has held since 2016: cross-border terror invites cross-border retaliation. Framing this as self-defence rests on firmer ground than Sharif's attempt to cast Pakistan's response as the defensive act.

Where the speech is weaker is in what it leaves unresolved. Refusing to name Pakistan gives the address deniability but also dilutes it. The speech also recycled language he used at three previous Assemblies – epicentre of global terrorism, consequences, mend its ways which sounds cliché. And it also fell short of calling Trump bluff on being a peacemaker.

The danger Jaishankar named – arguments that normalise terrorism and grant its sponsors immunity – is real and growing. When a state's leadership credits an army chief for actions triggered by a terror attack, and frames retaliation for that attack as the aggression needing justification, the line between perpetrator and victim starts to blur. Pakistan has used terrorism to inflict pain and cannot wash its hands by saying it has nothing to do with those non-state actors.

The speech worked: it dominated headlines, reasserted India's post-Pahalgam doctrine – no talks under terror, blood and water cannot flow together – and signalled continuity to a domestic audience still processing last year's conflict. But as diplomacy meant to move opinions, it did less.

The general debate is a stage for talking past adversaries, not persuading them, and nothing said on Saturday will alter Pakistan's calculus or loosen Washington's studied ambiguity between two nuclear-armed states it would rather not choose between. Effective messaging, then; not yet effective policy.

The real test was never the assembly hall – it is whether major capitals now treat normalising terrorism as disqualifying, or merely as rhetoric to nod along with before returning to business as usual with Islamabad.

A great personality, committed to nation-building

As India marks the birth centenary of Shri Ashok Singhal Ji, we remember a life devoted to society and the nation. From his early years in Prayagraj to decades of organisational work, social service and the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, Ashok Ji combined spiritual conviction with energy, simplicity and dedication.



NARENDRA
MODI

There is a beautiful saying, "*Vriksh kabahu naahin phal bhakhai, nadi na sanchai neer. Parmarth ke kaarme, saadhun dhara shareer*." It means the tree does not consume its own fruit, nor does the river retain its waters. Both exist for the benefit of others. Our saints and seers have long taught us that a life devoted to the welfare of those around us acquires a meaning far greater than individual achievement. If there is one person in whom this spirit was constantly reflected, it was Shri Ashok Singhal Ji. Starting 27th September, we mark his birth centenary to celebrate an outstanding personality who brought together spiritual pursuit, cultural awakening and decades of dedicated organisational work.

I consider it a privilege that I had innumerable opportunities to interact with Ashok Ji and receive his affection. One of the earliest instances dates back to 1981, when I was a young Karyakarta going about the organisational duties given to me. I received a handwritten letter from him. Naturally, it was a noteworthy moment for me. He talked about an important upcoming programme and gave a few tasks to be done.

Over several decades, I saw him work day and night. He would undertake long and often difficult travels to the remotest of areas. He was particularly passionate about travelling across tribal areas of Gujarat. His mind was constantly running, thinking about what more one can do for those on the margins of society. Whenever any part of the nation was affected by a natural disaster, Ashok Ji was either among the first to reach there himself or among those guiding Karyakartas to help those affected. My own experience with him in the aftermath of the 2001 Kutch earthquake was unforgettable.

This spirit of compassion and care for others is something that came to Ashok Ji very early in his life. He hailed from a very illustrious and prosperous family. His father, Shri Mahavir Ji, was a distinguished administrator. One of his brothers, Shri BP Singhal Ji, went on to become a police officer and later a Member of Parliament. Another brother, Shri VP Singhal Ji, was the Chief Secretary of Tripura when the state was just formed. Other family members succeeded in the world of commerce and agriculture. But from a young age, Ashok Ji was attracted to something else altogether...the revival of Bharat and bringing glory to Maa Bharti's children. Growing up in Prayagraj, Ashok Ji would sit for hours on the banks of the Sangam. The river naturally inter-



SHRI ASHOK
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The article has been written
by the Prime Minister of India

ested him, but so did the people who came, such as saints, seers and devotees. It nurtured an understanding of India's cultural ethos and strengthened his intention to do something for society. This desire to live for others drew him to the RSS. He embraced every responsibility that came his way with enthusiasm, discipline and a sense of duty.

Shri Ashok Singhal Ji nurtured institutions and movements through persistence and hard work. He was blessed with a formidable voice and an oratory that could hold an entire gathering in its spell. Equally noteworthy was his care for fellow Karyakartas. Anyone who came into contact with him could not help but marvel at his remarkable simplicity. He shared a deep bond with the Sant Samaj and commanded immense respect among saints and seers across the country.

They valued his counsel and listened to him with great regard. My mind goes back to two instances which brought out the legendary persona of Shri Ashok Singhal Ji. The first was in 1993, when the Vishwa Hindu Parishad organised a convention in the USA to mark 100 years since Swami Vivekananda's Chicago address. The vision to host such a conference overseas, the planning and the bringing together of diverse stakeholders revealed the organisational genius of Ashok Ji.

The second instance is from the year 2000. The World Hindu Conference was organised in Port of Spain in Trinidad and Tobago. I could see how his presence ignited so much enthusiasm among other delegates. After my address, his words of appreciation were a very moving experience for me. I saw yet again how his encouragement filled every Karyakarta with so much energy. No mention of Shri

He firmly believed that there could be no distinction of any kind in society and that every individual deserved equal dignity and respect. It was his thought that the first brick of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya would be laid by Shri Kameshwar Choupal Ji, a grassroots VHP Karyakarta from Bihar who hailed from the marginalised sections of society. At a Dharm Sansad in Kashi, he decided that the Dom Raja would be honoured and went on to work with him as part of various community efforts. Beyond nation-building, Shri Ashok Singhal Ji had two areas that were very close to his heart: education (especially Vedic education) and music. As the MP from Varanasi, I feel very proud that the city I represent, the eternal Kashi, has played its part in Shri Ashok Singhal Ji's life. He was educated at BHU and was also known to be a good student. He was closely associated with the Ekal Vidyalaya initiative, which worked to extend basic education to remote villages, especially among tribal communities. He was a voracious reader as well as a good listener and he always told younger Karyakartas to read as much as possible.

Those who knew Ashok Ji closely knew how well he sang! I recall meetings in Nagpur, where he would sing the Ekal Geet, leaving everyone mesmerised and setting the tone for the meeting.

A video of him surprising everyone and singing "*Hey Matribhumi Meri, Hey Pitribhumi Meri*" during his 90th birthday celebrations in 2015 went viral. On his birth centenary, let us ensure that more youngsters know about his greatness. And let us renew our pledge to realise his dreams for our nation and our people.

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The Messenger Who
Never Kept the Peace

Narada, the celestial messenger and constant traveller between worlds, was often mischievously blamed across the scriptures for stirring conflict wherever his travels took him.

Yet a closer look at his many stories reveals a rather different pattern underneath the mischief. Narada rarely lied or invented discord out of malice. He simply carried true information, often uncomfortable, sometimes deeply inconvenient, from one party to another, forcing hidden tensions and unspoken resentments into the open rather than allowing a false, fragile peace to persist undisturbed. His interventions frequently led to short-term conflict, arguments, confrontations, even temporary heartbreak, but they almost always resolved long-standing issues that had been quietly ignored, buried, or avoided for far too long by everyone involved. His somewhat mischievous role in these stories reminds us that peace built on avoidance is fragile at best, and that sometimes an uncomfortable truth, delivered honestly and without cruelty, does more lasting good for a relationship or a household than convenient, comfortable silence ever could manage on its own. We often prefer to avoid difficult conversations altogether, mistaking the temporary calm of silence for actual resolution, allowing real issues to quietly fester beneath a pleasant surface for months or even years.

Today, raise one honest, difficult truth you've been avoiding with someone close to you, trusting that the short-term discomfort it causes may lead to a far more lasting and genuine resolution between you.

—DAIV

Are we teaching children to think – or perform?



SAKSHI
SETHI

2ND
OPINION

A child delivers a flawless, rehearsed speech and wins loud applause. Another sits quietly, wrestling with a difficult problem, doubting every step until the solution finally emerges. Both represent real academic achievement - yet only one is likely to be photographed, celebrated, and held up as proof of learning. As classrooms grow ever more focused on visible accomplishment, an uncomfortable question follows: are we nurturing thinkers, or simply training performers? Educational institutions worldwide are embracing innovative pedagogy, technology-driven classrooms, and elaborate student activities. These can enrich learning, but they can just as easily disguise its absence. A colourful classroom does not guarantee intellectual growth. An enthusiastic student has not

necessarily understood the concept at hand. Even a beautifully executed project says little about whether its creator can explain the reasoning behind it. Presentation has become a proxy for comprehension, and the two are not the same thing. This traps teachers in an exhausting paradox: they are expected to cultivate critical thinking while demonstrating engagement, with every lesson creative and every activity memorable. But genuine learning rarely photographs well. It looks like patiently untangling a misconception, or letting a student sit with confusion long enough to work through it. Education should welcome creativity and presentation - but never let either substitute for understanding. Real achievement lies not in how impressive a student's work appears, but in how deeply they grasp it.

A related danger is the growing assumption that learning must always be entertaining. Surrounded by instant information and constant stimulation, children risk losing something essential: the knowledge that intellectual growth demands discomfort. A hard problem may take several failed attempts. A difficult text demands patience. Building an original argument requires uncertainty, reflection, and the willingness to be wrong. These experiences cannot be made entertaining, nor should they be. Learning to persevere through that discomfort builds something more lasting than momentary enjoyment: the confidence to think independently.

School leaders must ask whether their priorities reward genuine understanding or merely impressive outcomes. Parents must accept that learning cannot always be measured in certificates, performances, and public recognition. Teachers deserve the professional freedom to prioritise depth over display, with technology and pedagogy supporting that purpose rather than replacing it with spectacle. The real test of education is not how confidently a child repeats a rehearsed answer, but how thoughtfully they respond to an unfamiliar one - whether they can question an assumption, defend an argument, or recognise a mistake.

These abilities will matter long after the decorations are removed, the competitions forgotten, and the photographs faded. Perhaps the greatest danger facing modern education is not a shortage of information or opportunity, but too little time for children to develop their own thoughts.

A school should be remembered not for how brilliantly its students performed when watched, but for how confidently they learned to think when no one was. Education's purpose is not to prepare children for applause - it is to prepare them for a world in which they must think for themselves.

The writer is an educator and a columnist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Iran's balancing act in the Red Sea

Iran's reluctance to actively support the Houthis in their confrontation over Red Sea shipping appears less a rupture than a strategic calculation. Already under pressure from the United States, Tehran may be unwilling to encourage the opening of another costly front that could further expose its interests. China has also reportedly urged Iran to help prevent attacks on commercial shipping in the Red Sea.

Iran may therefore be seeking to protect its own strategic interests while retaining the Houthis as an important regional partner.

Such balancing could have wider consequences. The Houthis operate close to the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a vital maritime passage connecting the Red Sea with the Gulf of Aden and the Indian Ocean.

If disruption in the Red Sea continues while tensions around the Strait of Hormuz remain elevated, two critical maritime routes could face uncertainty. The consequences could include higher oil prices, increased insurance premiums and rising transportation costs as vessels are forced to take longer routes around Africa. For India, prolonged disruption could translate into higher fuel, freight and import costs.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Firmness must leave room for dialogue

This refers to the report, "India lashes out at Pak over terrorism at United Nations" (September 27). The exchange at the United Nations once again underlines how terrorism and Kashmir continue to complicate India-Pakistan relations. India must firmly articulate its security concerns, but sustained diplomatic engagement remains equally important. Statements at international forums should be measured enough to preserve space for dialogue while making India's position unmistakably clear. The larger priority should be preventing another cycle of violence. Intelligence-sharing, stronger border management and effective action against terrorist networks must remain central to India's security approach. At the same time, diplomatic channels should remain open. International institutions can play a constructive role by insisting that commitments to combat terrorism are implemented consistently. Concerns relating to people living in Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir should also be addressed. Competing narratives must not obscure the need to protect civilians and uphold basic rights. India's response can therefore combine firmness with restraint. Terrorism cannot be normalised, but lasting regional stability will require diplomacy, responsible communication and practical confidence-building measures.

A MYILSAMI | COIMBATORE

Transparency is vital for electoral trust

The controversy surrounding Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the ongoing electoral process raises important questions about transparency and collective decision-making within the Election Commission. A petition before the Supreme Court has challenged decisions, guidelines and alleged software changes attributed to the CEC without the consent of the other two Election Commissioners.

It has also sought criminal proceedings over alleged dereliction of duty. The petition further alleges that the Election Commission's software was modified to require details of ancestors and information relating to a previous Special Intensive Revision without completing the prescribed statutory process. It claims that both Election Commissioners objected to these changes and maintained that the forms could not be altered without following the required procedure. These allegations are serious and deserve examination through due legal and institutional processes.

The contribution of former CEC T. N. Seshan is often recalled for bringing greater discipline and visibility to electoral administration. Recent developments make it equally important that institutional decisions are transparent, collectively taken and firmly grounded in law.

DATTAPRASAD SHIRODKAR | MUMBAI



Participants take part in the 5th edition of the Skating Marathon 2026, organised to promote road safety, in Patna.

PHOTO: PTI

The macro cost of syndicated corruption

When corruption becomes systemic, the cost is no longer measured in bribes paid, but in opportunities lost.



PRASHANT TEWARI

“When plunder becomes a way of life for a group of men living together in society, they create for themselves, in the course of time, a legal system that authorizes it.”
— Frédéric Bastiat

India’s corruption problem can no longer be understood merely through the familiar image of an individual official accepting a bribe. The more serious challenge is the emergence of what may be described as syndicated corruption: a network in which political interests, sections of the bureaucracy, business intermediaries, compromised processes, and, in some cases, influential interests in the media or legal system can interact to protect one another. When corruption becomes networked rather than individual, its consequences are no longer merely financial. It begins to alter the functioning of the State itself.

The macroeconomic cost is enormous. Corruption distorts competition, increases transaction costs, weakens public institutions, discourages investment and diverts resources from productive activity. More dangerously, it destroys the most valuable intangible asset of a democracy: citizen confidence.

Modern democracy has created another structural complication. Elections require organisation, mobilisation, communication and increasingly sophisticated campaigns. As the cost of political activity rises, dependence on money, patronage and networks can increase. The danger arises when public office is viewed not primarily as an instrument of public service but as a source of political, administrative and financial leverage. When access to the State becomes a commodity, government begins to resemble an ATM for those who control the access points.

This is not a problem that belongs exclusively to one political party. The BJP blames the Congress, the Congress blames the BJP, while other parties blame both. Governments change, political slogans change, and investigative priorities change, but the underlying institutional question remains: why has corruption not become sufficiently dangerous for those who practise it?

The greatest victim is the last person in the queue, the citizen without money, influence or political connections. For a powerful individual, a delayed file may be an inconvenience. For a poor citizen, it can mean losing a job, a benefit, medical treatment, a school opportunity or access to justice.

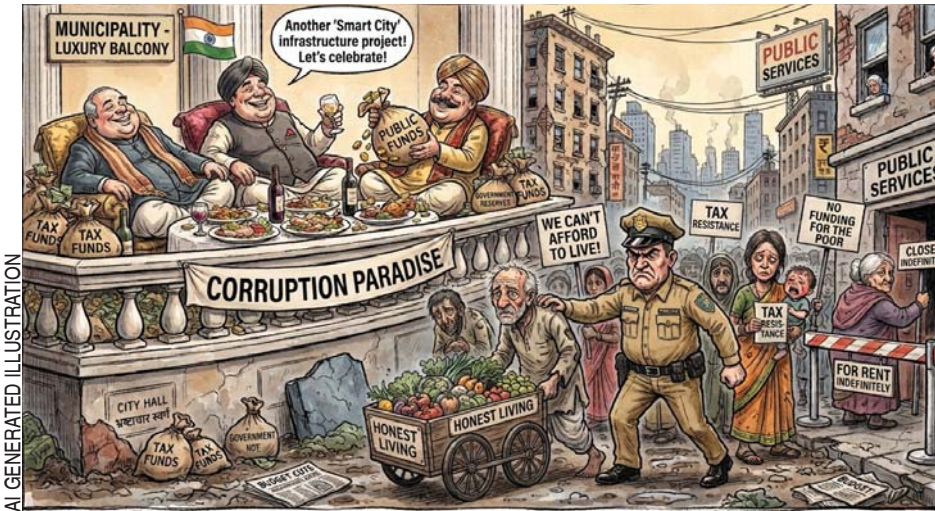
A municipal certificate, land record, police complaint, school service, tax assessment, health facility or welfare entitlement should be a matter of right. When corruption enters these transactions, the citizen pays twice, first through taxation and then through an informal payment for obtaining what the State is already obligated to provide. The World Bank has repeatedly noted that corruption disproportionately harms poor and vulnerable populations by increasing costs and reducing access to essential services.

The economic consequences extend far beyond petty bribery. Corruption can distort public procurement, favour connected businesses, weaken competition, inflate infrastructure costs and redirect capital towards rent-seeking rather than productive investment. It can influence taxation, customs, public enterprises and the allocation of licences and contracts. At its extreme, this becomes a form of state capture, where private interests acquire the ability to influence how public institutions operate. That is why corruption is not merely a moral issue. It is an economic efficiency issue, an investment issue and ultimately a national competitive issue.

“Power tends to corrupt and absolute power corrupts absolutely.” - Lord Acton

The institutional danger becomes greater when accountability mechanisms themselves become ineffective. If a bureaucracy can indefinitely delay action, if complaints are discouraged, if investigations take years and judicial proceedings stretch across generations, the citizen eventually learns a devastating lesson: fighting the system costs more than surrendering to it.

Allegations of corruption involving the judiciary, media or other institutions must, of course, be established through evidence and due process. But even the perception that justice, investigation or journalism can



AI GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

INDIA THEREFORE NEEDS GOVERNANCE IN WHICH THE LAST PERSON ON THE STREET BELIEVES THAT THE STATE WORKS FOR HIM. JAPAN AND SINGAPORE PROVIDE IMPORTANT EXAMPLES OF HOW ADMINISTRATIVE DISCIPLINE, INSTITUTIONAL PREDICTABILITY, TECHNOLOGY AND ENFORCEMENT CAN REDUCE EVERYDAY FRICTION BETWEEN CITIZENS AND GOVERNMENT

The author is a public policy expert and columnist

be influenced by vested interests can damage institutional legitimacy. An independent judiciary and a free media are important precisely because they are expected to restrain concentrations of power and expose wrongdoing.

India has repeatedly witnessed anti-establishment movements that mobilise public anger against corruption and entrenched interests. The rise of the Aam Aadmi Party demonstrated how anti-corruption politics could become a powerful vehicle for political mobilisation. More recent protest movements, including those framed around the “cockroach” metaphor, similarly reflect public frustration with established interests. But there is an important distinction between exposing selected corrupt interests and dismantling the institutional incentives that reproduce corruption.

One government can expose the corruption of its predecessor and yet create new centres of influence. A movement can begin with an anti-corruption agenda and subsequently become part of the same political ecosystem it once criticised. Unless the institutional architecture changes, the cycle survives.

India’s neighbourhood provides another warning. The economic and political difficulties experienced by Pakistan, Nepal, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh cannot be attributed to corruption alone. Political instability, economic mismanagement, institutional weaknesses, external shocks and social divisions have all played significant roles. Yet weak governance and corruption can amplify each of these vulnerabilities. When citizens lose faith that institutions operate fairly, political grievances become economic grievances, and economic grievances can eventually become threats to social stability.

India therefore needs governance in which the last person on the street believes that the State works for him. Japan and Singapore provide important examples of how administrative discipline, institutional predictability, technology and enforcement can reduce everyday friction between citizens and government.

Certainty of punishment matters more than the mere existence of punishment. India has laws such as the Prevention of Corruption Act, FERA, PMLA. But, is there any fear of law for a corrupt man in India? The real test is whether investigation, prosecution and adjudication are sufficiently swift, impartial and credible to create deterrence.

There is also a legitimate public-policy debate about stronger punishment for grave, repeated or organised corruption involving substantial public losses. Deliberate fabrication of evidence, forged documents and false statements under oath must similarly face meaningful consequences under constitutional safeguards and due process. The objective should not be vengeance. It should be to make deliberate institutional fraud economically and legally irrational. The question before the nation is larger than BJP versus Congress, Left versus Right, government versus opposition, or one pressure group versus another. It is whether a democracy of 1.4 billion people can sustain rapid economic transformation while allowing corruption to remain embedded in everyday governance. “Corruption is worse than prostitution. The latter might endanger the morals of an individual; the former invariably endangers the morals of an entire country.” - Karl Kraus

The real cost of syndicated corruption is not the money exchanged under the table. It is the factory that is never built, the entrepreneur who gives up, the public project that becomes expensive, the patient who waits, the student who loses an opportunity and the citizen who stops believing that the State belongs to him. The battle against corruption is therefore not simply a battle against bribery. It is a battle to restore institutional credibility, economic efficiency and citizen confidence. For a country aspiring to become a developed economy, that battle is not optional. It is foundational. And India is desperately running of options and time.

From Himalayan tragedy to global accountability



NAVITA SRIKANT

Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal laid the diplomatic groundwork. Prime Minister Balendra Shah has now carried it to the leaders’ level - and done something harder than plead for sympathy after the Bhotekoshi-Trishuli catastrophe. He has turned a national tragedy into an argument about climate justice, financing, resilience and the failures of global governance.

Climate, Shah told the UN General Assembly, respects no border. Khanal had already framed the disaster as an extraordinary Himalayan catastrophe and placed Nepal’s experience before the international community, arguing that climate-induced disasters do not respect political boundaries. Shah carried the message further, describing the tragedy as a warning to humanity and insisting the Himalayas - whose rivers, glaciers and ecosystems sustain nearly two billion people - cannot be treated as a peripheral ecological zone. Tellingly, he resisted turning climate change into a geopolitical battlefield, calling instead for shared responsibility and solidarity.

Finance, he insisted, must be real rather than repackaged. Khanal’s demand that the Loss and Damage Fund be capitalised through new, additional grants rather than repackaged commercial debt became, in Shah’s hands, a critique of the entire architecture of climate finance. His formulation - “Relief. Rehabilitation. Reconstruction. And also: Responsibility. Reparation. Resilience.” - gave Nepal’s diplomacy a vocabulary worth repeating. His point was blunt: when a poor country must borrow to rebuild what a crisis it did not cause has destroyed, the system is failing at justice, not merely at generosity. The conversation, in his hands, moved beyond climate solidarity as rhetoric to the architecture, accessibility and quality of financing itself.

Development, in this telling, becomes a resilience question. Khanal’s language of “climate-resilient, inclusive and sustainable” development gave Shah a still-wider frame. For Nepal, resilience is no longer confined to the climate sector; it touches infrastructure, connectivity, energy, agriculture, livelihoods and the durability of development gains themselves. Shah’s warning that a single disaster can erase years of progress reframes catastrophe as a development emergency, not only a humanitarian one.

The means matter

as much as the message. Shah pushed further on finance, technology and participation - the tools developing countries actually need, not just the sympathy they are offered. He linked climate vulnerability to food, fuel, fertiliser, supply chains and the ability of ordinary citizens to build secure livelihoods. His most striking image was the contrast between a world that can move weapons rapidly across borders and one where poor farmers still struggle to get fertiliser and fuel: proof, he suggested, that global systems mobilise vast logistical and financial capacity for war while remaining inadequate for basic human security.

Taken together, these threads mark an evolution in how Nepal argues its case - from asking the world to help it recover, to asking the international system to change how it responds. Shah placed Nepal alongside other climate-vulnerable states, landlocked developing countries and LDCs, and argued that justice must be both distributive, over who bears the costs, and procedural, over who gets a voice. His proposal for a Himalayan Climate Resilience Mechanism led by Nepal, India and China - sharing satellite data, monitoring dangerous glacial lakes, running joint early-warning systems and coordinated cross-border disaster assistance - would move Himalayan cooperation from political declaration to operational architecture. For a region where disaster still outruns warning systems, that shift from paperwork to plumbing is not cosmetic. His hope that the range could become “a laboratory of international cooperation, rather than a frontier of fragmented information” captures that strategic ambition well.

One place the address could have gone further: acknowledging India’s role as first responder. Shah thanked India and China jointly for their “prompt and generous assistance,” a formulation that understates what actually happened. On 26 August 2026, Prime Minister Narendra Modi called Shah directly, conveyed condolences, and pledged “all possible humanitarian assistance”; Indian teams, per the PIB, were already coordinating rescue and relief with Nepalese authorities on the ground. That first-responder relationship, and the highest-level commitment behind it, deserved explicit mention in a speech otherwise built around the future architecture of Himalayan cooperation. Naming it would not have undercut Shah’s proposal; it would have grounded it, showing that the trust a trilateral mechanism requires already exists in practice between Nepal and India.

What Shah’s address ultimately asks is bigger than aid for Nepal. It asks what the international system must do differently when disasters threaten to erase decades of hard-won development gains - through finance that doesn’t reproduce the debt it claims to relieve, through preparedness before rather than sympathy after, through cooperation instead of fragmentation. From Vanuatu to Kathmandu, vulnerable nations are no longer simply describing what climate change does to them; they are demanding that the system which enabled it be held accountable for fixing it. Nepal has spoken from the mountains. The question now is whether the world is ready to listen, and, more importantly, to act.

But the deepest cost of the Bhotekoshi-Trishuli catastrophe may not be measurable in either lives or infrastructure alone. Along that river stood a living civilisation: settlements, temples, livelihoods and generations of ancestral memory shaped by the water itself. Roads and bridges can be rebuilt.

A cultural landscape, once its communities and continuity are broken, cannot simply be reconstructed. This is the dimension still missing from most Loss and Damage frameworks: recognition that climate disasters can amount to civilisational loss, not merely a humanitarian or developmental setback. For Nepal, and for every country the Himalayas touch, rebuilding cannot mean only replacing what was destroyed. It must also mean preserving what can never be replaced.



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The Freebie reckoning: How cash-for-votes politics is fuelling a global debt trap



ASHWANI MAHAJAN

Freebies have become political currency worldwide, and the currency keeps changing denomination. In India, what began with free electricity, water and bus travel has expanded into

bicycles, scooters, mangalsutras, laptops and tablets - doled out by parties that once opposed such schemes on principle, all in the name of “public welfare.” The habit has now crossed the Pacific. US President Donald Trump has proposed handing every American adult \$5,000, contingent on his Republican Party retaining control of both the House and the Senate in the midterms.

Strip away the packaging, and the message to voters is blunt: back Trump’s party, collect a cheque.

There is a bitter irony here. Agencies tied to the United States have long marked down Indian democracy despite its peaceful transfers of power, free press, and independent judiciary - even as those same agencies have recently begun downgrading America’s own democratic score. Now Trump’s direct cash-for-votes offer raises an uncomfortable question worldwide: will elections turn on development, clean governance and constitutional rights, or on who pays more? If Democrats respond by topping

Trump’s offer, the rivalry will not stay at the national level - it will filter down to state and local races too, exactly as it has in India, where the strain such competition places on public services offers a preview of what it eventually costs.

India’s freebie economy is concentrated in a familiar list of states - Punjab, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Telangana, Rajasthan, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh and Tamil Nadu. Comptroller and Auditor General data for 2024-25 shows Punjab, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh and Tamil Nadu each spending over 13.5 percent of total government expenditure on such schemes.

Tamil Nadu and Delhi are cited most often, but their books don’t show the same strain: Delhi’s per capita government revenue is more than double the national average - an indirect result of per capita income also more than twice the national figure - and Tamil Nadu sits in a broadly similar position, a cushion most states simply don’t have.

Even the BJP, historically the loudest critic of freebie politics, has fallen in line - not just matching rival schemes but publicising its own versions to shift the political calculus, from Madhya Pradesh’s Ladli Behna Yojana to Delhi’s Mukhyamantri Mahila Samman Yojana.

The party frames these as more disciplined -



Delhi’s version, unlike AAP’s, is restricted to economically weaker women, even as the BJP has quietly kept AAP’s free power and water in place. Principle, it turns out, is negotiable once a rival’s scheme starts working - a case study in political compulsion overriding fiscal caution.

The real cost shows up in the debt numbers. In 2010-11, combined Centre-and-state debt stood at 65.6 percent of GDP - a figure adjusted for transactions between the two layers of government so it isn’t double-counted - with the Centre accounting for 48.6 percent and states for

barely moving. That it then jumped to 81.9 percent within seven years reflects both the pandemic shock, which briefly pushed combined liabilities to 88.7 percent in 2020-21, and a freebie-driven spending pattern that has kept debt elevated well after the emergency passed. Even now, the country sits far above its 2010-11 baseline - and state governments, not the Centre alone, are driving a meaningful share of the increase.

The United States is not immune to the same arithmetic, and arguably has less room to

23.5 percent. By 2024-25 that combined figure had climbed to 81.9 percent, with the Centre at 57.5 percent and states at 28.5 percent.

The distribution matters as much as the total: states leaning hardest on freebies carry debt-to-GSDP ratios far above the national picture - 47.3 percent in Punjab, 44 percent in Himachal Pradesh, 38 percent in West Bengal, 37 percent in Kerala, 36 percent in Rajasthan, and 34.7 percent in Andhra Pradesh. That kind of debt load eats into fiscal space, inflates interest obligations, and crowds out productive investment.

What should alarm policymakers is the pace, not just the level. Between 2010-11 and 2018-19, India’s total debt crept from 63.6 percent to 66.5 percent of GDP - barely moving. That it then jumped to 81.9 percent within seven years reflects both the pandemic shock, which briefly pushed combined liabilities to 88.7 percent in 2020-21, and a freebie-driven spending pattern that has kept debt elevated well after the emergency passed. Even now, the country sits far above its 2010-11 baseline - and state governments, not the Centre alone, are driving a meaningful share of the increase.

spare. Its debt-to-GDP ratio has risen from 95.7 percent in 2010-11 to 123.9 percent in 2025, with the IMF projecting 141.5 percent by 2030. Against that backdrop, Trump’s \$5,000 pledge is estimated to cost the federal budget \$1.2 to 1.3 trillion. Trump insists tariffs will cover the bill, but independent estimates put tariff revenue at a ceiling of roughly \$195 billion - leaving close to \$1 trillion to be absorbed by the federal budget, and by extension US government debt, pushing it up by a further 2 to 3 percentage points.

India offers the preview; the United States may be about to live the sequel. Once cash offers replace policy debate as the currency of elections, the competition rarely stays contained - it moves from the centre to the states, from one party’s ledger to its rival’s, until governments of every stripe are borrowing against the future to win the present. The fiscal reckoning that follows is not abstract: it shows up as debt states can’t service, investments that never get made, and less room to respond to the next genuine crisis. Democracies that let elections be auctioned this way are not so much choosing their leaders as mortgaging them. That is a bill voters, not politicians, eventually pay - and unless the debate returns to development, governance and public amenities rather than who hands out more, it deserves a far louder public reckoning than it has received so far.

The writer is the National Co-convenor of the Swadeshi Jagaran Manch and a former Professor at PGDAV College, University of Delhi



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 **Order Order**

SC orders action against Mau SPs in criminal case trial



Taking strong note of the “casual approach” of Uttar Pradesh Police in a criminal case trial, the Supreme Court has directed the state government to initiate departmental proceedings against the superintendents of police who have served from 2023 till date in Mau district. A bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahadevan noted that only two out of the 54 prosecution witnesses have been examined in the case lodged in 2017, despite charges being framed against six accused in March 2023.

It noted that the 14-year-old son of the petitioner was kidnapped on September 27, 2017, and till date, neither he nor his remains had been found.

“This leaves us in no doubt that the prosecution, which is accountable for producing witnesses, has been absolutely slack in its duty towards the court in the conduct of criminal trial,” the bench said in its September 21 order.

The top court said it is basically the investigating agency which is under obligation to produce witnesses.

“We are shocked at the conduct of the prosecution in not ensuring that witnesses are produced before the court for more than three years and, as of today, only two witnesses stand examined,” it said.

The bench noted that pursuant to its August 10 order, the incumbent superintendent of police of Mau was present in the court and has filed an affidavit dated August 29.

“On a query of the court as to how many witnesses have been examined since charges were framed against all six accused lastly on March 27, 2023, the answer is that two out of 54 prosecution witnesses have been examined,” the top court said.

It noted that despite framing of charges in March 2023 itself, there was not even a “semblance of seriousness” shown by the prosecuting agency in getting the trial concluded.

“Accordingly, we direct the State of Uttar Pradesh to initiate departmental proceedings against the Superintendents of Police, Mau district, Uttar Pradesh, who served from 2023 till date, for such casual approach towards a duty cast upon them, especially in matters of trial. The same shall be initiated within two weeks from today,” the bench said.

“The court would indicate that if it finds that the charges served on the superintendents of police are only by way of formality, the court would take action against the competent authority who issues the said memo of charges to the superintendents of police, Mau district, Uttar Pradesh, who held the post from the year 2023,” it said. While posting the matter for November 16, the bench said an affidavit personally affirmed by the state’s chief secretary bringing on record the action taken be filed before the next date of hearing.

The apex court was hearing a plea challenging a May 2025 order of the Allahabad High Court.

The petitioner had filed a petition before the high court seeking transfer of the probe in the case lodged at Mau in 2017 to the Central Bureau of Investigation or any other agency.

The high court had disposed of the plea while noting the submissions of the state’s counsel that investigation in the case was concluded and a chargesheet had already been filed in the court.

India’s election commission at a crossroads



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

The Election Commission of India (ECI) has become the focus of intense scrutiny in recent days. This has been manifested in a flurry of events and activities witnessed over the past several months.

The issues span multiple fronts, ranging from the legislation governing the appointment of the poll panel’s head-the Chief Election Commissioner and the two Election Commissioners-to the Commission’s functioning on constitutional matters, as well as general public reactions to its operational mechanisms.

An analysis of these issues shows how the nation is witnessing some of democracy’s most critical aspects play out within one of the Constitution’s most sensitive organs.

For decades under Article 324 of the Constitution, the Union Government (the Executive) held the exclusive power to appoint the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners, because Parliament had not passed a specific law. In March 2023, a landmark five-judge Supreme Court bench ruled that appointments must temporarily be made on the advice of a panel consisting of the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition, and the Chief Justice of India (CJI) to ensure fairness.

To replace this temporary judicial arrangement, Parliament quickly enacted the 2023 Appointment Act (The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023), which removed the CJI and replaced them with a Union Cabinet Minister chosen by the Prime Minister.

The Act was challenged in the



Supreme Court, and a two-judge bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and S. C. Sharma heard the petitions. The two judges, on September 23, 2026, delivered a split opinion and differed on whether the case should be referred to a larger bench.

Justice Datta noted that it is not enough for the Election Commission to be independent; it must also appear to be independent to the public. He termed the inclusion of the Cabinet Minister an “ornamental” role, observing that a minister chosen by the Prime Minister is bound by cabinet collective responsibility and cannot act as a true counterweight. This gives the ruling government a permanent 2-to-1 majority on the panel, making the Leader of the Opposition’s presence largely symbolic.

Normally, a split verdict between two judges goes to a three-judge bench first. However, because of the massive constitutional importance of how election watchdogs are picked, both judges agreed to bypass a three-judge bench.

They sent the case files directly to the Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant to consider setting up a Constitution Bench (usually 5 judges or more) to resolve the matter definitively and avoid unnecessary delays.

Beyond appointment laws, the Election Commission faced intense public, political, and legal scrutiny

over its massive Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls across multiple states.

The ECI defended the drive as a necessary step to remove ineligible entries, fake voters, and ensure clean elections.

However, opposition parties and civil society groups strongly opposed it. They argued that the process caused mass deletions of genuine voters and created unnecessary fear of disenfranchisement.

The Supreme Court previously upheld the ECI’s statutory power to carry out the SIR exercise under Article 324 and the Representation of the People Act, ruling that it supports free and fair elections.

Despite upholding the power, the apex court recently pulled up the poll panel over how notices were being handled.

In September 2026, the Supreme Court noted that notices sent to millions of voters-such as over 33 lakh voters in Delhi flagged for “logical discrepancies”-appeared to be mechanically issued and machine-generated without proper application of mind.

The Apex Court suggested that the ECI add administrative safeguards and offer modern, flexible options like email or WhatsApp so ordinary citizens are not subjected to undue harassment during verification. While appointment laws and voter roll revisions were already

making headlines, things escalated quickly with reports of deep internal conflict inside the Election Commission.

News reports allegedly exposed that the two other Election Commissioners-Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi-had formally recorded written objections against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar at least 14 times over 10 months.

They flagged that major executive choices, software modifications, and policy changes were being pushed unilaterally in the name of the full Commission without their consensus or knowledge.

In response, the ECI defended itself by stating that differing views and internal notes are a normal part of a multi-member body’s work during the draft stage, and that all final steps had proper legal backing.

The internal rift and massive voter deletions caused immediate political shockwaves, bringing opposition parties and citizens out onto the streets.

Prominent opposition leaders openly demanded the immediate resignation and removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, calling the mass voter roll changes a threat to democracy.

Political parties and youth groups organized widespread nationwide protests across multiple state capitals, demanding accountability, an independent audit, and a halt to the controversial revision process.

As internal dissents and public outrage mounted, fresh legal battles quickly reached the Supreme Court doors. A Public Interest Litigation (PIL) was filed under Article 32 of the Constitution, seeking to declare all unilateral executive guidelines and software changes implemented without full commission consensus as illegal.

Taking the legal challenge a step further, a Supreme Court advocate sought the statutory consent of the Attorney General of India to initiate criminal contempt proceedings against the Chief Election Commissioner.

This application argued that bypassing fellow commissioners

to issue unilateral instructions under the banner of the “Full Commission” amounts to wilful disobedience of landmark apex court rulings (T.N. Seshan v. Union of India, 1995).

The petition specifically urged the court to set up an independent Special Investigation Team (SIT) or a Judicial Inquiry Commission for an end-to-end technical audit of poll databases.

These overlapping controversies-ranging from appointment laws and voter roll revisions to internal administrative friction and fresh court petitions-have created a serious crisis of confidence.

Citizens, political groups, and legal experts are deeply worried. To save the democratic setup, there is an urgent need to stop these mounting controversies over the working and functioning of the ECI.

Public trust and confidence in this vital constitutional body must remain intact at all costs. After all, the ECI is the independent authority responsible for conducting free and fair polls that bring the government of the day to power in the Centre and the states.

The first and most important remedy lies in fixing the appointment process for the election watchdogs. This process must look completely fair, transparent, and unbiased to the common public.

For this to happen, judicial action from the Supreme Court must not be delayed or dragged out. The legal questions regarding the 2023 Appointment Act need to be resolved in a fast and expedient manner. Time lost in resolving these core structural issues will only cause the institution to crumble further from within. Once public faith in an electoral body is completely lost, the damage becomes extremely difficult to cure.

Protecting the independence, transparency, and collective integrity of the Election Commission is essential to keeping India’s democracy strong, healthy, and credible for future generations.

The author is a senior journalist covering legal affairs

SC to hear plea on MDR on UPI payments above ₹2,000

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court will on Monday hear a plea challenging the Centre’s decision to impose a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on specified UPI person-to-merchant transactions of over ₹2,000.

Ending nearly six years of fully free UPI payments, the government has introduced a 0.4 per cent fee on transfers worth over ₹2,000 made to merchants through the UPI platform from October 15 while explicitly ring-fencing everyday person-to-person transactions and small payments from any charge.

The MDR will be capped at ₹300 for payments of ₹75,000 and above.

Essential and thin-margin sectors — railways, telecom, insurance, fuel and agricultural inputs — will pay a flat MDR of ₹5 per transaction above ₹2,000.

Payments into mutual funds, securities and through stockbrokers and dealers will attract 0.02 per



cent MDR, also capped at ₹300.

Person-to-person (P2P) transfers — which make up 37 per cent of UPI’s transaction volume and 70 per cent of its transaction value — will continue to attract zero charges, irrespective of size.

According to the apex court’s cause list of September 28, the plea would come up for hearing before a bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana.

The public interest litigation (PIL) filed by advocate Anjan Datta has challenged the Centre’s September 14 notification and the MDR framework announced on September 15, which is stated to come into effect from October 15.

The plea alleged that the levy has been introduced without adequate statutory safeguards, transparency or public consultation.

It challenges the constitutional validity of the amended Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, alleging that it gives unguided powers to the executive to decide which electronic payment modes would receive the no-charge protection.

“Declare that no MDR or analogous compulsory charge may be imposed or recovered merely on the strength of a press release or FAQs absent a duly authorised, authenticated and published statutory instrument,” it said.

The petitioner has also questioned the distinction between UPI transactions and RuPay debit card payments, pointing out that the notification continues the no-charge protection for RuPay debit cards without a monetary ceiling.

The plea alleges that the framework is arbitrary and discriminatory, and may

adversely affect merchants, particularly those with low margins, while also raising concerns over possible indirect consumer burden and digital exclusion.

It has sought the quashing or suspension of the framework insofar as it imposes an MDR on UPI transactions of above ₹2,000. Alternatively, it has sought a reconsideration of the framework after transparent consultation, publication of empirical data and an impact assessment, besides safeguards for micro and small enterprises.

“Direct that any future MDR classification be based on relevant considerations including merchant turnover, statutory MSME status, actual margins, geography and ability to bear the cost, and avoid cliff-edge treatment unsupported by evidence,” the plea said.

It has made the Centre and others, including the Reserve Bank of India, as party respondents in the matter.

Courts’ solution in family disputes often artificial: SC judge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Supreme Court Judge NV Anjaria on Sunday said solutions arrived at in family disputes through courts often become artificial, with parties feeling that justice has been foisted upon them, which becomes “illusory and partakes injustice”.

Mediation is the most befitting Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) mechanism for resolving family problems as they are “human disputes arising out of human sentiments”, Justice Anjaria said. He was delivering the keynote address at the Eastern Zone Regional Conference on ‘ADR vs Adjudication in Family Disputes: Challenges and Way Forward’ here.

“Forget our sanskar, the sanskar of Bharat, Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam, now we are struggling to keep even a single family united and one,” the judge said, referring to the rise in family litigation.

Noting that participants had “fruitfully discussed how to counter the explosion of



family dispute cases and the way to increasingly use the alternative dispute resolution system”, Justice Anjaria said the phenomenon of multiplicity and rise in family disputes was noticed as far back as 2008 by Justice Kurian Joseph. He said that family disputes are human disputes arising out of human sentiments and human sensitivity. “The solutions arrived at in the family disputes in the courts or by judge-made law often become artificial. In many cases the parties would

feel that justice is foisted upon them and when the justice is foisted upon or imposed it is illusory, it is illusive, and it partakes injustice,” the SC judge said.

Solution to family dispute is also a process of social engineering, he added at the concluding function of the two-day conference.

Quoting from a case, Justice Anjaria said, “The recent litigation trend in matrimonial disputes indicates that a matrimonial dispute between the parties could generate at least

half a dozen cases.”

Access to justice shall not be handled by multiplication of litigation by taking recourse to all possible legal remedies before available forums, he said.

In the present times, the situation is worse, and there is a cascading multiplication of the family disputes, he added. Justice Anjaria asked the gathering from the legal fraternity of Northeastern states whether the Family Courts Act has been viewed from a different angle.

“Have you read it between the lines, the provisions? The objective reason says that it was enacted for the settlement of the family disputes. The emphasis was on conciliation and achieving socially desirable results. Adhering to rules of procedure was not contemplated,” he said.

A judge in the family court has to play different roles, the Supreme Court judge said.

“He has to be conciliator; he has to arbitrate; he can even arbitrate the disputes between the husband and wife or family members. He

has to be mediator in the resolution of the disputes. His task is really challenging,” he added.

“But the Family Courts Act has perhaps not achieved the desired. And we have failed to extract what we should from the working of the Act,” the judge said.

It is in this light that the need arose to invent and discover the use of ADRs, Justice Anjaria opined.

“Amongst the ADRs, the most befitting alternative dispute resolution system to solve family disputes, I believe, and respectfully believe that the answer will be unanimous. It is mediation,” he added.

Mediation takes care of shortcomings in the legal process, the apex court judge stressed.

“Mediation is suitable to resolve family disputes because it is a method which explores human psychology and, in that peculiar way, explores the human psyche; it searches for the solution of the disputes. It is a win-win situation for both the sides,”

Muslim marriage doesn’t remove criminality of physical relations with minor: Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A marriage claimed to be valid under Muslim personal law cannot confer immunity from penal law for establishing physical relations with a minor wife, the Delhi High Court has held.

The high court said the POCSO framework would be substantially weakened if an adult could answer a prosecution concerning a girl below the age of 18 simply by producing a marriage certificate recognised by personal law.

“The statutory protection would then depend not upon the age of the child, but upon whether a marriage had been arranged before the sexual relationship was discovered. That would turn the legislation on its head,” Justice Sanjeev Narula said in a September 23 order.

The court’s observations came while refusing to quash a criminal case registered against a man for



allegedly sexually assaulting a minor, his wife.

The couple got married when the girl was 16 years and three months old and the man was 28 years old. They subsequently lived together and the girl became pregnant. Her age came to light when she visited a government hospital during her pregnancy.

The girl, unfortunately, delivered a stillborn baby in June. A case was lodged against the man under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act when the matter was reported to police by the hospital

authorities.

The girl maintained that the marriage took place with the consent of both families and that she had not been subjected to force or coercion. She also supported the man’s bail application earlier and sought his presence during her pregnancy.

In their plea, the couple argued that under the Muslim personal law, a Muslim girl who had attained puberty was competent to marry and that the validity of the marriage meant that the subsequent sexual relationship could not attract criminal liability.

Instilling Civic Discipline through the wisdom of the Tirukkural

The *Tirukkural*, usually attributed to the Tamil sage *Thiruvalluvar* who lived in India in the 6th century, is probably one of the most concise and universal secular treatises on ethics. It contains 1,330 verses, the '*kurals*' which encompass almost every facet of human life. Its 133 sections of 10 verses each are divided into three books: *aram* (virtue), *porul* (government and society) and *kamam* (love).

Although the *Tirukkural* is often read as a work of personal ethics, its moral vision extends far beyond the private individual. *Thiruvalluvar* is concerned with the conditions under which human beings can live together in an orderly, prosperous and just society. In modern vocabulary, a substantial part of this teaching may be described as a philosophy of civil or civic discipline.

While the text speaks in the language of its time often addressing an audience of kings, ministers, and householders, its valuable insights into righteousness and personal conduct; and the reciprocal duties of rulers and subjects offer a powerful framework for cultivating civic discipline in contemporary citizens. Thus, *Tirukkural* envisages civic order as a chain: self-control → right conduct → responsible speech → social obligation → respect for others → impartial justice → responsible government → social harmony.

The most significant feature of *Tirukkural* is that the text is non-sectarian. It avoids endorsing any particular religion and instead focuses on universal moral principles such as truth, compassion, and justice. For a diverse, multi-religious democracy like India, this secular and inclusive ethic is crucial because it allows citizens to find shared values that cut across caste, religion, and region. In its own unique way, this text propounds a political philosophy that is democratic at its core where citizens see civic duties as expressions of widely shared virtues for self-governance. This could be juxtaposed with another monumental work on socio-political philosophy, *The Arthashastra* by *Kautilya*.

Three concepts of social ethics form the basis of *aram*. Moral order and right behaviour or "*ozhukkam*, duty to society or, "*oppuravarithal*" and possession of self-restraint or "*adakkamudaimai*".

Kural 121: Self-control places a person among the gods; lack of it leads into deepest darkness.

Kural 122: Guard self-control as a precious treasure; there is no greater wealth in life.

The first and perhaps the most crucial step in becoming a dutiful citizen is mastering one's own impulses. This quality is of paramount importance, especially regarding traffic discipline.

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Queue-jumping, road rage, or failure to drive in one's designated lane happens when one lacks self-control. In crowded cities, treating restraint as valuable wealth would help people observe traffic rules, silence in public libraries, and orderly behaviour. The discipline of speech and control of anger is another important component of the *Tirukkural*. It warns that wounds inflicted by harsh words never fully heal and that uncontrolled anger destroys both the individual and the community.

Kural 127: Whatever else you leave unguarded, guard your tongue; otherwise errors of speech will bring bitter suffering.

Kural 129: The wound inflicted by fire may heal, the scar inflicted by the tongue does not.

Kural 301: He truly restrains anger who restrains it when he has the power to harm; when he has no power, restraint is of little account.

These *kurals* are directly relevant especially in the context of social media and public discourse. In an age of instant messaging, information deluge and online anonymity, these couplets speak with particular force. The decision not to share an inflammatory rumour, to withhold reply in anger to a communal slur, and avoiding to indulge in trolling become civics acts. Calm, measured speech protects social harmony and strengthens the unity-in-diversity that the Constitution seeks to safeguard. Thus, the verses instruct the citizens to speak with utmost responsibility.

The *Tirukkural* goes on to expand the concept of "*oppuravarithal*".

Kural 211: Duty asks for no repayment, what repayment can the world offer to the rain?

Kural 212: All the wealth acquired through one's labour, is ultimately meant to be used in service of those who deserve assistance.

Kural 215: The wealth of a wise person who understands the world's needs, is like a village reservoir filled with water.

Kural 216: When wealth belongs to one who cares

for others, it resembles a fruit-bearing tree standing in the centre of the village.

Kural 217: The wealth of a truly generous person, is like a medicinal tree whose every part can heal.

Modern social reformers from Gandhi to Ambedkar and Periyar have cited the *Tirukkural*'s emphasis on human dignity, non-violence, and social justice. The text criticises pride based on birth and wealth valuing virtue over status, thereby undermining the ideological basis of rigid hierarchies. The text has been cited by national leaders, included in parliamentary speeches and public addresses, as a symbol of India's civilisational wisdom that transcends narrow politics. Its universal ethical language makes it possible to speak of duty, sacrifice, and service without privileging any single community, which supports unity in diversity.

Perhaps the most compact statement of *Thiruvalluvar*'s social philosophy occurs in *Kural* 983, which establishes that a perfected character is supported by the five pillars of love, moral shame, social responsibility, consideration for others, and truthfulness. A disciplined citizen possesses love, because society cannot be sustained by hostility; moral restraint, because conscience must operate even when enforcement is absent; social responsibility, because human beings have obligations beyond themselves; consideration, because others possess dignity; and truthfulness, because trust is essential to collective life.

Using *Tirukkural* to frame civic education (whether in schools, public campaigns, or government messaging) can therefore strengthen a nationally constructive discourse that respects regional cultures (such as Tamil heritage) while tying them to a shared Indian ethos of dharma and responsible citizenship.

From the Himalayas to the Indian Ocean, our nation possesses a profound wealth of scriptures, philosophical concepts, and ideas. This heritage is vital in today's world, where we urgently need a guiding light. Across time and space, the teachings of our sacred texts reiterate that strong ethics are essential for leading a happy, purposeful life and becoming responsible citizens. In our journey toward a Viksit Bharat, we must bring these teachings to the centre stage, ensuring the latent wisdom of our glorious country is accessible to all. A true milestone will be achieved when all of us are well versed with the scriptures of the north, south, east and west. We must unearth and disseminate this ocean of wisdom residing in texts, poetry, and proverbs to every corner of our nation.

Fable with Moral

The Silent Sacrifice for Duty

(Urmila Nidra- Ramayana)

When Lord Rama was sent to the forest for 14 years, Sita chose to go with him. Lakshmana decided to leave his royal life behind to serve his elder brother. He asked his wife, Urmila, to stay back in Ayodhya. He explained that his time would be fully dedicated to guarding Rama and Sita, leaving no room for family life. Urmila agreed with a heavy heart. She chose to support his duty instead of becoming a distraction.

On the very first night in the forest, Rama and Sita fell asleep. Lakshmana stood outside the hut with his bow, keeping a watch. Nidra Devi, the Goddess of sleep, appeared before him. She noted that it was time for Lakshmana to rest. Lakshmana folded his hands and begged the Goddess to spare him for 14 years. He needed to stay awake day and night to ensure his brother's safety.

Deeply moved by his devotion, the Goddess agreed to his request. However, the balance of nature required someone to bear Lakshmana's share of sleep. Lakshmana asked the Goddess to approach his wife back in Ayodhya. Nidra Devi went to Urmila and explained the situation. Without hesitation, Urmila accepted the burden.

For the next 14 years, Urmila slept continuously in the palace of Ayodhya. This divine pact allowed Lakshmana to remain completely sleepless and alert during the entire exile. His unbroken wakefulness eventually enabled him to defeat Indrajit (Meghnada), who could only be killed by a warrior who had conquered sleep. When the exile finally ended, Lakshmana returned and finally fell into a deep sleep so Urmila could wake up. This quiet act became known as *Urmila Nidra*, an unmatched tale of silent sacrifice and devotion.

MORAL OF THE FABLE: True duty requires shared sacrifice

Wisdom Word Search

W P A S A S A N A V B J N
A O W N M K L H U O A Q I
D K A D H I K A R A N A S
H U P E S P O E B I N L S
I J P A R I S A L K K A A Y
P O I J Y O F W V A O C Y
A I A Y U T T A K A T F A
T W M H I T I S V A T Z K
E A A L R A T T H A H D H
Y X C Q R O G A R A V A Y
Y H C D Q W M U E A K E N
A R A K X H G T N I T I A

WORDS TO FIND
Adhikarana, Adhipateyya, Amacca, Ana, Ayuttaka, Garava, Nissaya, Parisa, Pasasana, Rattha

ADHIKARANA (A-DHI-KA-RA-NA) - A legal matter, official case, or public dispute requiring administrative resolution.
ADHIPATEYYA (A-DHI-PA-TAY-YA) - Sovereignty, supreme authority, or the rightful exercise of governing power.
AMACCA (A-MATCH-CHA) - A high-ranking minister or trusted adviser who assists the ruler in governing the state.
ANA (AA-NAA) - An official order or administrative decree issued by the governing authority.
AYUTTAKA (AA-YUT-TA-KA) - A government-appointed superintendent responsible for supervising public works and state affairs.
GARAVA (GA-RA-YA) - Respect and reverence shown toward authority, responsibility, and public duty.
NISSAYA (NIS-SA-YA) - Support, guidance, or dependence that enables the proper functioning of administration.
PARISA (PA-RI-SAA) - An assembly, council, or gathering where important public matters are discussed and decided.
PASASANA (PA-SAA-SA-NA) - The system of governance, administration, and orderly management of a kingdom or society.
RATTHA (RUT-THA) - A sovereign kingdom, nation, or political territory governed under an established administration.

THE WISDOM LEXICON

Note: These terms come from Pali, one of India's Ancient Languages.

Marvels of India

MAURYAN CIVIL SERVICE

Departmentalised Bureaucracy
Kautilya's Arthashastra describes an elaborate, extensive and efficient civil service organised around 27 adhyakshas (superintendents), each heading a specialised department such as agriculture, land, mines, customs and tolls, weights and measures, trade and commerce, shipping etc., assisted and supported by clerks and accountants. This functional division let a vast empire (c. 321-185 BCE), stretching from the northwestern frontier to the Deccan, be administered with the best governance model.

Built-in Accountability
Uniquely, the Arthashastra prescribes qualifications - honesty, loyalty, intelligence and administrative capability - for appointees, alongside an espionage network to detect corrupt officials and other suspicious activities, predating the present-day civil service ideals of merit and oversight.

Corroborated Evidence, Not Concocted
Megasthenes, the Greek envoy at Chandragupta's court, refers to six committees of five members each governing Pataliputra. At the same time, Ashoka's rock and pillar edicts allude to officials called mahamattas carrying out welfare functions. Hence, the textual, epigraphic and foreign travelogue testimony converge on one picture.

Centralised Governance
Ancient Indian historians note that this centralised structure gave Mauryan Bharat its first authentic administrative uniformity. However, they also observe that acute centralisation later made the system vulnerable once weaker successors held the throne: a caution embedded in its own success.

QUIZ

Agriculture & Food Security

Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1 The image shown is a silver punch-marked coin/Karshapana from ancient India. Which dynasty could it belong to?	Nanda	Indo-Greek	Kushana	Satavahana
2 Which is currently the largest site from the Indus Valley Civilisation, showing an uninterrupted timeline of human settlement spanning the Early/Pre-Harappan, Mature and Late Harappan periods?	Chanhudaro	Dholavira	Ganweri-wala	Rakhigarhi
3 Which of them was not a royal emblem for dynasties during the Tamil Sangam Period?	Bow & Arrow	Twin Fish	Bull	Tiger
4 Who was the highest judicial officer in the Delhi Sultanate, second only to the Sultan in the administration of justice?	Kotwal	Qazi-ul-Quzat	Mufti	Amil

Answers: 1 - A, 2 - D, 3 - C, 4 - B

mahabharata

Abhyasavashagam manah

1 "A Mind Tamed by Practice"

Look, Ravi! This is a treasure of books!

Sangita! This is our school library.

SCHOOL LIBRARY

2

Oh! Look! There is also a book carousel (Granthachakrika)!

Yes. Many Sanskrit books are kept in this book carousel.

Books (Granthachakrika)

3

Here are the Vedas, Upanishads, Ramayana, Mahabharata, and Puranas. How come there is no Gita?

Ahl! The Gita is actually a part of the Mahabharata.

Vedas
Upanishads
Mahabharata
Puranas

4

So, in the Mahabharata, there is a war between the Kauravas and the Pandavas, right?

Yes! And during that war, Krishna advised the confused Arjuna — and that teaching is what we find in the Gita.

5

Alright, I remember now. But what exactly is the message of that teaching?

Let's read a part of it today. The chapter is called "A Mind Tamed by Practice."

What does that mean?

A restless mind can be brought under control by practice.

6 Selected Verses from the Gita

Arjuna said:
Desire leads to anger, anger to delusion, delusion to loss of memory, loss of memory to destruction of intellect, and destruction of intellect to downfall. (2.62-63)

The Lord said:
Desire, born of passion, is the great enemy — it is destructive and leads to sin. (3.37)

Contemplating sense-objects, attachment arises; from attachment comes desire; from desire comes anger; from anger, delusion; from delusion, loss of memory; from loss of memory, intellect is destroyed. (2.62-63)

Therefore, control the senses at the beginning. The mind is restless, strong and obstinate; but it can be controlled by practice and detachment, like the wind. (6.35)

7 The lesson...

With practice and detachment, the mind becomes steady and peaceful.

So, the Gita is not just a story of a war...

...it is a guide to inner strength and self-control.

8

Let's keep reading. A calm mind is the beginning of a better life.

MORAL OF THE STORY:
The Gita teaches us that true strength lies in a disciplined mind.

FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

Ten missing after avalanche strikes

Ten people, including climbers and support staff, went missing after an avalanche struck the Himlung Himal peak in Nepal's Manang district, local media reported. According to the Expedition Operators Association Nepal (EOAN), eight people from Himalayan Holidays Nepal and two from Imagine Nepal Treks lost contact after the avalanche buried tents at the base camp of the 7,126-metre Himlung Himal peak in the Nar Phu area, The Himalayan Times newspaper reported. Ram Krishna Lamichhane, director general of the Department of Tourism, said authorities were closely monitoring the situation, The Kathmandu Post reported. Officials were working to locate and rescue thoseunaccounted for, he said. (PTI)

THAILAND

Rain eases in Bangkok

Rain eased in Thailand's capital on Sunday, but flooding persisted in several low-lying areas, with thousands forced to move into temporary shelters. At least eight people were reported killed in the past 10 days nationwide. Days of continuous downpours have caused widespread flooding and severe disruptions in Bangkok, impacting traffic and businesses, with accumulated rainfall exceeding 30 centimetres (11.8 inches) in many areas. Thailand's Meteorological Department said moderate to heavy rain was still expected Sunday in several parts of the country, but conditions were expected to improve by Monday. The city set up more than 200 temporary shelters, and about 3,000 people remained in them as of Sunday. Officials said 31 roads were still impacted by floodwaters. (PTI)

India, Canada ties to reach higher level: Jaishankar

YOSHITA SINGH
United Nations

India and Canada are preparing to take their relationship "to a higher level", External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said after holding a "productive discussion" with his Canadian counterpart Anita Anand on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly (UNGA). "Always a pleasure to meet FM @AnitaAnandMP of Canada #UNGA81 A productive discussion as we prepare to take the relationship to a higher level," Jaishankar said in a post on X Saturday. Earlier this week, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney said at the UN that Prime Minister Narendra



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar

PTI

Modi is expected to visit Canada around December this year, noting that Ottawa is making "good progress" in its trade negotiations with India. "We are making good progress in our trade negotiations with India. It is an exceptionally important relationship on many many levels, people-to-people levels, security levels, and also trade and economic," Carney had said at a press conference Tuesday on the sidelines of the UNGA. Carney was responding to questions on when Modi would visit Canada and how close Ottawa was to concluding a free trade agreement - called the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement -

with India. US President Donald Trump will host the G20 Summit on December 14-15 at the Trump National Doral Miami resort in Doral, Florida. Amid discussions in India regarding diversification of its energy sources, Jaishankar also met Venezuela Foreign Minister Felix Plascencia Gonzalez on the UNGA sidelines. After the meeting, he said: "Our energy ties are gaining momentum, besides other areas of bilateral cooperation. We also discussed current regional issues." He also met Belarus Foreign Minister Maxim Ryzhenkov and his Mexican counterpart Roberto Velasco Alvarez of Mexico. (PTI)

RUSSIA BACKS INDIA'S FOR UNSC SEAT



Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov

YOSHITA SINGH
United Nations

Russia has backed India's candidature for a permanent seat in the United Nations Security Council, saying that any reform of the UN body cannot involve additional seats being allocated to Western countries, especially to Germany and Japan. "Our principled approach is the following: UN Security Council reform cannot involve any additional seats being allocated to Western countries, especially to Germany and Japan, who are now on the path to militarism and revanchism," Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov said in his address to the UN General Assembly. "We are in favour of broadening the representation of Asia, Africa, and Latin America. We support Brazil's and India's candidatures for a permanent seat, and at the same time, I wish to emphasise this: we must satisfy the interests of the African continent," he said. Lavrov added that through its foreign policy, "Russia is trying to fix the situation in the world, working together with its allies and strategic partners: the BRICS, the SCO, and the Eurasian Economic Union". (PTI)

Relentless rainfall triggers floods, landslides across Nepal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kathmandu

Relentless rainfall across Nepal since Thursday has triggered fresh floods and landslides, swept away houses and disrupted road traffic, according to a media report, as the Himalayan country reels from the disaster that killed at least 1,453 people and more than 5,000 remain missing. The bodies of 1,451 people have been recovered till Saturday a month after flash floods, originating near the Nepal-Tibet border, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal, according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and



Management Authority (NDRRMA). Two others had died while undergoing treatment. A total of 13,795 people have been rescued till Saturday, the NDRRMA said. In Rupandehi district, a part of Lumbini province, floodwaters from the Tinau

River swept away six houses along the riverbank in Butwal on Saturday night as the river rose above its danger level, the Kathmandu Post newspaper reported. A police official was quoted as saying that around 200 houses along the river-

bank in Butwal were at risk, with security personnel evacuating about 1,000 people overnight after the Tinau and nearby streams swelled amid continued rain. Authorities initially moved around 500 residents from Majhuwa, a high-risk area in Butwal Metropolitan City-13, to the Durga Temple holding centre, the report said. They were later transferred to safer locations, in various schools in Butwal-11. The Tinau River crossed its danger mark at around 8 pm on Saturday, prompting security personnel to begin rescue and evacuation operations. The Rupandehi district administration has urged people living near

rivers and streams to remain alert and move to safer areas if water levels rise further. In Chitwan district of Bagmati province, the Narayani River and the Riu stream crossed their danger levels early Sunday as rain continued. At the Devghat gauge station, the Narayani River reached 9.23 metres at around 5.15 am, according to the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology. The warning level there is 7.3 metres, and the danger level is 9 metres. The Riu, which flows along the boundary of Madi and Chitwan National Park, reached 3.92 metres. Its warning level is 3.4 metres,

and its danger level is 3.8 metres, the Kathmandu Post reported. The Riu flows through southern Chitwan before joining the Rapti River near Meghauli and eventually draining into the Narayani. Heavy rain has also triggered landslides and mudslides at several points in Chitwan, disrupting road traffic. At Dharapani in Ichchhakamana Rural Municipality-4, part of the road subsided further, and a mud-laden landslide blocked traffic in both directions, a police official said. A landslide at Simaldhara in the same municipality has also blocked the road in both directions.

Burnham brings good vibes to Labour conference, tough choices ahead

JILL LAWLESS
London

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham has been in the job for two months, and so far his party isn't demanding his head. These days, that's an accomplishment. The governing Labour Party opens its annual conference beside the River Mersey in Liverpool on Sunday, with Burnham pledging to turn the page on a decade of economic and political turmoil that has made him the UK's seventh prime minister since its 2016 vote to leave the European Union. He says his message in a keynote speech on Tuesday will be: "It's time for Britain to have hope again." "We've had a decade since

Brexit and it's been a decade of too much drift, too much division, and we need to draw a line on that," Burnham said as he arrived in Liverpool on Saturday. His message is aimed at both the British public and a centre-left party that is hopeful but nervous - ready to embrace his promise of better times, but worried about economic damage rippling out from conflict in the Middle East. University of Manchester political science professor Rob Ford said Burnham's difficult task is to win over "a sceptical electorate" eager for change, "while at the same time doing that within the constraints of a very difficult economic and fiscal situation."



British Prime Minister Andy Burnham

In short: "How do you serve people a bowl of cold porridge and convince them it's a pepperoni pizza?" Britain's main political parties all hold conferences in September and October, combinations of pep rally, social gathering and policy

forum that set the political tone and agenda for the year ahead. Last year's Labour gathering was gloomy, as members despaired about Prime Minister Keir Starmer's deep unpopularity, little more than a year after winning

power in a landslide, and the seemingly unstoppable rise of the anti-immigration opposition party Reform UK. Burnham, then the popular mayor of Greater Manchester, was followed around Liverpool by journalists as speculation grew that he would challenge Starmer. Events came to a head months later when a panicky party forced Starmer's resignation and his replacement by Burnham as party leader and prime minister in July. Now, Labour is seeing a "Burnham bounce" driven by the new leader's upbeat talk and modest moves to put money in voters' pocketbooks by cutting tax on electricity bills and capping bus fares. (AP)

Proposed Sikh marriage bill in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa reviewed

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Peshawar

A proposed law to give full legal recognition and protection to Sikh marriages in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa has been reviewed by lawmakers, government officials and representatives of the Sikh community at a consultation held here. The meeting earlier this week discussed the key provisions of the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Sikh Anand Kaaraj Bill, 2026, its current status and the remaining steps before it can be presented to the provincial assembly, said Gural Singh, vice chairperson of the Parliamentary Caucus on Minorities and a member of



the provincial assembly. Muhammad Saeed-ur-Rehman, local government focal person for family laws, briefed the meeting on the legislative process. He said that after vetting by the law department, the bill would be sent to the Cabinet Committee on Legislation. After approval by the com-

mittee, the bill would be placed before the provincial cabinet and subsequently presented in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Assembly for consideration. The proposed law aims to provide a clear legal framework for Sikh marriages, covering the solemnisation of Anand Kaaraj, compulsory

registration and issuance of marriage certificates, matrimonial rights and duties, maintenance, custody, reconciliation and dissolution of marriage. Anand Kaaraj is the traditional Sikh marriage ceremony, performed according to Sikh religious traditions and centred on the recitation of the four 'Laavaan' in the presence of Sri Guru Granth Sahib. Participants were told that the proposed legislation would go beyond the Anand Marriage Act, 1909, which mainly provided legal recognition to marriages performed according to the Sikh Anand Kaaraj ceremony. Under the proposed law, both parties would have to be at least 18 years old and give their free and full consent to

the marriage. Consent obtained through force, fraud, coercion, misrepresentation or undue influence would not be considered valid. The bill also makes registration of Sikh marriages compulsory and proposes licensing Anand Kaaraj Registrars through the local government, elections and rural development department. A registered Anand Kaaraj would be recognised as a valid marriage for legal and civil purposes, including inheritance, succession, maintenance, guardianship, legitimacy of children, family registration and identity documents. The proposed Anand Kaaraj certificate would also serve as legal proof of marriage before courts, tribunals, government departments

and other public institutions. The bill provides for equal rights and responsibilities of spouses, including mutual respect, support and maintenance. It also seeks to protect Sikh families from violence, coercion and abuse and provides legal mechanisms for reconciliation and dissolution of marriage. The proposed law would give Family Courts jurisdiction over matrimonial matters involving Sikh marriages. Asker Pervaiz, chairperson of the Parliamentary Caucus on Minorities and a member of the provincial assembly, said the legislation was intended to provide the Sikh community with a clear and accessible legal framework while respecting its religious traditions.

Rio residents tackle gangs as crime dominates Brazil election

ELEONORE HUGHES/DIARLEI RODRIGUES
Rio de Janeiro

Crime is the top concern for Brazilians ahead of October's presidential election, with candidates competing to offer the toughest - and most effective - approach to the deep-seated problem. Senator Flavio Bolsonaro, son of ex-President Jair Bolsonaro, is seeking to defeat President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, with a promise to loosen organised crime's grip on Brazil, particularly in Rio de Janeiro. After Rio's deadliest-ever police operation last year, in which more than 120 people

were killed, polls indicated that the hard-line policies Sen. Bolsonaro touts are popular. Lula, meanwhile, has argued for a more prominent role of the federal government in the fight against organised crime as well as greater coordination between Governmental institutions. But while politicians trade barbs, residents in Rio de Janeiro have been designing their own responses, with ex-traffickers launching podcasts and grieving mothers stepping up to stop youth recruitment. Many residents, community leaders and experts say

that the current approach - which favours armed confrontations between police and the groups - is inefficient and often results in indiscriminate loss of life. They're taking on crime on their own to bridge that gap. Once a week, a group of former drug-traffickers gather in a small recording studio on the outskirts of Rio to dissect their past lives of crime and those of their guests. They air the episodes of 01 Sobreviventes, or 01 Survivors, on YouTube and streaming platforms. A painting of the four founders grinning hangs on the wall, while the podcast's



Mothers whose sons were killed by police attend a tribute event in the Morro da Crianca favela in Rio de Janeiro on Saturday

AP

logo - a microphone breaking a chain - is projected on a screen over the desk. "We want to propagate the idea that crime isn't worth it," said host Fabio Santos, a 56-year-old ex-trafficker from the Mangueiras favela who spent 25 years in prison. "We want them to follow our current lives so that they don't go through what we went through," he added after recording a recent interview with a former gang member who is now a pastor. The podcast, launched in 2024 and followed by more than 225,000 people on Instagram, is both for those tempted by the allure of quick

cash and for those who need convincing to course-correct. Crime leads to prison, a wheelchair or a coffin, they say repeatedly. Santos says several people have said they have seen traffickers listening to the podcast and that he regularly hears about people who left the world of crime or didn't enter thanks to their work. Alan Duarte, 38, grew up in Complexo do Alemao, one of the two sprawling complexes of favelas targeted in Rio's lethal police operation last year. He lost a brother, uncle and cousins - 10 family members in all - to violence.

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UP has emerged as preferred investment destination: Goyal

Uttar Pradesh has emerged as a preferred investment destination due to favourable industrial policies and its ability to attract large companies, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Sunday.

Addressing the UP International Trade Show in Greater Noida, he also said that significant increase in the state revenue collection has helped to push the development of the state.

The minister noted that the state currently has an annual export volume of around ₹2 lakh crore and has set a target to increase this to ₹5 lakh crore by 2030.

“Uttar Pradesh is a preferred investment destination due to its favourable industrial policies,” he said, adding that major corporations and global investors are arriving across sectors, creating new employment opportunities.

He added that excise duty collection increased over four times to ₹60,728 crore in 2025-26 from ₹14,273 crore in 2016-17. It is expected to reach ₹70,000 by the end of this fiscal.

Land transfer registration fees, including stamp duty collections, increased to ₹43,802 crore in the 2026-27 Budget, from ₹11,564 crore in 2016-17.

A similar jump has been registered in mining revenue collections and all this is being used to push the state's economic development, Goyal said.

Goyal added that the next frontier for Uttar Pradesh's development lies in expanding exports in global markets, attracting international investments, strengthening tourism and building global recognition for brands from the state. (PTI)

PE investment in co-working at \$946 million since 2016: Report

Private equity investment in India's coworking segment stood at nearly \$946 million since 2016 amid rising demand for managed flexible office space from corporates, according to Knight Frank.

Real estate consultant Knight Frank India data showed that the coworking segment has attracted \$945.5 million private equity (PE) fund between 2016 and June 2026.

The highest PE fund inflow was seen at \$594.5 million in 2022. In the first half of 2026, the PE investment touched \$30.9 million, surpassing \$24.3 million in the entire 2025 calendar year.

On the rising importance of this segment, the consultant said co-working operators contributed to 24 per cent of the total 48 million sq ft gross office space leasing achieved in January-June 2026 across eight major cities.

The co-working or managed workspace operators take office space from real estate developers to set up their centres. Then, they sub-lease spaces to corporates of all sizes.

Large enterprises have taken 72 per cent of the total seats available in managed workspace centres.

The consultant noted that this indicates that flexible managed office space is no longer primarily associated with freelancers, startups and small businesses. From end-use perspective, global capability centres accounted for 52 per cent of demand.

This showcases that managed office space is increasingly becoming part of the real estate strategy of larger organisations seeking greater flexibility in capacity and location.

There are many managed office space operators listed on the stock exchanges, including WeWork India, Smartworks, Awfis, and IndiQube.

The Executive Centre and Table Space have filed documents with Sebi to launch their initial public offering.

Other major players are Incuspaze, Simpliwork Offices, Urban Vault, 91Springboard, Spring House Workspaces, BHIVE Workspace, 315Work Avenue, The Office Pass, and Hanto Workspaces. (PTI)

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | SEPTEMBER 28, 2026

BUSINESS

13

FMCG growth moderates in June quarter: NielsenIQ

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) sector witnessed a moderation in growth during the June quarter of 2026 amid a broader consumption slowdown, with rural markets recording a 5 per cent decline in volumes, according to a quarterly report by NielsenIQ. The slowdown in the country's FMCG sector, has now widened beyond a handful of categories to a broader basket of products, signalling a more systemic demand slowdown driven by rising input costs and weakening consumer sentiment, it said.

"FMCG slowdown is no

longer confined to core categories. Until Q1, '26, weakness was concentrated in a few categories. By Q2 '26 (June quarter), macro pressure is visible across a wider basket, creating a more systemic slowdown," said the NielsenIQ FMCG Quarterly Snapshot for April-June 2026 (AMJ '26) said.

As many as 68 per cent of FMCG categories registered a decline in the April-June quarter, indicating that consumption pressures have intensified and spread well beyond core categories, the report said.

The report classified FMCG categories into four bands based on the severity of the slowdown, with the impact varying sharply across

product segments.

Only 8 per cent of categories fell under the "Least Impact" band, described as "islands of growth amid macro slowdown". These included vermicelli and noodles, packaged rice, hair oils and liquid toilet soaps.

Another 25 per cent of categories were classified as "Low Impact", indicating muted momentum but relatively stable demand. This group comprised packaged atta, non-refined oils, utensil cleaners, and palmolein oils.

The largest share, at 35 per cent, was in the "Medium Impact" category, where

emerging headwinds were seen having a moderate negative effect on momentum. Iodised salt, biscuits, salty snacks and shampoo were among the products in this band. At the other end, 33 per cent of categories were classified as "Heavy Impact", the most severe band, reflecting strong growth headwinds. Washing powders and liquids, refined oils, detergent cakes and bars, and toilet soaps were among the products in this group, pointing to pressure across home care, personal wash and edible oils segments.

Overall, 68 per cent of FMCG categories fell in the Medium and Heavy Impact bands, pointing to meaningful growth pressure during

the quarter, while only 8 per cent of categories were classified as relatively resilient.

The spread of category-level decline aligns with sharper rural distress, where overall volumes fell 5 per cent against a 2.1 per cent rise in prices, dragging rural FMCG value down 2.9 per cent.

In the June quarter, which dominates rural distribution with an 82 per cent sales share nationally, "dragged rural FMCG into decline", while organised trade sustained urban growth. Its volume was down 6 per cent.

Modern trade and e-commerce continued to post strong volume growth of 17.5 per cent and 34.8 per cent, respectively, with expansion into non-metro markets.

Customer first and nation always SBI's growth mantra: Chairman

KUMAR DIPANKAR
■ New Delhi

Digital first, customer first, nation always' is the philosophy guiding State Bank of India (SBI) as it drives business growth, Chairman of the country's biggest lender C S Setty said.

Talking to the news agency in an interview, Setty said the bank's focus over the past two years has been on strengthening its capital base, deepening its role in the financial sector and building a more digital, customer-centric banking model. Looking back at his tenure, Setty said several of the most visible objectives his team set had been achieved, including capital augmentation, the listing of SBI Mutual Fund and the bank's strategic role in addressing the Yes Bank issue.

"These are the most visible outcomes of my tenure," said Setty, who completed his two years as the bank's chairman last month.

However, he said the more consequential changes were taking place beneath the surface and would strengthen both SBI and the wider banking industry over the longer term.

At the heart of this trans-

formation, he said, is a "digital-first" approach. Setty argued that the rapid adoption of digital payments in India demonstrated how technology can fundamentally change the way people interact with financial institutions.

The same approach, he said, needs to extend across banking. A digital-first banking system, however,

cannot come at the expense of the customer, he said, adding that banks must ensure that customers are protected while carrying out digital transactions and should simultaneously work to improve financial and digital literacy.

The larger objective, he said, should be to help customers achieve meaningful livelihoods rather than viewing banking merely as a series of transactions.

"We cannot be just looking at a transactional approach," he said, emphasising the importance of building long-term relationships with customers, an approach that he said has traditionally been associated with SBI.

This philosophy, he said, is captured in the framework of "digital first, customer first, nation always." Setty acknowledged that the vision

may sound ambitious, but argued that it is achievable.

SBI, he said, has demonstrated over the past seven decades the role a large public sector bank can play in supporting the real economy.

"We would like to continue that journey," he said, signalling that SBI's next phase will seek to combine its traditional relationship-led banking model with digital innovation and a broader developmental mandate.

He further said SBI's total business could double to around Rs 200 lakh crore by 2030, when the bank celebrates its platinum jubilee, given its current growth trajectory.

SBI came into existence on July 1, 1955, through an Act of Parliament, which, among other things, provided for the transfer of the undertaking of the Imperial Bank of

India. The country's biggest lender crossed the landmark of Rs 100 lakh crore business, which is an aggregate of total loans and advances in the second quarter of the last financial year.

This rose further to Rs 110.01 lakh crore by the end of June 2026.

Whether the bank had set a specific target for its platinum jubilee year, Setty said there was no formal milestone, but the bank's growth trajectory could take its total business to Rs 170-180 lakh crore and potentially as high as Rs 200 lakh crore by 2030.

"We don't have any milestone, but if you take the current growth rate, I think we should be around Rs 170-180 lakh crore, or maybe reaching Rs 200 lakh crore. That would be another important milestone," he said. (PTI)

NSE pushes electronic gold

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has empanelled Augmont Gold Tech, a subsidiary of Augmont Enterprises as a key partner for promoting electronic gold receipts, aimed at deepening India's organised gold market.

The strategic partnership is designed to simplify the creation and extinguishment of electronic gold receipts (EGR) and promote their trading on the exchange, NSE said in a statement on Saturday.

Under the arrangement, Augmont will provide technical and on-ground support for the development of the EGR product, drawing on its experience across the gold value chain.

The partnership will facilitate conversion of physical gold into EGRs and their subsequent conversion back into physical gold within the regulated ecosystem.

EGRs are dematerialised securities representing ownership of physical gold stored in Sebi-accredited vaults and held electronically through depositories. Each receipt is fully backed by physical gold and can be traded on the exchange.

The exchange said the partnership is aimed at strengthening the gold trading ecosystem by improving price discovery and market participa-

tion while enhancing transparency and trust among jewellers, refiners, traders and institutional investors.

"By combining NSE's robust technology and liquidity framework with Augmont's rich experience and on-the-ground presence across the gold value chain, we are simplifying the creation and extinguishment of EGRs and making gold investment more accessible to investors across the nation," said NSE Chief Business Development Officer Sriram Krishnan.

Augmont Enterprises Whole-Time Director Ketan Kothari said, "We aim to make the conversion between physical and electronic gold simpler, faster and more transparent for the trade and investors alike."

EGRs also allow investors to participate in the gold market in smaller denominations, while offering liquidity and flexibility similar to other financial instruments held in demat form, NSE said.

Mahindra & Mahindra weighs SUV price hike amid rising commodity costs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mahindra & Mahindra is weighing another price increase across its SUV portfolio amid recent commodity price increases, with a decision expected in the next couple of weeks, CEO Automotive Division, Mahindra Group Nalinikanth Gollagunta said.

In an interview with PTI, Gollagunta said the company has already taken three price increases this year -- in January, April and July, with the July increase being about 2.7 per cent on sports utility vehicles (SUVs).

"We're watching it very closely. As you know, we've already taken three increases -- one in January, one in April, and a fairly significant one in July, about 2.7 per cent on SUVs. That said, it's something that can be very dynamic, so we continue to watch it," he said.

Elaborating further, Gollagunta said, "We'll probably take a call in the next couple of weeks on whether we need a price increase... I can't say we will or we won't, but it's something we're looking at closely, given the recent price increases on commodities".

He said recent price

increases across the auto industry have not affected customer inquiries or bookings, with vehicles still priced below pre-GST levels.

"No, primarily for a couple of reasons -- we're still well below pre-GST prices, so demand continues to be quite intact and robust at this point," Gollagunta said.

On the festive season, he said demand should be strong for Mahindra as well as across the industry, helped by prices remaining below pre-GST (Goods and Services Tax) levels and a refreshed product portfolio.

"Festive should be very good for us, and across the industry, for a couple of reasons. We've had inflationary pressures, but the reality is the GST price cuts from last year are holding us all well below pre-GST prices,

even with the inflationary price increases we've made over the past year or so," he said. On hybrid technology, Gollagunta said Mahindra remains focused on electric vehicles and would adapt if the regulatory environment changes.

"We're very clear in our minds -- EV is the end state the country is heading towards, and that's also what the government has made clear to the industry. If you look at the CAFE (Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency) norms, there's a very clear differentiation between the benefits given to an EV versus a hybrid.

So our focus is on EVs to that extent. If the regulatory environment changes, we have the ability to adapt, but at this point our focus is primarily on EVs," he shared.

On capacity, Gollagunta said Mahindra currently has about 60,000 units of monthly ICE (internal combustion engine) capacity and about 8,000 units of EV (electric vehicle) capacity, and is largely delivering to those levels.

"The next set of capacity increases will happen at the end of March, early April -- the 60,000 ICE capacity will go to 70,000, and the EV capacity of 8,000 will go to 12,000. So, where we are now, we're at 68,000, and we'll go to 84,000 in about six months," he said.

Gollagunta also said the company has several product refreshes and two major launches lined up over the next two quarters.

"We'll have a set of refreshes coming -- some of this we've already talked about. We have about 5 (product) refreshes; a few have already happened, and two or three more are coming up. Other than that, we have two major launches coming within the next couple of quarters -- that's also why we've added the capacity. We'll have one major launch on the ICE side and one major launch on the EV side, both happening within the next two quarters," he said.

Bullion faces choppy spell amid US data

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gold and silver are expected to face another choppy spell, with US data, West Asia tensions and their impact on crude prices set to test bullion sentiment during a holiday-shortened week, analysts said.

Market participants will shift their focus to the US data calendar, with consumer confidence, GDP and PCE inflation readings, alongside Eurozone inflation.

Additionally, manufacturing PMIs, speeches from Federal Reserve officials and the US non-farm payrolls report will provide further cues for bullion sentiment, they added.

Geopolitical uncertainty will continue to play a role, particularly the US-Iran standoff, after US President Donald

Trump said that he rejected Tehran's proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz within a week and resume nuclear talks in exchange for lifting the naval blockade.

Commodity markets would remain closed on Friday for Mahatma Gandhi Jayanti.

"The broader outlook remains cautious with volatility likely to stay elevated as the market will closely focus on the upcoming US nonfarm

payrolls and unemployment data, which will be crucial in determining expectations around the Federal Reserve's October policy decision," Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), gold futures for October delivery fell ₹3,500, or nearly 2.3 per cent, last week to settle at ₹1.5 lakh per 10 grams. Silver futures declined

₹6,907, or 3 per cent, to ₹24.34 per kilogram.

"Gold remained highly volatile last week, trading within the ₹1.5-1.54 lakh per 10 grams range and ending lower by more than 2 per cent as profit booking from higher levels continued as markets increasingly priced in the possibility of another Fed rate hike in October," Trivedi said. The recovery remained limited as traders cut positions at elevated levels.

A sustained rise in the dollar index above 101 could add to the pressure on gold, as a stronger dollar tends to reduce demand for dollar-denominated bullion.

In global markets, Comex gold futures for December delivery dropped \$103.7, or 2.34 per cent, last week to USD 4,321.2 per ounce. Silver fell \$2.35, or 3.5 per cent, to \$64.80

an ounce in New York.

"Gold futures traded in a range for most trading sessions last week but overall remained under selling pressure with international prices closing around \$4,300 per ounce," said Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd. Silver futures also ended with a weekly loss following gold and consolidation and correction in industrial metals, he said.

The pressure is not coming from currencies alone. US 10-year Treasury yields have climbed to their highest since 2007, while 30-year yields are near 2004 highs. Higher long-term yields tend to dent demand for assets such as gold and silver even as West Asia and Russia-Ukraine tensions persist.

Mobile phone retailers to protest against UPI MDR charges on October 2

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mobile phone retailers across India plan to observe October 2 as "No UPI Day" in protest against 0.4 per cent merchant discount rate charges on UPI transactions, a senior official of industry body AIMRA said.

The Government has introduced a 0.4 per cent fee on UPI transfers exceeding ₹2,000 to merchants from October 15, while exempting person-to-person transactions as well as small payments from any charges.

"The All India Mobile Retailers Association (AIMRA) has called for a 'NO UPI DAY' on October 2, 2026, to highlight the concerns of mobile retailers regarding the 0.4 per cent Merchant Discount Rate

(MDR) applicable to eligible merchant UPI transactions," AIMRA Vice President and President for Delhi NCR region, Tarvinder Singh, said in a statement.

He said retailers will symbolically cover UPI QR Codes with black cloth and refrain from accepting UPI payments on Gandhi Jayanti.

According to a representation sent to Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman by AIMRA, the move to impose MDR on UPI will lead to an immediate net monthly loss

of ₹2,000 to ₹12,000 for a small retailer processing ₹5 lakh to ₹30 lakh monthly via UPI, thereby wiping out a substantial portion of their net income.

The mobile retailers' body estimates that 0.4 per cent MDR will impose an unsustainable burden of approximately ₹40 crore per month and nearly ₹500 crore per annum on small mobile retailers across India.

"If We Want Digital India, UPI Must Remain Zero MDR. This is not a protest against UPI or Digital India. Our concern is the additional financial burden being placed on merchants who accept digital payments. If we want Digital India to grow further, digital payments should remain affordable for the entire retail ecosystem.

ITC steps up dairy push in East, bets on branded milk

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

ITC is strengthening its presence in the fresh dairy segment in Eastern India through its flagship Aashirvaad brand, betting on rising demand for branded milk and value-added dairy products across Bihar, West Bengal and Jharkhand.

The diversified conglomerate, which entered the fresh dairy business in 2018 with the launch of Aashirvaad milk in Bihar and later expanded to West Bengal and Jharkhand, has emerged as the second-largest dairy player in Bihar with a lineup ranging from fresh milk to curd, paneer, lassi and Mishti Doi.

As part of its expansion strategy, ITC has tailored its dairy portfolio to regional tastes, local consumption patterns and evolving consumer preference for quality-assured dairy products.

When asked about expansion to other regions, Hemant Malik, Chief Executive Officer, Foods Division, and Executive Director, ITC, said Eastern



India will remain a key focus market for the company's dairy expansion plans, which offers significant headroom for expansion.

"East is one of the most promising growth markets for the dairy category and will be central to our growth strategy in the coming years," Malik told PTL. For instance, in Bihar, over 80 per cent of consumers purchase loose milk, which presents a "compelling opportunity" to transition households to branded value-added dairy solutions that ensure quality, safety, and consistency, he said.

"In South India, consumers moved to branded curd over

a decade ago, and we wanted to enable a similar transition in Bihar. With our pouch curd offerings, we are helping consumers shift to branded curd that delivers assured quality and consistency, backed by the trust of ITC," said Malik.

Moreover, in the value-added segment, ITC is evaluating innovative and healthier dessert options as it seeks to broaden its portfolio beyond products such as Mishti Doi. For ITC, the dairy business is "one of the fastest-growing categories witnessing high double-digit growth".

It currently operates dairy manufacturing facilities at Munger, Patna, Muzaffarpur

and Gaya in Bihar, Ranchi in Jharkhand, and Howrah and Bardhaman in West Bengal.

As part of Project Gomukh, ITC works with over 40,000 dairy farmers and directly procures milk from dairy farmers. "The overarching objective of the project is to increase milk productivity and improve the quality of milk, while empowering rural farmers and increasing their income," it said.

ITC, which aspires to become India's leading FMCG player, has expanded brand Aashirvaad beyond wheat flour into staples, spices and fresh foods, and even the frozen category, aiming to double consumer spends to over ₹20,000 crore in the next five years.

According to the company's latest annual report, its 'Aashirvaad Svasti' fresh dairy portfolio maintained strong growth during FY26, aided by the strengthening of its premium milk variant 'Select' and robust growth in value-added products such as curd, paneer, Mishti Doi and lassi.

Assam CM Himanta reviews preparations for Hazarika centenary celebrations in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday visited Bharat Mandapam in the national Capital to review the facilities and preparations for the grand closing ceremony of the birth centenary celebrations of Bharat Ratna Dr Bhupen Hazarika.

The grand finale and closing ceremony of the centenary celebrations of the legendary singer, composer and cultural icon will be held at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, on November 29, 2026. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to attend the landmark event.

During his visit, the Chief Minister inspected the halls and reviewed the arrangements being made for the grand finale. Senior officials briefed him on the preparations and various aspects of the programme.

An exhibition showcasing the life, works and times of Bharat Ratna Dr Bhupen Hazarika, the doyen of Assamese and Indian culture, will also be organ-



ised at the venue as part of the centenary celebrations. The exhibition will highlight his remarkable artistic journey, contribution to Indian music and culture, and enduring legacy.

"We are curating an unforgettable tribute, one truly befitting the legacy of Sudhakantha," Dr Sarma said in a post on X after his visit to Bharat Mandapam.

The centenary celebrations seek to commemorate the extraordinary life and legacy of Bharat Ratna Dr Bhupen Hazarika, whose music transcended linguistic

and geographical boundaries and established him as one of India's most influential cultural figures. His compositions and songs reflected themes of humanity, social harmony, fraternity and national integration.

The grand finale in the national capital will bring together eminent personalities, artists, cultural practitioners and admirers of Dr Hazarika from across the country for a fitting culmination of the centenary celebrations.

The event will also provide a platform to showcase

Assam's rich cultural heritage and the unparalleled contribution of Bharat Ratna Dr Bhupen Hazarika to India's cultural landscape.

Additional Chief Secretary B Kalyan Chakravarty, Commissioner & Secretary, Information and Public Relations, Padmapani Bora, Resident Commissioner, Assam Bhawan, Kavitha Padmanabhan, MLA Taranga Gogoi, Director, Information and Public Relations, Manabendra Dev Ray, among other senior officials, were present during the inspection.

Renewable Energy India Expo 2026 to unlock ₹2,800 crore investment in bioenergy sector: IBA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Biogas Association (IBA) on Sunday said the Renewable Energy India Expo (REI) 2026, scheduled for next month, is poised to unlock over ₹2,800 crore in fresh investment for India's bioenergy sector.

This year, the spotlight is firmly on biogas as a game-changer for India's green growth, an IBA statement said.

This momentum was further strengthened by the Union Cabinet approval of the Rs 23,731 crore GOBARDhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) National Circular Bioenergy Scheme in August 2026, which took effect on September 1, 2026.

The REI 2026 is scheduled from October 22 to 24, 2026, at the India Expo Mart & Centre,

Greater Noida. The ₹2,800 crore investment pipeline expected from the Expo represents nearly 12 per cent of the ₹23,731 crore GOBARDhan scheme outlay.

By bringing together investors, developers, technology providers and policy makers, REI 2026 can help turn policy momentum into scalable projects and support the government's ambition of nearly tenfold growth in domestic CBG production, the statement added.

This year's Bio-Energy Pavilion, powered by the IBA, is set to be the largest ever, featuring 35 per cent more exhibitors than 2025 and strong participation from global technology leaders, startups, and policy-makers.

Supported by the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) and the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas



(MoPNG), the pavilion will showcase innovations in waste-to-energy, CBG technologies, co-digestion models, and digital monitoring solutions, the statement said.

"India is no longer looking at

biogas as just a rural solution. It is now a cornerstone of the clean energy economy, reducing carbon emissions, supporting farmers, fuelling transport, and enabling green hydrogen. With the GOBARDhan scheme provid-

ing long-term pricing certainty and offtake assurance, REI 2026 will demonstrate how the sector is scaling from pilot projects to nationwide impact," said A R Shukla, President, Indian Biogas Association.

The GOBARDhan scheme, to be implemented till 2035-36, aims to increase domestic compressed biogas (CBG) production nearly tenfold, mobilise large-scale private investment, and create a vibrant circular bioeconomy across the country.

Key features include an administered CBG price of ₹2,110 per MMBtu, assured offtake mandates for CNG and PNG segments, capital assistance of up to ₹2 crore per TPD for greenfield CBG plants, and dedicated support for pipeline infrastructure and credit guarantees.

The three-day REI Expo 2026 is expected to attract over 70,000

participants from across the globe, covering sectors like bioenergy, solar, wind, hydrogen, e-mobility, and energy storage.

"With India's potential to generate over 62 million tons of CBG annually, we can cut down fuel imports, create thousands of rural and urban jobs, and build a truly circular economy. The GOBARDhan scheme's pricing support, capital assistance, and offtake mandates have addressed the sector's biggest blockers," IBA Chairman Gaurav Kedia said.

The IBA is the first and largest nationwide and professional biogas association for stakeholders of the biogas industry, including Technology providers, Project developers, Plant operators and planners of biogas plants, and representatives from public policy, science and research in India.

Delhi jewellery and gem fair 2026 begins

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lok Sabha MP Praveen Khandelwal on Saturday inaugurated the 14th edition of the three-day Delhi Jewellery & Gem Fair (DJGF) 2026, organised by Informa Markets.

Khandelwal stressed on the need for upskilling the manpower and adoption of newer technologies in the jewellery sector. He noted the sector's export potential and highlighted that rising gold prices are reshaping consumer demand toward lightweight, design-driven, and studded jewellery while strengthening the push from "Vocal for Local" to global competitiveness.



Lok Sabha MP Praveen Khandelwal inaugurated 14th edition of the three-day Delhi Jewellery & Gem Fair (DJGF) 2026

The MP also underscored Free Trade Agreements potential in pitching India's ambitious targets toward a \$100 billion export and a \$30 trillion economy by 2047.

The DJGF has brought together over 650 exhibitors, 3,000 plus jewellery brands and more than 150,000 designs under one roof. The event is witnessing participation from jewellery manufacturers, wholesalers, retailers, distributors, exporters and allied industry professionals from across India.

Petronet to pay 1% of profit as commission to directors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Petronet LNG Ltd, India's biggest gas importer, has sought shareholders' approval to continue payment of commission to its directors, capped at 1 per cent of annual profits, for another five years from financial year 2026-27 to 2030-31.

The proposal, contained in the notice for the company's forthcoming general meeting, seeks approval for distribution of a sum not exceeding 1 per cent per annum of profits calculated under Section 198 of the Companies Act, 2013, among the directors in such amounts and proportions as may be decided by the board from time to time.

Shareholders had last approved the commission arrangement at the annual general meeting held on September 28, 2021, for FY22 to FY26. The earlier approvals for similar payments were granted in 2007, 2011 and 2016, according to the shareholder notice.

The company said the proposed continuation was

being sought in view of its "healthy financial position".

For the fiscal year ended March 31, 2026, Petronet paid its CEO Akshay Kumar Singh and other directors a commission of ₹26.5 lakh each, according to the annual report. They had received a commission of ₹25.5 lakh in the previous fiscal year.

The commission took Singh's total remuneration in 2025-26 to ₹3.64 crore, up from ₹3.03 crore in the previous financial year.



Independent directors on the company board also got ₹10 lakh each as commission on profit, besides the sitting fees. They were paid ₹9.75 lakh commission in previous 2024-25 fiscal.

The actual commission paid to whole-time directors, including the managing director and CEO, and independent directors has remained well below the statutory ceiling, according to the company.

CIJW school conducts seminar on northeast India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Aizawl

Counter Insurgency and Jungle Warfare School, Vairengte, conducted a two-day seminar on "Cultural Diplomacy, Ecosystem of Tribals and Indigenous People, Population-Centric Engagement and Way Ahead for Northeast India" on 23-24 September 2026.

The seminar brought together eminent moderators and speakers from NIT Silchar, Assam University, Central University of Jharkhand, Mizoram University, North-Eastern Hill University, Tripura University, the Indian Institute of Public Administration, and DIPR, DRDO, along with army officers, academicians, and students. The three thematic sessions brought academic research, professional experience and local understanding onto a common platform.

The first thematic session, "Cultural Diplomacy & Ecosystem of Tribals and Indigenous People," explored the cultural strengths of Northeast



India and their potential for strengthening people-to-people linkages. The second thematic session, "Population-Centric Engagement," placed trust at the centre of meaningful engagement with local populations.

The final thematic session, "Economic & Technological Pathways & Way Ahead," focused on future development opportunities for the region. Participants analysed extensive comparative economic data and offered suggestions the strengthen economic

development in Northeast India. The technological dimension highlighted existing Government technology initiatives while also proposing new technology-enabled solutions to improve governance, accessibility, service delivery, and development outcomes.

An interesting progression of ideas also emerged through the two days. The discourse began with the 3 Cs — Connectivity, Culture and Community, emphasising that regional engagement must go beyond physical connectivity alone.

As the discussion widened towards cross-border linkages and cooperation, the thought expanded to the 5 Cs — Culture, Community, Connectivity, Cooperation and Confidence.

In his closing remarks, Maj Gen Kulvir Singh, SM, PhD, Commandant, CIJW School, carried this progression further into a comprehensive 7 Cs framework - Culture, Community, Connectivity, Capacity, Commerce, Confidence and Convergence. He also underscored inclusive growth and meaningful participation of women as essential elements in shaping the way ahead for Northeast India.

This 3-5-7 progression captured the broad journey of the seminar-from cultural understanding and community engagement, through cooperation and confidence, towards capacity building, economic opportunity and convergence of efforts.

The seminar strengthened Army-academia interaction and generated practical perspectives towards an inclusive, people-centric and progressive future for Northeast India.

GDA showcases Ghaziabad's development vision at UP International trade show

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Greater Noida

The Ghaziabad Development Authority (GDA) is showcasing the city's ongoing transformation and future growth potential at the Uttar Pradesh International Trade Show (UPITS)-2026, being held at the India Expo Centre & Mart, Greater Noida, from September 25 to 29.

Through an attractively designed exhibition stall, GDA has presented a comprehensive picture of Ghaziabad's ongoing and proposed development projects, highlighting planned urban expansion, modern

infrastructure, improved connectivity, residential development, sports facilities, green spaces and urban beautification.

The fourth edition of UPITS-2026 provides a major platform to showcase Uttar Pradesh's industrial strength, development potential, and investment opportunities to visitors, investors, and international delegates. According to official information, the event features more than 2,400 exhibitors, over 550 international buyers and participation from 85 countries.

HarNandiPuram: A New Chapter in Planned Urban Development

The ambitious HarNandiPuram Residential Scheme occupies a prominent place in GDA's exhibition. Proposed across approximately 501 hectares, the scheme envisages well-planned residential sectors supported by a network of roads, green spaces, parks, civic amenities and improved connectivity.

International Cricket Stadium to Strengthen Ghaziabad's Sports Infrastructure

The proposed International Cricket Stadium in Raj Nagar Extension is another key attraction at the GDA stall. GDA has prepared



a preliminary design and cost assessment for the proposed stadium, while the process of joint development between GDA and the Uttar Pradesh Cricket Association (UPCA) is also being pursued.

Hapur Chungi Flyover to Enhance Traffic Connectivity

Improving traffic movement and strengthening urban connectivity are key priorities in GDA's infrastructure plans. The proposed four-lane flyover and service/slip roads at Hapur Chungi have therefore been prominently featured at the exhibition. GDA is also showcasing its initiatives to create new recreational, cultural

and knowledge-based public spaces. These include Anand Vatika, Viksit Bharat Experience Park, Sanskriti Darshan Park and the Ramayana-themed Park/Anand Vatika.

GDA's vision is centred on planned urban expansion, enhanced connectivity, sustainable and green development, improved civic infrastructure and modern public amenities. Through its participation in UPITS-2026, GDA is presenting Ghaziabad's development journey and future opportunities to visitors, investors and delegates from across India and around the world.

 BRIEFLY

Ancy Sojan clinches long jump silver at Asian Games



India's Ancy Sojan led for a major part of the competition before settling for the silver medal in the women's long jump competition at the Asian Games here on Sunday.

Ancy recorded a best jump of 6.53m to finish behind Huang Yingying of China, who produced a late 6.55m jump to snatch gold.

Earlier, India's Harita Bhadra clinched the bronze medal in the women's 200m, clocking 23.20 seconds in the final.

Bhadra finished third, just ahead of Japan's Ido Abigeirufuka, who clocked 23.21 seconds.

There was, however, heartbreak for Ancy's compatriot Shaili Singh, who missed out on a bronze medal in the women's long jump final after China's Mengyi Tan produced a 6.46m effort to move ahead of the Indian jumper. (PTI)

Squash: Silver lining, but no gold again for India at Asiad



India's long wait for an individual squash gold at the Asian Games stretched on Sunday as young guns Anahat Singh and Abhay Singh were outplayed by seasoned Malaysian opponents and settled for silver medals after straight-game defeats.

On a rain-soaked day that added to the gloom around the Indian camp, Abhay, ranked 24th in the world, found defending champion Ng Eain Yow a class apart as the Malaysian produced a controlled, tactically astute performance to win 11-9, 11-5, 11-5 in 44 minutes.

Anahat, 18, had an equally frustrating afternoon, going down 4-11, 4-11, 7-11 against Malaysia's world No. 5 and defending champion Sivasangari Subramaniam in just 27 minutes. The result means that both Anahat and Abhay missed out on securing berths for 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, where the game will make debut. The Indians will now have to look for other route. (PTI)

Asiad Hockey: Indian women to play Korea in semifinal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kakamigahara

Sunelita Toppo scored a brace as the Indian women's hockey team trounced Singapore 7-0 in their final Pool B match to set up the Asian Games semifinal against Korea here Sunday.

India topped Pool B with five wins from as many games. The semifinal is scheduled for September 30.

Skipper Salima Tete (17th minute), Sunelita (22nd, 24th), Lalremsiami (26th), Rutuja Dadoso Pisal (29th), Nikki Pradhan (35th) and Deepika (55th) scored for India.

Defending champions and reigning Olympic silver medalist China will take on hosts Japan in the other semifinal.

Unfancied Singapore gave India a run for their money in the first quarter even



though the Salima Tete-led side dominated the proceedings.

Singapore were particularly brilliant in their penalty corner defence as they

denied India as many as eight penalty corners.

The play was mostly in the Singapore half with India mounting attacks after attacks and in the process

Salima finally gave India the lead with a fine field goal.

In the 22nd minute, Sunelita doubled India's lead scoring from a botched up penalty corner effort.

Sunelita again registered her name in the score sheet, again directing in a Deepika's flick from a penalty corner from a variation.

Lalremsiami then extended the lead deflecting in another Deepika flick from a penalty corner three inutes later.

Rutuja made the scorelin 5-0 with a fine field goal in the 30th minute.

But the Indians were quote sloppy from penalty corners as they converted just three from 15 they earned in the first two quarters.

The Indians continued to earn penalty comers a galore but failed to convert them from direct tries.

Four minutes into the third quarter, India extended their lead through Nikki Pradhan, who pushed home a loose ball from another messed up set piece.

The Indians secured five more penalty corners in the third quarter but failed to convert them as the Singaporeans defended in numbers.

For records, India had 24 penalty corners in the first three quarters out of which they converted just three, that too from variations and a rebound.

Five minutes from the hooter, India secured two back-to-back penalty corners and Deepika finally scored with a powerful flick to the left of the Singapore goalkeeper.

India had another set piece a minute later but wasted the chance. (PTI)

Indian boxers storm into Asiad semis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nishio (Japan)

Indian boxers Parveen Hooda, Ankush Panghal and Narender Berwal assured the country of three medals with dominant quarterfinal wins at the Asian Games here on Sunday, while Sachin Siwach's campaign ended in the last eight stage.

Parveen defeated world championships silver medalist Navbakhor Khamidova of Uzbekistan by a 5-0 margin to move into the women's 65kg semifinals.

Narender (+90kg) added another medal to his bronze from the previous edition after forcing the referee to stop his quarterfinal against Thailand's Adthapong Saengtpe in less than two minutes. The Indian super heavyweight unleashed a barrage of heavy blows on his Thai opponent, forcing the referee to give Saengtpe three standing counts before stopping the contest.

Ankush, who won Commonwealth Games gold last month in Glasgow, notched a 5-0 unanimous decision win over Tajikistan's Nekruz Salimov in the men's



80kg quarterfinal. It was, however, the end of the road for Commonwealth Games champion Sachin, who went down 0-5 to local favourite Shunsuke Kitamoto of Japan in the men's 60kg quarterfinal. It was the Haryana boxer's first bout of the ongoing edition as she had received a walkover in the previous round, but Parveen showed no signs of rust, expertly landing a flurry of combination punches on Khamidova.

"I'm feeling very good. My coaches made a plan for how to fight. I managed the distance well and focused on counter-punching. That was our strategy for the bout," she said after the win.

Parveen's bronze medal from the previous edition was taken away after the International Testing Agency (ITA) suspended her for 22 months for a whereabouts failure. Since returning from her suspension late last year, Parveen has moved up from 57kg to 65kg. She was one of only three boxers who failed to finish on the podium in last month's Commonwealth Games.

"I'm getting my confidence back. Being away from your sport for so long makes you doubt yourself and wonder how you'll perform in the future. "But now I feel confident again and want to achieve even more than what I lost during that time

away," she added.

Making his Asian Games debut, Ankush put up a dominant display to outclass Salimov and book his place in the semifinals.

"In the first two rounds I boxed at long range, and I had already won those two rounds. After that the opponent was just passing the time," Ankush said.

"There was no difficulty at all. I am not satisfied with my performance. I have already secured a medal. But it doesn't matter because I am looking ahead," he added.

The Haryana boxer started strongly, landing clean singles, including a straight left and a right hook, to keep Salimov on the back foot. The Tajik tried to counter, but his punches lacked accuracy and impact to trouble Ankush, who took opening round on all five cards.<

Ankush maintained the pressure in the second round, continuing to attack and landing a steady stream of punches. Salimov tried to close the distance and find openings on the counter, but Ankush was quick to respond and largely kept control of the exchanges.

As injuries pick up, questions on selection

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ Nagoya

The list of injured Indian track and field athletes at the ongoing Asian Games grew longer on Sunday after 400m hurdler Yashas Palaksha pulled up midway through his heat race, raising questions about how these athletes were selected in the first place, and who will be held accountable.



Yashas did not start in the Indian Athletics Series Final held on September 10 in New Delhi where almost all the Asian Games-bound members participated. There was speculation that Yashas was carrying an injury.

Woman 100m hurdler Jyothi Yarraji and triple jumper Praveen Chithravel, who also did not take part in the New Delhi meet, pulled out on Saturday due to injuries. Yarraji was carrying knee stress while Chithravel was struggling with a calf muscle pull.

They were, however, cleared after their coaches

gave assurances to the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) about their fitness by showing medical certificates.

On Sunday, Yashas pulled up with an apparent hamstring injury even before clearing the first hurdle in his 400m hurdles heat, leading to a DNF (Did Not Finish) status. "His injury has been assessed by the team doctors," an Indian team coach said. On Saturday, Yarraji pulled out before her 100m hurdle heat race after "feeling pain" during warm-up. Chithravel went for his first attempt but could not complete his jump, leading to leaving the pit holding his calf. He was later taken off in wheelchair, and he got NM (No mark) status. (PTI)

DAILY SUDOKU

	8			1		6	5
4		7			3		
	2		4				
					3		6
	7		5	2		8	
1			9				
				7		4	
		5			2		8
8	4		3			9	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.

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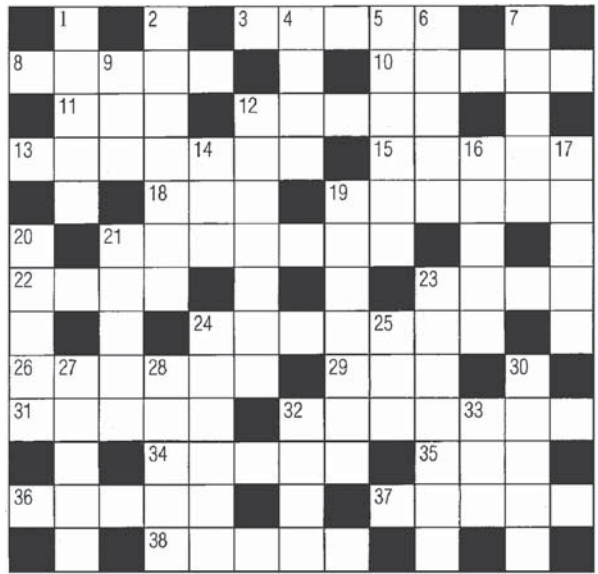
SOLUTION (26.9.26)

3	5	2	8	7	1	6	4	9
8	9	7	6	2	4	1	5	3
6	4	1	9	5	3	2	8	7
7	3	8	5	1	6	4	9	2
9	2	6	4	8	7	3	1	5
5	1	4	2	3	9	7	6	8
1	8	9	7	6	2	5	3	4
4	7	3	1	9	5	8	2	6
2	6	5	3	4	8	9	7	1

No. SS2264 Distribution: www.kingfeatures.com

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

MONDAY | SEPTEMBER 28, 2026



ACROSS

- A mine rediscovered in a Welsh strait (5)
- Girl to do wrong with, in a deluge (5)
- Is such a coat dressy? (5)
- Intend to go first class to Maidenhead (3)
- Got together again for just so long (5)
- He's a bit freakish in his wild way (7)
- Powerless to revise the rent for one (5)
- A traffic stopper in the road around central Harlesden (3)
- Pictures, I see, from the sciences (6)
- The same again, and not so much of it! (7)
- Plunder from Waterloo terminus (4)

DOWN

- Blare loudly at a politician (5)
- Such cakes are black but not burnt (7)
- Regarded as rich after one short day (4)
- A fair touring around, note, covers a lot of ground! (6)
- I, a Frenchman, get the girl (5)
- Success at twenty? (5)
- What the poilu has to put on his hair (3)
- Average sized Scandinavian fruits? (7)
- Fireplace salesman? (3)
- What the last man did? (5)
- Majestically, they could have been stars (5)
- Frowned when a beastly female

- What a chap might call an expensive woman (4)
- Smothered with water? (7)
- Stiffeners for bald-headed people (6)
- Highball! (3)
- One's personal space (5)
- Cause of rash effects in bed? (7)
- Very formal but not Blimpish (5)
- Arboreal monarch (3)
- Traditionally the fare for an identical triplet? (5)
- Exhorted the rude to reform and be good hearted (5)
- Adorns parts of vessels (5)

- entered the vehicle (7)
- For batsmen, they can come in pairs (5)
- Norma's terrible Italian (5)
- They've been given credit for maybe extravagant things (7)
- Urge to chuck teacher into the river (6)
- Having no central heating is negative (3)
- Never the left sock (5)
- Corrected in crude style (5)
- Dogs said to interest mountaineers (5)
- Old devil at the police station (4)
- Having left at some stage, he may be back in jug (3)

Archery: Indian compound teams enter semifinals in Asian Games

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nagoya

India made a strong start to their Asian Games archery campaign as both the men's and women's compound teams marched into the semifinals along with the recurve and mixed teams with a string of convincing victories here on Sunday.

The men's compound team of Kushal Dalal, Sahil Jadhav and Ganesh Mani Ratnam began the competition with a 235-215 win over the UAE in the round of 16 before edging Bhutan 235-232 in the quarterfinals. The women's compound trio of Jyothi Surekha Vennam, Chikitha Taniparthi and Prithika Pradeep also registered two wins, defeating Mongolia 238-223 in the round of 16 and



Kazakhstan 233-230 in the quarterfinals.

Both Indian compound teams will face South Korea in the semifinals on September 30. In the men's recurve section, Dhiraj Bommadevara and Sanjay Bhoge opened with a 5-1 win over the Philippines before registering another identical victory to seal their place in the semifinals.

The women's recurve team

of Kirti and Kumkum also enjoyed a dominant run, blanking Mongolia and Chinese Taipei 6-0 in their respective matches to advance to the last four.

Later in the recurve mixed team event, Dhiraj Bommadevara and Kumkum defeated the UAE 6-0 before producing an identical scoreline against Vietnam to book their semifinal berth.

The compound mixed team of Chikitha Taniparthi and Sahil Jadhav also made it through, beating Mongolia 160-146 and Kazakhstan 159-154 in their two matches. India had swept all five available gold medals in compound archery at the Hangzhou Asian Games, held in 2023, and will look to maintain their dominance in the discipline in Japan.

Sindhu criticises badminton scheduling after playing three matches in 24 hours

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ Nagoya

Ace Indian shuttler PV Sindhu on Sunday expressed her displeasure at playing three singles matches in a span of 24 hours, saying the cramped Asian Games badminton scheduling "was not really well organised" and does not give enough recovery time.

Sindhu was scheduled to play two matches on Saturday, with the second match ending after midnight. She then returned to the court on Sunday for her quarterfinal match against Chen Yufei of China which Sindhu lost.

"Not really, because the scheduling was not really well organised is what I feel," said Sindhu when asked if she had ever played two matches in any major championships earlier.

"We literally slept really late and then coming back in the morning (on Sunday), playing two matches in a day. Recovery



is the most important priority."

The two-time Olympic medalist played her second round match in the afternoon of Saturday. Her third round match ended after midnight (around 1am local time on Sunday). Her quarterfinal match started around 1:30pm local time on Sunday.

Asked how she prepared herself mentally to play three matches in 24 hours, Sindhu said, "It's more than mentally preparing, you need to recover. Even though you think you are

doing good, physically you might not be able to go there or you might not be able to play."

"When there are long rallies, definitely yes, recovery. When you had a good thing, you would automatically (go) but your legs don't move."

"But I think apart from that it was a good game overall but it's just that the scheduling should have been a bit better." Shuttlar Unnati Hooda was also not happy with scheduling as many players had to play more than one matches in a day. (PTI)

Kohli and Gill 100s, Kuldeep’s magic give India win over WI in 1st ODI

G UNNIKRIISHNAN
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Maestro Virat Kohli and skipper Shubman Gill displayed their mastery in 50-over format with virtuoso hundreds as India subdued the West Indies by eight wickets in the first ODI here on Sunday.

India now lead the three-match series 1-0, after Kohli (139 not out, 10x4, 9x6) and Gill (110, 107b) milked 150 runs for the second wicket to help the hosts scale down 296 in 41.4 overs, ending up at 300 for two. West Indies too had a centurion in their ranks in Justin Greaves, but his maiden effort - 101 - is now destined to remain as an afterthought as it was already overshadowed by Kuldeep

Yadav's excellent four-wicket burst. But even Greaves will not complain about that after remaining a reverent student during India's innings, watching a GOAT and another batter looking to attain that status working in tandem.

Here's a quick look at the stats: Gill crunched his 10th ODI hundred and Kohli steamrolled Windies for his 55th ton, and 86th in international cricket.

Additionally, Kohli also became the second batter in history to register 15000 runs in one-dayers after Sachin Tendulkar.

All these are heady numbers but their batting on the day was even more so - in haste but not in hate.

After scoring 75 runs for the opening wicket with Rohit



Sharma, Gill's innings blossomed in the company of Kohli. Gill exploited the reprieve he received on 11, when substitute Keemo Paul dropped him off Jayden Seales, to the hilt, first bringing a 50 off 49 balls and the next 50 in 47 balls.

In the interim, there were a litany of shots - a square cut and punch through the covers of Alzarri Joseph, a square cut off Seales and six

and four combination off spinner Gudakesh Motie.

They were shots played with the subtle hands of a butterfly curator, and even the bowlers would not have felt the anguish.

Kohli, on the other hand, did what he has been doing all these years - running hard and then unfurling an array of dazzling shots, his blue-print while conducting ODI chases. Just that this time, he showed an increasing appetite for sixes. The only false shot in his innings was a top-edged pull off Joseph that went for a six over the stumper's head, and in one way it hinted that the day belonged to the 'Master.'

Shots of the highest class flowed soon, and Joseph bore the brunt - three fours in a

row and a later six down the ground to bring his half-century in 40 balls.

A tired-looking Gill departed when a slog sweep off Roston Chase was caught in the deep by Jewel Andrew.

But a certain 37-year-old made of iron will and sublime skills soon reached his own mark in just 74 balls as the Greenfield Stadium erupted like a live volcano, spewing chants of Kohli and howling of appreciation. The Delhi man fetched his three-figure mark with a thundering six over mid-wicket off Motie - a neat leap from 94 to even hundred. But the holiday crowd was also fortunate to witness another class act - Kuldeep Yadav, who took four wickets (4/40) to stem the early run of Windies, and

Kohli completes 15,000 runs in ODI cricket

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Batting maestro Virat Kohli on Sunday completed 15,000 runs in One-Day International cricket, becoming only the second batter in history after the legendary Sachin Tendulkar to achieve the feat.

Kohli reached the landmark during the opening ODI between India and the West Indies here at the Greenfield International Stadium. He brought up his 15,000 runs with a majestic pull shot for a four off Alzarri Joseph towards midwicket, and celebrated with his arms aloft in air to acknowledge the crowd.

Kohli has been the second highest run-scorer in the ODI format ever since he went past former Sri Lanka captain Kumar Sangakkara in October 2025, who scored 14,243 runs in 50-overs cricket and remains the third highest-ever scorer.

At the fourth spot in the list is former Australia captain Ricky Ponting, who



Full-strength India begin Asiad campaign against Afghanistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nisshin

India will face an inexperienced Afghanistan in their Asian Games opener on Monday with the overwhelming favourites looking to quickly acclimatise to the unfamiliar conditions in Japan. India would not know what to expect from the surface at the Korogi Sports Park which also staged the women's competition won by Harmanpreet Kaur and Co. Though the women's event was a high-scoring affair, the men's games thus far have not seen big totals.

After the one off game against Japan in Sano on Tuesday when India were

pushed to the limit by the hosts on a turning track, the Shreyas Iyer-led side has not had much to do.

India have utilised the time exploring the sights and

sounds of Japan. The players reached Nagoya from Tokyo via the iconic bullet train and expectedly enjoyed the journey. Being in a non cricketing nation for the first time

has also been a refreshing experience for majority of the players. "It has been beautiful," Iyer told the BCCI website on way to Nagoya.

It is to be noted that India



Rizwan accused of non-cooperation in NCCIA probe

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Former Pakistan captain and wicketkeeper-batter Mohammad Rizwan has allegedly failed to cooperate with the National Cyber Crime Investigation Agency (NCCIA) in its ongoing probe involving him and fellow batter Imam-ul-Haq, according to a media report here.

The report in a leading Pakistan newspaper, quoting well-placed sources in the NCCIA, said Rizwan had not been responding to repeated requests from the agency to appear for a forensic examination of his mobile phone.

"We have contacted Rizwan several times and asked him to come and

meet us and be present when we carry out forensic analysis of his phone so that no data is wasted. But either he has not taken calls or told us to contact his lawyer," the newspaper quoted an NCCIA source as saying on Sunday.

The source said the agency had even offered to send a team to Rizwan's residence if he was unable to visit its office, but he had not responded.

"He is not cooperating in the inquiry which we want to complete as soon as possible as the Lahore High Court has also directed us to complete our inquiry quickly," the source said.

The NCCIA source also made it clear that the agency was not doing anything outside the parameters of the International Cricket Council (ICC) Anti-Corruption Code and had not contacted the ICC in the matter. "There are some suspicions which need to be cleared. Legally, at present, both players are not guilty of any wrongdoing and if we find no evidence they will be cleared as soon as possible," the source was quoted as saying. Rizwan and Imam, along with Salman Ali Agha, were asked to return home after second Test against England.



India made right calls after 2007 ODI World Cup: Mohammad Yousuf

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

The Indian cricket board making the right calls is the reason behind their national team's progress since the 2007 ODI World Cup when compared to Pakistan, says former captain Mohammad Yousuf. Both India and Pakistan were eliminated in the group stage of the 2007 ODI World Cup in the Caribbean, and Yousuf said it was a decisive moment for two arch rivals, from which former has edged ahead.

"It was a decisive moment for both cricket boards, and I just feel that after that, the Indian board made the right calls, like appointing MS Dhoni, etc., while in contrast, in Pakistan, the wrong

calls were made, because of which Pakistan cricket is struggling now," Yousuf said on a YouTube podcast.

Yousuf said India are also reaping benefits of having players being nurtured by former captain and head coach Rahul Dravid.

"India's success also comes down to the way Rahul Dravid managed their junior cricket, and over the years, the work he put in identifying and grooming players has paid off for them now," he said.

"I think Virat (Kohli) is the best white-ball player of this era. Unfortunately, after 2019, we have not produced the sort of players you need to maintain dominance at the top level, the sort of players we had in the 80s or 90s,"



Yousuf said. The former Pakistan middle-order mainstay said that the current players do

not want to do the hard yards. "The unfortunate part is that I feel some of these current players don't want to

also put in the extra hours and hard work. I have been a batting coach with the Pakistan team, and I can tell

you at times felt these players didn't want to learn," he said. "Cricket is a sport where no matter how much you have played, you learn something new every day. The moment you think you know everything is when you start going downhill," Yousuf added. Yousuf, who has served as the national team's selector and batting coach, said Pakistan were still doing better when Sarfaraz Ahmed was their captain.

"I felt that Sarfaraz sacrificed a lot for his team because he wanted to see the team do well. I remember telling him, 'Why don't you bat higher?' and he said, 'For him, the team result mattered the most, not his position,'" he said.

Forgettable domestic return for Babar Azam

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Babar Azam endured a disappointing return to Pakistan's domestic first-class cricket, failing in both innings of an Abbottabad Presidents Cup match on Sunday in his first red-ball appearance at this level in more than six years.

Babar was dismissed for four on the fourth and final day, trapped leg before wicket by Pakistan teammate Faheem Ashraf while playing for Oil and Gas Development Company Limited (OGDCL) against Khan Research Laboratories (KRL). The former Pakistan captain had also failed in the first innings, scoring 12 before being caught at short mid-wicket off a short-pitched delivery from pacer Arshad Iqbal.

Babar's twin failures triggered sharp reactions on social media, with critics questioning his form and approach while his supporters defended the star

batter.

There had been considerable anticipation surrounding Babar's first appearance in a domestic first-class match since December 2019, with a decent crowd turning up at the picturesque Abbottabad ground to watch him bat.

However, they were left disappointed on both occasions.

In contrast, young Pakistan batter Abdullah Fazal, who was sent home from the West Indies tour in August because of a back spasm, struck a brilliant triple century for State Bank in Islamabad on Saturday.

The selectors did not pick Babar and several other senior players for the Asian Games cricket event in Japan.

Pakistan's next international assignment is a three-match T20 series against Sri Lanka at home next month, followed by a two-Test home series against the same opposition in November.



Asian Games: India win 2 silver and 3 bronze in athletics, wait for gold continues

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ Nagoya

Long jumper Ancy Sojan and high jumper Sarvesh Kushare raised hopes of India's first athletics gold in the ongoing Asian Games before settling for a silver each to lead the country's five-medal haul on a productive Sunday.

Decathlete Tajaswin Shankar, 3000m steeplechaser Parul Chaudhary and 200m runner Harita Bhadra clinched a bronze each to take India's total athletics medal count to 13 (6 silver, 7 bronze) at the Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium that was lashed by incessant drizzle for the second day running.

The 75-member strong

Indian athletics team is still searching for a gold with two days left in the competition.

The 25-year-old Ancy was on the verge of winning her maiden Asian Games gold with her fifth round effort of 6.53m but China's Huang Yingying produced a late 6.55m effort in the final jump of the competition to snatch the gold.

"Yeah, actually little bit heartbreak for the 2cm I missed. Till the very last moment I was in gold position. But fate is different. Today is not my day," a disappointed Ancy, who holds the national record of 6.88m, said later. "But I am happy for one thing. This is my second Asian

Games and I am a medallist in both. This is not the end for me. I will come back stronger."

Another Indian in the fray, Shaili Singh, was in the bronze medal position with her fifth round jump of 6.42m but she was pushed to fourth after the Chinese gold winner's final attempt. It was a protracted contest in the men's high jump between Kushare and eventual gold winner Chaohsuan Fu of Chinese Taipei. The Indian was in the gold medal position till the bar was raised to 2.22m. Kushare needed just one jump to clear the bar till the 2.22m while Fu could clear the same height in his second attempt. But the scenario changed when the



bar was raised to 2.25m.

Kushare, who holds the national record of 2.31m, needed a second jump to clear the height while the Chinese Taipei athlete did it in

his first try.

Both went for 2.28m but failed in three attempts. The gold medal was awarded to Fu on countback, with Kushare settling for silver,

with the same 2.25m height being credited to both.

"This medal means a lot to me, because such Games come after four years. You never know what happens in four years," said Kushare who had finished fourth in the last edition in China.

"I also won silver in the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, so I wanted to win gold but couldn't do it. But I am satisfied that the medal has come. It will give me confidence going ahead."

Decathlete Tejaswin Shankar added another bronze to add to the silver he had won in the last edition. He accumulated 7934 points in the gruelling 10-event discipline competed over two

days. Japan's Maruyama took the gold with 8123 points while China's Chen X aggregated 8012 points to win the silver. "It was more of losing a silver than winning a bronze," Tajaswin, who holds the national record of 8057 points, said.

"I did four decathlons this year. I've been going on since 30th of January but not blaming anybody. I had to do it and I needed to get that performance."

Parul clocked 9 minute 8.67 seconds to break her own national record of 9:12.46, but that was enough to win a bronze. She had won a silver in the previous edition in the same event.

Bahrain's Winfred Yavi

grabbed gold, finishing ahead of Kazakhstan's Norah Jeruto Tanui (9:06.82).

Earlier, Harita Bhadra clinched the bronze medal in the women's 200m, clocking 23.20 seconds in the final.

Bhadra finished third, just ahead of Japan's Ido Abigeirufuka, who clocked 23.21 seconds. Singapore's Shanti Pereira won the gold with a season-best 22.78 seconds, while China's Chen Yujie took the silver in 22.93 seconds. The other Indian in the final, Unnathi Aiyappa Bolland, finished sixth with a timing of 23.48 seconds.

Bhadra's participation in Asian Games was cleared in last minute and she turned it into an opportunity. (PTI)